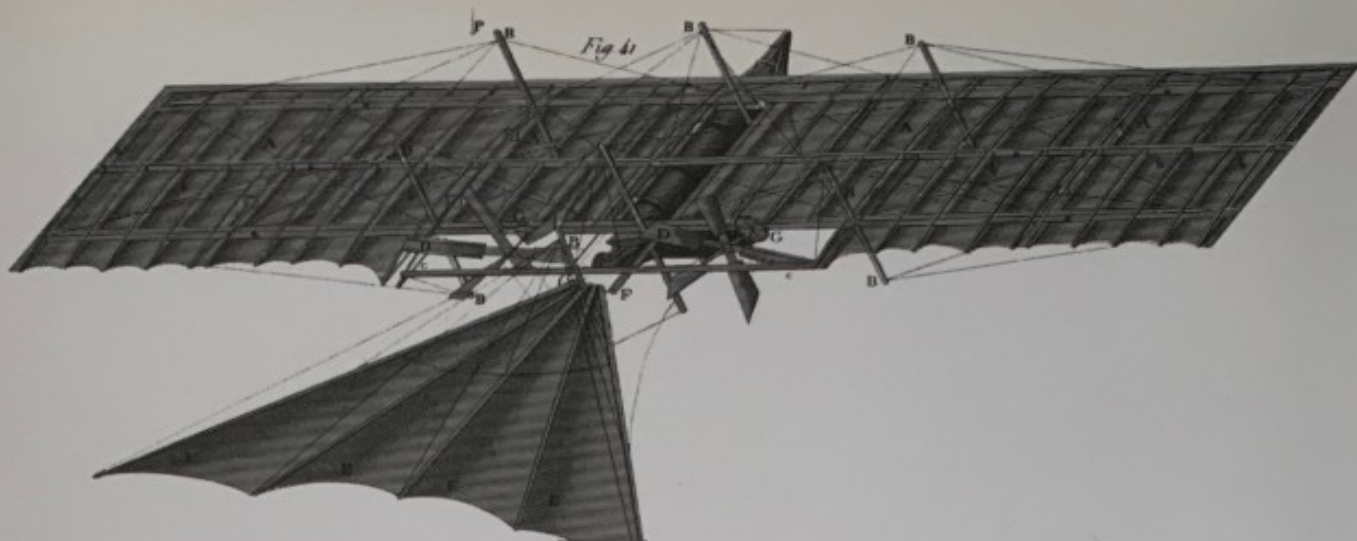
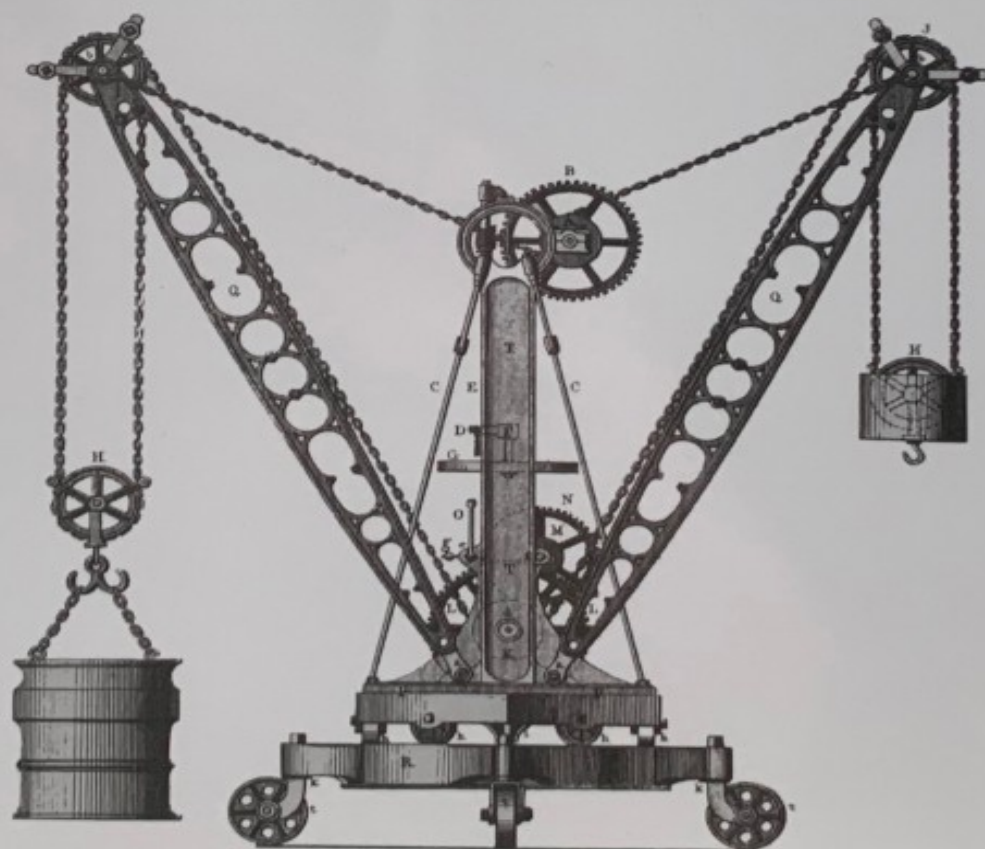


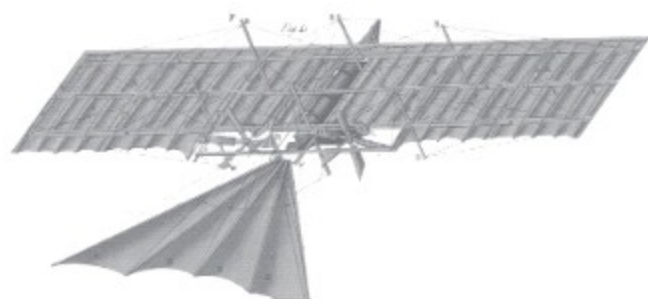


DESIGNING MIRACLES

Creating the Illusion of Impossibility

Darwin Ortiz



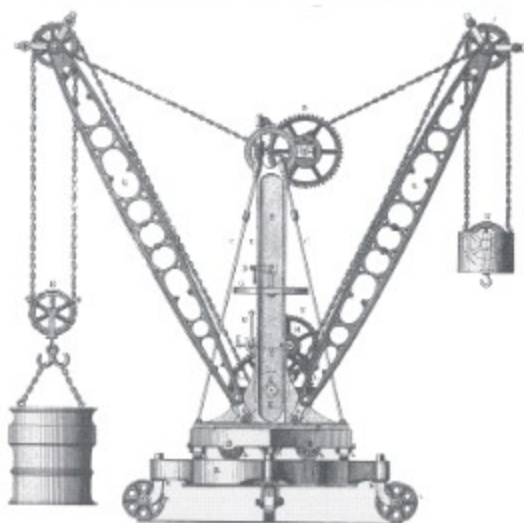


DESIGNING MIRACLES

Creating the Illusion of Impossibility

by

Darwin Ortiz



Dedicated

to Derek Dingle, Gene Maze, and Michael Skinner

DESIGNING MIRACLES

**Creating the Illusion of
Impossibility**

**by
Darwin Ortiz**

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“This detail, I believe, makes the trick appear more impossible (the main goal of our art).”

Juan Tamariz, **Mnemonics**

“If the magic isn’t baffling, it isn't magic,”

TA, Waters **Foreword**

by Whit Haydn

Designing Miracles. That is what we try to do whenever we create, adapt, or fix a magic effect. Just as there are certain artistic principles that underlie the arcs of music or painting, there are elements of design that apply to magic as well. Knowing these principles, and understanding them, is what enables us to improve our art.

Here we have an outstanding new book by one of the modern day-masters of card magic, Darwin Ortiz.

Darwin's breadth of knowledge and vast performing experience make any work of his important, but this book focuses on the theory of magic as it applies to the construction of a magic effect, something that is *essential* to both creating and improving our magic.

Where Darwin's previous work on theory, **Strong Magic** dealt with the principles of *performance* that help create memorable and exciting magic, this book deals with the principles *at design* that go into the construction of a magic effect—what are the basic principles that make magic seem impossible and unassailable from the spectators point of view. Books like these are even more rare and important today than ever before.

Young magicians today, for the most part, absorb their knowledge of magic from DVDs and other video sources such as the Internet, rather than from books and manuscripts. The availability of great magic performances on video, and the teaching of magic by video, presents a lot of advantages. It allows a tremendous and unprecedented access to the best magicians and their work, a kind of access that in prior times was only available to a handful of the most dedicated. But, with this new mode of learning, often the more abstract concepts and theoretical underpinnings of magic are neglected.

In the great old books of magic, there are usually several chapters devoted to performance, acting, misdirection, and theory—things that are often neglected in video. The great books on magic theory by Maskelyne and Devant, Fitzkee, Sharpe, Nelms, Wonder, Ascanio, Tamariz and others are not easily translatable into sound bites for video. Such topics can be rather dry for video, and they really require the sort of thought and attention

that best comes from the process of reading and thinking; and yet, without studying these things no magical education can be complete.

With many more students of the art learning on their own using these resources that would never before be available, mentorship and the patient process of teaching the important underlying principles of magic theory have been neglected.

But why do we need to understand and study theory? Can't we just learn from studying the effects of the masters and performing them? Doesn't the process of performing itself teach what works and what doesn't. Isn't that the very best teacher? Can we get where we want to be just by working on and improving our magic as we go? And what is theory anyway?

The problem with learning in performance is that we can discover what works and what doesn't, but we don't necessarily learn why and how. We constantly have to re-invent rather than learning from what has been done before. Without a way of evaluating one method or ruse over another, we are forced to try every method just to see what works. Progress will be interminably slow.

The “Theory of Magic” is not some nebulous philosophical musing. It is the attempt to organize and distill what we have learned from the practice and performance of magic. It is the attempt to abstract from the specific techniques and applications the general rules that seem to govern the success of our craft, and to analyze what it is that we as magicians—both as craftsmen and artists—actually do and try to do.

So far, there is no overall Theory of Magic. There is as yet no systematic or overarching framework within which we can work out the goals and principles of our craft. Each author on this subject has been forced to find ways to explain and express the various issues and concepts that he found to be important. We share little common language in our craft. Even essential words such as “effect” have no one, agreed upon meaning within our community. Generally, each author has tried to define his terms and express his concerns using his own experience and education as a guide.

The performers whose main career has been stage performance tend to look at magic in a slightly different way than those who have focused on close-up. Yet, there is no one “right way.” There are simply different vantage points and different ways of expressing how each author looks at the work the magician does.

Many writers are expert performers whose advice is always going to be insightful and helpful, even when they seem to disagree. There are also some well-known writers who are much better at theorizing than actually doing the work, and their theory can sometimes be misleading even when it seems to say nearly the same thing.

Theory has to work in practice, or it is simply wrong. When a person whose knowledge, experience and performing ability gives us special reason to pay attention sits down to write about theory, it is a significant event. Such is the case here.

Maskelyne and Devant, in **Our Magic**, gave us twenty-four “rules” of magic and explicated each one. These are very wise and useful guidelines for magic that still provoke discussion and provide insight into our craft more than 100 years after they were formulated. In this current work, Ortiz gives us another twenty-seven, which he calls “Darwin's Laws.” There are also very insightful and helpful rules of thumb that are well worth studying and keeping in mind. These “Laws” are explained and illustrated throughout the book, and codified at the end.

The most important part of this work, however, is not the rules, but the tools of design that Darwin gives us. This is quite extraordinary. Just as the architect needs T-squares, compasses, and other tools to design a building, we need tools to look at and examine the “structure” of our magic effects. The tools that Darwin gives us are multi-use and provide revealing ways of looking at magic effects and analyzing their strengths and weaknesses.

The analytical *tools* that are presented in this book are actually measures that can be applied to any trick or magic effect that help us to identify the strengths and weaknesses of the trick with regard to how it is perceived by the spectators and whether or not it convinces them of “impossibility.”

First of all, Darwin assumes that our spectators are intelligent and approach a magic effect as it is happening with an engaged “common sense” that is very capable of assessing out—if not the cause—the existence of some kind of cause other than magic. It is not enough to deceive our spectators as to the cause of the effect; they must be convinced that there is *no* possible cause for the effect in order to create the experience of magic.

In order to do this, we have to always be aware of the difference between the Inner and Outer realities—between what is actually happening, and what the spectator perceives as happening. We need to know what the spectator is thinking and how to control that thinking at all times, and at each step in the procedure. In order to do that we need to understand how the “common sense” mind processes causal links—something it does effortlessly and relentlessly. How do we keep the Inner and Outer realities from converging?

By studying the way the mind deals with causality, how it searches for causes when it is “stumped,” we can discover the four elements or “common paths” that are most often relied upon to search for the source or cause of

an event. How close in time was the actual cause to the perceived effect? How much contact with the actual cause did the perceived effect have?

These tools of common sense can be frustrated by seeking out various methods for preventing the spectator from making causal connections between what he *sees* the magician actually *do* and the *effect* of the illusion. The tools for this include creating both spatial and temporal displacements between the actual cause and the perceived effect, as well as conceptual and framing techniques.

This book is an ingeniously new way to look at old problems. The principles are sound and useful, and *very* exciting. Darwin lays out a new way of looking at how the mind is fooled, and gives the tools and methods for both analyzing the strengths and weaknesses of an effect, as well as for improving and “fixing” those effects that need it, as well as to evaluate different approaches to the same problem.

I have found this book to be both exciting and helpful. I know that you will look at magic effects differently after you have finished, and will find your thinking about magic stimulated and challenged.

—Whit Haydn

Introduction

Magic as Craft

“Craft is the sum total of all means used to draw the audience into deep involvement, to hold that involvement, and ultimately to reward it with a moving and meaningful experience.”

Robert McKee, **Story**

My friend Pat Cook is a playwright, songwriter, musician, former actor, and amateur magician. This means that he has spent time around many different kinds of creative people. He once mentioned to me that, of all these groups, magicians are the only ones who constantly prattle on about “art”. According to Pat, other creative people spend their time talking about *craft* rather than art. Perhaps they realize that art is a subjective and solitary pursuit, little helped by endless discussions. Craft, by contrast, is something that they can help each other learn and understand.

They probably also realize that pursuit of art is futile without first achieving a complete mastery of craft. Every endeavor that aspires to being an art form is also a craft. You can't create art without first mastering the tools and techniques of your art form, which is exactly what craft is all about.

It's only in magic that many seem to feel that *talking* about art can substitute for *mastering* craft. This may partially reflect an inferiority complex stemming from the realization that no one except magicians considers magic an art form. It's also, I think, an excuse for laziness. Talking about art is easy; working at your craft is hard. My own feeling is that, if we can improve the generally low level of craft in magic, the art aspect will take care of itself.

This raises the question: where does the craft lie in magic? On the rare occasions when magicians address this question, they usually focus on acting skills or storytelling skills. But acting and storytelling are art forms in their own right. Magic may borrow from these areas but, if it doesn't have anything to offer that's *unique* to magic, it's hard to justify its existence, let alone its claims to art.

Filmmakers don't talk about the craft of filmmaking by telling you to go study live theater. Indeed, the best proof that film is an art form is that it has its own elements of craft distinct from the legitimate stage or any other art form. The essence of the craft of filmmaking is not the elements that film has in common with live theater, but the elements that set it apart from live theater. We can thus frame my original question slightly differently, what craft elements does magic have distinct from other forms of theater?

After many years of professional performing and a great deal of time spent thinking about this question, here is my best answer. The craft in magic consists of three elements. The first is the technology of magical methods. Magic is more technology-dependent than most art forms because the first and fundamental step in magic is to *deceive*. As magicians we must achieve a variety of things unsuspected. Technology in the form of sleights, gaffs, and psychological ploys offers us the means to do so. These are the building blocks of a magic effect. When new methods are created, we have new opportunities for doing things secretly, which is always the first step in creating a magical experience for the audience.

At the other end of the process is the second element: showmanship. This consists of the spectrum of techniques for investing a performance with dramatic, emotional, and magical power, (It is here that we find considerable overlap with theater and other narrative arts.) My belief that this is a craft that can be taught and learned resulted in my book **Strong Magic**.

In between these two lies the third and most under-explored element of magical craft: effect design. If sleights, gaffs, and other secret methods are the building blocks, you still need a blueprint to build from. If showmanship is about presentation, you first need something worth presenting. That *something* is certainly not sleights and gaffs. It's something

that utilizes sleights and gaffs but is more than the sum of those parts. This is the realm of effect design. It stands squarely in the center of the magical process, between the raw material of double lifts and retention vanishes and the final product of a moving and memorable performance. This book is about this critical central link.

Designing the Effect

“At the very core of the study of presentation is the effect. Never lose sight of it.”

Roberto Giobbi, Card College, Volume 2

Until now, almost all discussions about how to make magic more deceptive have actually dealt with how to make *sleights* more deceptive (mis-

direction, naturalness, simulation, etc.). This is certainly valuable. If the sleights aren't deceptive, the effect won't be.

The inverse, however, is not necessarily true. Even when the sleights are deceptive, the effect may not be. A spectator may be fooled by every sleight, yet see through the deception. He may realize how the effect was done, not by catching the moves, but just by figuring it out.

An unfortunate aspect of equating deceptive effect with deceptive sleights is that the most you can ever hope to achieve with a sleight is deception. Magic is not simply about deceiving. It's about creating an illusion, the illusion of impossibility. To focus solely on making the sleights deceptive is to fixate on the level of deception and hamper your chances of moving up to the level of illusion.

Creating an illusion of impossibility depends on audience psychology. Magic literature is filled with references to “the psychology of deception.” The usual assumption, however, is that the psychology of deception begins with the performance (misdirection) or, at most, with creating the presentation that will be used in performance. I believe that there is a

psychology of deception involving decisions made long before you start the performance or fashion the presentation. If certain psychological principles are not built into the very design of the effect, their absence will be difficult to compensate for in performance or presentation.

Understanding effect design is valuable as a critical aid, a diagnostic aid, a remedial aid, and a creative aid. It can help you choose wisely when trying to decide among different versions of the same trick. It can help you identify the problem when a particular trick isn't playing well. It can then help you find solutions to the problem. Finally, it can help you create strong original magic effects yourself. In short, it can provide you with a road map toward your goal of creating miracles. Let's start mapping out the territory.

Chapter One: Picking the Best Method

A quick survey of Internet magic boards will show that a large percentage of posters are seeking the “best” version of a particular trick, (“Is the Balducci levitation better than Zero Gravity?” “Can somebody recommend the best Card to Wallet?” “Which torn and restored card is better: The Reformation, The Restoration, The Reparation, The Renovation, or the Regurgitation?”)

We live at a time when there is a glut of methods, versions, and “improvements” for every magic plot. Consequently, it's more important than ever to ask, not just which version is best, but *how do we determine* which version is best? (Life is simply too short to audience-test every possibility) Before offering my own answer, I want to consider some of the most commonly used criteria.

Cleverness

“A weak trick remains a weak trick no matter how brilliant or devious the method.”

Ken Weber, Maximum Entertainment

I remember once performing an effect for a prominent amateur magician. I didn't expect the trick to fool him and it didn't. When I finished, he said

enthusiastically, “That's a really clever method.”

“And it's a really strong effect for lay people” I responded.

“But it's a really clever method,” he said admiringly.

“And it's a really strong effect” I said.

“But it's a *really* clever method” he retorted.

Admittedly, this is not Oscar Wilde/G.B. Shaw caliber repartee. But that's the point. The impasse in the conversation reflected the chasm between his perspective on magic and mine. For many magicians, methods develop a seductive quality. The method justifies the effect rather than the other way around. I've been to more than one magic lecture where the audience initially responded apathetically to a certain effect but fell in love with it when they learned the ingenious method.

Magicians love cleverness. That's why magic books are filled with diabolically clever effects that are worthless for entertaining lay audiences. Even something as appealing as cleverness is only a means, not an end in itself. The cleverest method is not always the best method. I recommend a utilitarian, rather than aesthetic, view of methodology. *The only thing that matters about a method is how impossible an effect it produces, not how good it makes you feel inside.*

Creativity

Here is another seductive method pitfall Creativity is rightly valued in magic (perhaps because it's so rare). Yet it too is only a means, not an end. What the cleverness crowd and the creativity crowd have in common is that they both admire method divorced from effect. Methods need to be judged by their *results*, not by aesthetic qualities such as cleverness or creativity. All that matters is what the audience perceives.

Another field that values creativity is advertising. Yet, ad agencies never forget that their job is not to win Cleo awards but to sell dog food. Consequently, they have a saying in advertising: *It's not creative unless it*

set. In magic we should take the attitude: It's not creative unless it produces strong effect.

If you aim to be the most effective magician you can be, I recommend that you avoid emotional attachments to methods. If a doctor falls in love with surgery, he may perform an operation when drugs or physical therapy might have worked better. The surgery might be fun for the doctor, but what about the patient?

Difficulty

Emperor Joseph II: Exactly. Very well put. Too many notes.

Mozart: I don't understand. There are just as many notes, Majesty, as art required. Neither more nor less.

Emperor Joseph II: My dear, young man, don't take it too hard. Your work is ingenious. It's quality work. And there are simply too many notes, that's all. Cut a few and it will be perfect.

Amadeus

Various legendary names in magic have been quoted to the effect that the way to improve a trick is to eliminate sleights. This is as ridiculous as a chef saying that the way to improve a recipe is to eliminate ingredients.

Of course, it would be equally ridiculous to claim that the way to improve a recipe is to *add* ingredients. The key to a good recipe is finding the right combination of ingredients. In the same way, the key to designing a strong effect is finding the right combination of sleights and/or gaffs and/or subtleties. In one case, that may be many sleights, in another it may be few or none. In one case it may be difficult sleights, in another it may be easy sleights.

Of course, if you can eliminate a sleight without impacting the effect in any way, you should certainly do it. In practice, this is almost never possible. In a magic effect, removing something almost always requires substituting something in its place. What you substitute may be more

handling or simply a less convincing effect. The notion that you can remove a sleight and everything else remains the same is a fantasy.

The easier-is-better school often argues that easy methods allow the performer to concentrate on presentation. This claim is undercut by the fact that so many of its proponents are such lousy showmen. They'll stumble and fumble their way through a self-working trick so badly that you tremble to think what it might look like if they weren't "concentrating on presentation." I suspect that's because this argument is often an excuse for laziness. A lazy magician is no more likely to work on his presentation than on his technical skills.

Your ability to concentrate on presentation is a function of your *mastery* of the method, not the *difficulty* of the method. Of course, it takes more work to master a difficult routine. You shouldn't consider adding such a routine to your repertoire if you've not willing to do the work. Nevertheless, someone like Paul Gertner concentrates more on presentation while performing a technically demanding coin or Cups and Balls routine than most magicians do when performing self-working tricks.

As misguided as it is to say that the easier version is always better, this is only the flip side of the equally misguided view that the harder version is always better. This attitude is found among many card technicians, particularly young magicians in love with their own technical skills. I think of these two camps as the "old fart school" and the "young wise-ass school." (I apologize to the many young and old who don't fit these stereotypes.)

Either way, judging the merits of a routine by how many sleights it contains is like judging the merits of a sculpture by how much it weighs.

Efficiency

"In magic, the law of maximum effect is more important than that of minimum effort."

Arturo de Ascanio,
The Structural Conception of Magic

Some will tell you that the best effects are those that achieve the most impact for the least effort. This is really a twist on the easier-is-better philosophy. At least it's a step in the right direction in that it also factors in audience impact. This philosophy underlies such magic clichés as, “I've streamlined the handling” (code for “I've made the trick easier”) or, “That's a very efficient method,” “Streamlined” and “efficient” are engineering terms. However, magic is not engineering. Energy efficiency is not the goal.

Magic is a craft. Most magicians even pay lip service to the notion that it's an art. In art and in craft you don't measure success in terms of input vs. output. Art and craft both require you to strive for perfection. All that matters is the quality of the output, regardless of how much input it takes to achieve it.

Of course, no sensible person would deny that if you can make a trick easier without weakening the impact, that's a good thing. If, as sometimes happens, you can make it easier and at the same time make it stronger, that's a great thing. But those are the easy cases. Let's turn to a tougher example.

If you're one of the many magicians who affirm that magic is an art, let me test your sincerity. Think of any item in your repertoire. If you could make this trick 10% stronger, but doing so would make it 50% harder, would you be willing to do the extra work? An engineer would answer no—highly inefficient! An artist would answer yes. Even a true craftsman with no pretensions to art would answer yes.

Admittedly, I'm espousing a highly idealistic position, and idealism has its limits. If I thought of an improvement that would make a trick 5% stronger but 300% harder, I would probably say, “The old way is good enough.” Nevertheless, this theoretical example shows the artistic shortcomings of applying an engineering model to magic.

The “efficiency” approach tends to produce two problems. First, in practice, pursuing the most effect for the least effort often degenerates into pursuing the least effort, period. Better I think to pursue the most effect,

period. If occasionally you can achieve that with little effort, consider it a lucky break.

Second, so-called efficient methods tend to be *direct* methods. In my experience and observation, the phrase “direct method” is a synonym for “obvious method.” You may find this a surprising notion, so I hope you'll give me a chance to persuade you later in Chapter Seven.

For now, I'll offer one last thought for the efficiency experts to consider. Efficiency can only be measured in terms of a goal. Magicians tend to think that the goal is to move the card from here to there. In fact, that's only half the goal. The more important half should be to create a false impression—and ultimately, a certain experience—in the spectator's mind. The proper rest of an effect's design is not efficiency but *effectiveness*. How effective is it in creating an illusion of impossibility? You can't measure that with a simple input/output equation.

Whether It fooled You

“Egocentrism is a feature of preoperational thought in which the child is not able to distinguish between his own perspective and someone else's perspective.”

J. Messina, Ph.D., Constance M. Messina, Ph.D.,
Cognitive Development in Early Childhood

I'm continually amazed by how much importance magicians give to whether a trick fooled them. Most magicians think that the greatest possible praise for a trick is, “It totally fooled me.” My response is, “Who cares?” It's nothing personal. I'm just as likely to think, “Who cares?” when *I'm* fooled by a trick.

If you seriously believe that whether a trick fooled you should be a major factor in deciding whether to perform it, it can only mean one of two things. First, you're mainly interested in performing for people who think like you do, which is to say, other magicians. In that case, do yourself a favor and list this book on eBay as soon as possible.

Alternatively, it may mean that you believe that laypeople think like you do. There are two reasons why this isn't so. First, you have technical

knowledge that they don't have. The old version of a trick no longer fools you because, somewhere along the line, you learned how it's done. The new version fools you because you haven't yet learned how it's done. The layperson has never learned how *either* version is done,

Second, the way magicians try to figure out tricks is completely different from the way laypeople do. When you watch a trick, you're continually rummaging through your mental file of technical magic knowledge, looking for a match. If you don't find one, you're fooled. Laypeople don't have a mental file of technical magic knowledge. They're forced to rely on common sense. Common sense is that thing that progressively atrophied inside you and me as we learned more and more about magic. Common sense is, however, an excellent way of figuring out how many tricks are done, including many that fool magicians. When a magician describes an effect to me and concludes by saying, "It fooled me completely," I sometimes respond by asking, "Yes, but would it fool a layman?" They usually think I'm joking. I'm not.

Novelty

There is an old saying, "Better the devil you know than the devil you don't know" Magicians, however, always choose the devil they don't know. Novelty trumps quality every time.

Often a new effect's only virtue is that it doesn't use the standard method for achieving that type of effect. (Often this is because it uses a far inferior method.) The great selling point in the ads will be, "no thread" or "no double-faced cards" or whatever the standard method for this particular effect may be. Since magicians are familiar with the standard method, this strikes them as a great breakthrough.

Laypeople, of course, don't know the standard method and are therefore less likely to be impressed. In many cases, the only way to make a lay audience appreciate this new version would be to first explain the standard method and then perform the new version. The audience would then think, "Isn't it clever how he somehow did the trick without resorting to the method that we didn't know existed until he taught it to us a moment ago."

One reason why magicians always think the newer method is better is that it's more likely to fool them. As we just discussed, that's the only thing in life that matters to most magicians. Another reason is that it's also more likely to fool the other magicians who may form their primary audience. (See eBay comment above.) A third is that many magicians are hobbyists who only want to entertain themselves. They get bored with the old version and need a new one to amuse them. Fortunately, the fact that you're reading this book means that you've probably not in that category.

There is, however, a more insidious appeal to new methods that we all have to guard against. Every trick has a secret method and every secret method has a vulnerability. As we perform a trick over time we become intimately familiar with its vulnerable point. We're acutely aware that the cards can't be examined at the end, or that the deck can't be shuffled at the beginning, or that we can't show our hand empty before reaching in the pocket.

In classic paranoid fashion, we begin to obsess over this vulnerability and project our own feelings on the audience. We're consumed with the fear that the spectator will want to shuffle the deck, examine the cards, or ask to see what's in our hand. Along comes a version that uses a shuffled deck or ordinary cards or no palming. It seems to promise salvation. You can be sure, however, that the new version carries its own vulnerability. In the end, it may prove a worse one. Just remember, *everything in magic involves a trade-off*. Before embracing the new devil, make sure the trade-off is worth it.

The Trick with No Method

There is a certain type of magician who is perpetually searching for what he thinks of as “the perfect method.” In fact, what he really wants is an effect that requires no method at all. It just happens.

Magic dealers encourage this mindset by running ads that list all the methods that a particular trick doesn't use: “no double-facers, no rough and smooth, no double-ended cards, no split-face cards.” All of these are fine methods that can be used to create miracles. So what's the point of stressing

that the trick doesn't use them? I believe it's to subtly suggest that the trick happens by real magic. By eliminating every method the reader can think of, these ads imply that here is a version that doesn't require a method. It just happens. Of course, it does require a method—often one inferior to all the ones that the ad ruled out.

No magician would ever admit even to himself that he is searching for an effect that happens by real magic. But his behavior betrays him. The magician reads about a floating bill effect. It sounds very magical, so he buys it. He is disappointed to find that the trick requires a thread to make the bill float. After all, you can get caught using a thread if you don't practice. He then sees an ad for another floating bill effect. This one says,

“No threads.” He rushes off his check only to discover that this method requires magnets. Suppose a spectator catches him palming the magnet? That won't do at all. Fortunately, he soon spies an ad for another version that promises, “No threads or magnets.” But when he buys this one he finds that it makes secret use of scotch tape. He starts to get discouraged until the next magic magazine arrives carrying an ad for a floating bill that requires, “No threads, magnets, or scotch tape” Surely, this must be the version he is seeking; the one that entails no method at all; the one where the bill just really floats.

Needless to say, such magicians never find their ideal. But, credit card in hand, they continue pursuing their dream. In the process, they make the dreams of many magic dealers come true.

I'm not really worried that you fall into this category. You wouldn't be reading this hook if you did. I felt, however, that I should mention it for the sake of completeness. If nothing else, it may help you understand the behavior of those odd magicians who are forever buying but never performing. These are the ones who continually pester you about this type of gaffed wallet or that Torn and Restored Card effect, all under the guise of “research.” A couple of years later, they're no closer to doing the effect. They're still busy “researching.”

“It Doesn't Matter”

According to one school of thought, everything that makes a trick effective is added after the fact: misdirection, presentation, etc. This philosophy has produced clichés like, “A great magician can make a miracle out of anything,” and, “There are no bad tricks, only bad magicians.”

Compare this to other fields. Would an actor say, “I don't care whether the part is well written or whether the play is any good. My talent will make it work.” Would a stand-up comic say, “Who needs strong material? I'll just buy an old joke book. My delivery will make it funny.” On the contrary, actors will kill for the right part. The best comics sweat blood to develop strong material and usually find it an extremely slow process. Top film directors look for great scripts to direct. They don't say, “There are no bad scripts, only bad directors.” In fact, in the film industry they have the opposite saying: “If it ain't on the page, it ain't on the stage.” In other words, the script has to have the potential for greatness before even the best director can bring it out.

What's true of a film script is true of a magic effect. Admittedly, the effect itself only contains the *potential* for a great performance. The performer determines how much of that potential will ever be realized. But if the potential isn't there, even the greatest performer can't pull it out of thin air.

My own view is that the most successful performances of a magical effect succeed on three levels simultaneously: the *dramatic*, the *emotional*, and the *magical*. The *dramatic* level involves the use of various technical devices (surprise, suspense, pacing, tempo, progression, etc.) to ensure that what the audience sees registers in a powerful manner. The *emotional* level involves the use of presentations capable of reaching the viewer on a deeper level I explored both of these areas in Strong Magic. The *magical* impact, however, is limited by the nature and design of the magic effect itself. You need effective presentation to bring it out. But, in the end you're still limited by the effect's *magical potential*, and that's determined primarily by its design.

In the last couple of years this fact has been powerfully brought home to me by my experience with two effects of my own creation. The first

involves the fusion plot in which two cards are melded to create one double-faced card. Ilic second is a packet trick in which faces are printed on double-backed cards.

I published the original version of each of these effects in previous books. (*Bold Fusion* appeared in **Cardshark** and *Back Off* appeared in **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**.) I've since developed revamped versions of each. (*Ultimate Fusion* and *The New Back Off*, both found in **Scams Fantasies with Cards**.) Each of the new versions has been earning me at least *twice as much* audience reaction as the old ones. In each case, the only differences between the old and new version were *design* changes.

Whatever strengths or weaknesses I may have as a performer and showman, they're the *same* strengths or weaknesses in each performance. Additionally, the presentations I used for the old versions of these two effects are identical almost word for word, with the ones I'm using for the new versions. Finally, of course, the effect (in the sense of how someone would describe the trick in words) is identical in both versions. The *only* variable in each case is the design of the effect.

All of this points to one conclusion: the material itself *matters*. If you want to perform miracles, start with strong material. Those who spend their lives pursuing the perfect miracle are kidding themselves. But those who think that they can make *any* trick into a miracle through presentation are also can in themselves the old phrase “polishing a turd” comes to mind.) It's better to have a wonderful presentation for an amazing effect than a wonderful presentation for a weak effect.

Design

In volume two of his **Expert Coin Magic... Made Easy!** DVD series, David Roth teaches his handling of the visual retention coin vanish, (This is a method of pretending to place a coin in one hand while actually retaining it in the other,) In Roth's hands this is one of the most amazing visual illusions you'll ever see. Any observer would be willing to bet at least one gonad that the coin is really in the hand. Yet, after demonstrating this uncannily convincing sleight. David observes: “But, remember, as in all coin vanishes, no matter how well you do this move—even if you do it

perfectly—once you open your left hand to show that the coin is gone, the spectators will look at the other hand.” He goes on to say that even if you really did put the coin in your left hand and then vanished it by some other means, “When you open your hand, they will look at the other hand.”

He then explains, “This is where routining is most important. It's the routining that will keep spectators from suspecting the other hand.” Routining is a term that magicians use to mean a variety of things. In this case, I believe that what David is calling routining is what I call *design*.

The Roth example demonstrates that perfect technique is not enough to create an enduring magical mystery. Similarly, misdirection is not enough, and even presentation is not enough. It's not a failure of technique, misdirection, or presentation that leads people to look at the other hand. It's simply that *it just makes sense*. If the coin isn't in one hand, it's probably in the other. It's this pesky common sense that often allows lay people to figure out what you thought was a perfect illusion. It's precisely this common sense that good design can defeat and even turn to your advantage,

To an extent, strong misdirection can compensate for poor technique and perfect technique can compensate for weak misdirection. Neither one, however, can compensate for poor design. Few magicians understand this. When a magician has problems putting over a poorly designed effect, some other magician will invariably advise him to work on his misdirection (if he is a misdirection fanatic) or to practice more (if he is a technique fanatic). Few will suggest that he tear the trick apart and start again from scratch—Yet that may be just what's needed.

I suggest that you consider selecting material based on the soundness of design in terms of the psychology of deception. When an effect's design is solid, you can add presentation, technique, and misdirection knowing that you're building on a strong foundation. That's what this book is about: demanding how the psychology of deception applies to the *design* of magic effects.

Chapter Two: The Magical Experience

The Magical Experience

“Astonishment gives pleasure; evidence of this is the fact that everyone exaggerates when passing on news, on the assumption that they are giving pleasure.”

Aristotle, **Poetics**

Some magicians see magic as strictly a vehicle for comedy or for an emotionally moving story. Such performers sometimes consider the magic element, not only secondary, but almost a nuisance. I've heard such performers denigrate a spectator who points out that he wasn't fooled. In their eyes, this is someone who just doesn't “get it,” someone who insists on viewing the performance as a “puzzle.”

There is no denying that there are tricks that are not very amazing yet are highly entertaining in other ways. Still, a spectator watching a magician has a right to expect to see apparent impossibilities. Furthermore, I believe that whatever other kind of entertainment value you wish to wring from an effect will only be enhanced if the effect is also truly amazing, it's this aspect of a magic effect that I term its mystery value.

Mystery value is what sets magic apart from all other art forms or forms of entertainment. This book is entirely about maximizing mystery value—not because I think that it's the only important element in magic, but because I think that it is important enough to merit in-depth treatment.

All of my writings are based on the conviction that magic can give an audience an emotional experience they simply can't get from any other art or form of entertainment—what Juan Tamariz has aptly titled *the magical experience*. Further, it's my conviction that, even more than comedy or any other form of amusement, it's our primary job as magicians to provide an audience with this experience—because if we don't, no one else will.

Deception vs. Illusion

“I may be the master of illusion, but it turns out that you're the master of Deception.”

Kane the sorcerer,
Highlander: The Final Dimension

“For a ninja, trickery is his weapon, illusion a way of life.”

from the Chuck Norris classic,
The Octagon

A recent magic magazine column proclaimed that it's a magician's “job to fool the audience.” It seems like a reasonable statement. Horace Goldin once wrote a book called *It's Fun to be Fooled*. Ever since, that sentiment has been an article of faith among magicians.

Yet, in *Shattering Illusions*, Jamy Swiss challenges this premise, “was it fun to buy that new car only to discover it was a lemon?” he asks rhetorically. “Was it fun to declare fidelity in a marriage vow, only to be cuckolded? Was it fun to vote for your choice for the highest political office in the land, only to learn that he subverted the Constitution that he swore to uphold, or had to flee from office in order to escape Congressional subpoena?”

These examples are, of course, flawed. In each case, it's not so much the deception, but rather the *betrayal* that the deception concealed that would anger us. Suppose your wife tells you she has to work late. If you learn that she is really having an affair with her coworker you'll respond one way you learn that she is really meeting with a party planner to organize your surprise birthday party you're likely to respond another way. The deception is the same in both cases, but only the former involves betrayal.

Despite poor reasoning, however, Swiss does have the germ of a valid point. Being fooled is not, in itself, fun. Yet, although people don't necessarily enjoy being fooled, they do enjoy magic. The key to this paradox lies partly in the limitations of the word fooled. In reading an English translation of a Spanish magic book I ran across the phrase “illusionning the audience.” No doubt, this was simply a poor translation of what should have read, “fooling the audience.” But the phrase does highlight a problem. There is no English word for what good magic does.

Good magic doesn't just fool an audience. It creates an illusion, *the illusion of impossibility*.

That's why saying that it's a magician's job to fool the audience is as inadequate as saying that it's a painter's job to smear paint on a canvas or a novelist's job to type words on a page. A painter or novelist's job is to create a representation of reality (whether an objective or subjective reality)—to create an *illusion* of reality. A magician's job is to create the illusion of an impossible reality. Magic is not about deception; it's about illusion. The magician's *tool* is deception; his *goal* is illusion.

I remember reading a magician's observation that, “Most people don't like watching things they can't explain.” But magic is not about watching something you can't explain. It's about watching something inexplicable. If I feel that I'm seeing something I can't explain, it suggests that there is something wrong with me. If I feel that I'm seeing something inexplicable, it suggests that what I'm seeing is extraordinary. This is what people should feel when they watch magic: not that they're not smart enough, but that even someone ten times smarter would have no better chance of explaining it, because there is no explanation.

If you understand that, you're not likely to say things like, “You don't know where the coin is, do you, laddie?” That statement makes sense if magic is about deception. It makes no sense if magic is about illusion. If you're working to create the illusion that the coin has vanished, it's meaningless to talk about “where the coin is.” It isn't anywhere. That's what it means for something to vanish. If you don't know where the coin is and I do, I'm superior to you; I've fooled you. If the coin has vanished, I'm sharing an experience with you, the magical experience.

This doesn't mean that it's not important to deceive your audience. Every time you perform a sleight, you must deceive them as to what you really did. Every time you use a gaffed prop you must deceive the audience as to the item's true nature. In each of these cases, however, the spectator does not subjectively experience being fooled. He is not aware, either at the time or later, that he was deceived when you turned over the top card because you really turned over two or that he was deceived when he freely selected a card because you really forced it on him. All that he subjectively

experiences is the magical effect—the apparent impossibility—that these individual deceptions cumulatively produce. Fooling is an aspect of the method, not of the effect. If you do your job right, the lay spectator experiences only the effect, not the method. He doesn't experience being fooled; he experiences an impossibility.

It's revealing that, whenever a magician describes a magic performance that particularly impressed him, he almost always uses the word “fooled.” He'll say things like: “He fooled the hell out of me.” “I've never been so fooled in my life.” “His card-to-wallet fooled me completely.” Fancying himself knowledgeable about magic methods, the magician does experience being fooled when he sees something impossible. (And, oddly enough, he finds the experience pleasurable.) Since most magicians are incapable of distinguishing between their own reactions and those of laypeople, they assume that lay audiences also experience magic as a case of “being fooled.”

In fact, when a layperson describes a magic performance that particularly impressed him, he almost never uses the word “fooled.” He'll say things like: “That guy was amazing.” “The things he did were impossible.” “I have no idea how he got my card into his wallet.” You won't hear the word fooled, however, because the layperson didn't experience being fooled. He only experienced seeing something impossible.

Puzzle vs. Miracle

Magicians often talk about the difference between a puzzle and a magic effect. The cliché is that the difference lies in an entertaining presentation. In fact, a puzzle entertainingly presented is still only an entertaining puzzle. The real difference is that a puzzle merely deceives, while magic creates the illusion of impossibility. This point was beautifully expressed by Simon Aronson's observation that, “There is a world of difference between a spectator not knowing how somethings done versus his knowing that it can't be done.” Achieving the former produces a puzzle. Achieving the latter produces a magic effect.

There is even a physiological basis for distinguishing between puzzlement and astonishment. Body language experiments have shown that

people tend to respond to puzzlement by “closing their faces.” The eyebrows lower, The eyes narrow. The jaw tightens. But they respond to astonishment by “opening their faces.” The eyebrows rise. The eyes widen. The jaw drops. (See, for example, **The Nonverbal Dictionary** by David B. Givens.)

Magicians love to go on about how magic should produce a “sense of wonder.” In one Internet discussion. Whit Haydn asked: “What do you guys mean by this? What is the mind thinking about when it is in 'wonder?' We use this expression so much, and most of the time it means so little. What is going on in the head when there is 'wonder?'" This question provoked the same reaction that usually greets any particularly insightful observation in an Internet discussion. Everyone ignored it.

I've searched long and hard for a definition of wonder. The best one I have found for magic purposes came, not from a dictionary, but from psychologist Dr. Paul Ekman. He defines wonder as, “The feeling of being overwhelmed by something incomprehensible.” If it's not incomprehensible, it won't produce wonder, only puzzlement.

How do we achieve the former reaction instead of the latter? The first step is to realize that, while deception is necessary, it's not sufficient. It's possible to perform an effect in which *every individual element deceives the*

audience, yet which fails to create an illusion of impossibility. Whether individual deceptions add up to an all-encompassing illusion depends largely on design. I observed earlier that words and paint are only the *tools* that writers and painters use. Nevertheless, the words or colors have to be carefully chosen, skillfully combined, and properly composed if they're to achieve the desired illusion. Effective design means selecting, combining, and composing the micro-elements of an effect (sleights, gaffs, subtleties, misdirection) in such a way as to produce success on the macro level (the illusion of impossibility).

Most magicians tend to think that there are two elements to a magic trick: effect and method. The more enlightened recognize three elements: effect, method, and presentation. The underlying premise of this book is that there are *four* elements to strong magic: effect, method, presentation, and *design*.

In practice, they intertwine so thoroughly that it can be difficult to say where one ends and the other begins. But the longer I perform magic and the more experience I have in creating original effects, the more convinced I become that design should be viewed as a separate element.

I don't think that magicians generally have adequately recognized design as an element separate from method. The best proof of this is the almost complete absence in magic literature of discussions of the principles of sound effect design. (The shining exception is Juan Tamariz's groundbreaking book **The Magic Way**.) Ignoring design principles is, for example, why the results are so disappointing when a magician spins out version after version of a trick by simply combining methods mechanically.

For the rest of this book I'll explore the principles of effect design that, quite apart from the details of method, are the surest path to achieving strong magical impact. (I don't for a moment discount the importance of *presentation* in achieving strong magic. But I have, after all, already written a book on that subject.)

If you want to make the jump from puzzle to miracle, start by studying this wonderful passage from **The Card Magic of Le Paul**: “A puzzle may baffle by its cleverness or its intricacy, but its solution manifestly lies within the actions that have been shown. It does not suggest the operation of something outside of normal cause and effect.” Never forget this. A magic effect, to be worthy of the name, must lie *outside of normal cause and effect*.

Chapter Three: Causality

“For that onelie is woonderfull to the beholder, whereof he can conceive no cause...”

Walter Scot,
The Discoverie of Witchcraft

No Way

To create the illusion of impossibility we must first understand how the mind concludes that something is impossible. This raises what may be the single most important question in magic. Amazingly, it's one I've never heard a magician ask. *What leads a spectator to conclude that something is impossible?* The question matters because, ultimately, effect design is about how laypeople think. How laypeople think is the most important subject in magic.

I'm going to approach this question by an indirect route. Let's start with Arturo de Ascanio's brilliantly simple definition of a magic effect. The effect is *the difference between the initial condition and the final condition*. At the beginning of the trick the aces are in *four* piles. There is nothing amazing about that. At the end of the trick the aces are in *one* pile. In itself, there's nothing amazing about that either.

Suppose a spectator is watching a magician perform. He sees him deal the four aces in a row and place three cards on each. Then his cell phone rings and he has to leave the room to take the call. That spectator didn't see a magic effect. He saw only the *initial* condition. Suppose another spectator arrives late. He comes in as the performer shows that all four aces are in one pile. Everybody applauds. He thinks, "So what's the big deal?" He didn't see a magic effect either. He saw only the *final* condition. To experience a magic effect, the spectator would have to see the four-ace trick from beginning to end so that his mind could compare the difference between A) the initial condition (four aces separated) and B) the final condition (four aces together). The magic is in the *difference*.

It's like those before-and-after weight-loss ads. If you see only the photo of the fat guy or only the photo of the thin guy, it doesn't mean much. You have to see both so you can compare. It's only then that you can conclude, "Wow, that guy lost a lot of weight!"

This fact is at the core of the claim that *the magic happens in the spectator's mind*. It's the spectator's mind that compares A to B and concludes that the difference constitutes magic. What forces him to that conclusion is the lack of any causal link—even any *possibility* of a causal link—between A and B.

Any magician who performs strong magic has had laypeople tell him as much countless times. “There's *no way* those aces could have gotten under her hand.” “There's *no way* that card could have gotten into your wallet.” “There's *no way* you could have known what card I was thinking of.” Spectators may also communicate this message nonverbally. At the end of a strong trick, you will often see people shake their heads as if saying no. Sometimes the spectator will simply exclaim, “No way!” Those two words say it all. There is no *way*—literally, no *path*—leading from A to B. There is no *causal link*.

Thus, the magical experience is an intellectual process that produces an emotional impact. The moment your intellect concludes that there is no possible causal link between A and B, the trapdoor opens beneath you. Your mind goes into free fall. That free fall is the emotional experience of magic, the feeling of being overwhelmed by something incomprehensible. What your body feels when you plummet in a roller coaster your mind feels when you experience magic. Both come from the realization that you're no longer on firm ground. In the first case, this is literally true. In the second case, it's the firm ground of everything you thought you could believe about reality that has just disappeared. The coaster and the magician both allow you to experience something potentially scary in a safe environment.

Making Causal Connections

“If it were not for cause and effect we could not perceive anything as an event, *only unrelated perceptions. It is the condition of all experience.*”

Immanuel Kant,
Critique of Pure Reason

“Effect had been shown, so cause had to be somewhere around; it only remained to identify it.”

Cornell Woolrich, **Deadline at Dawn**

The psychologist Jean Piaget, who pioneered the study of the mental development of infants and young children, has concluded that the search

for causal connections is one of the perceptual patterns that automatically evolve as a child's mind develops. It's not learned. It's not culture-based. *The drive to organize experience in term of cause and effect is built into the human brain.* Causality is how humans make sense of reality.

We magicians refer to magic tricks as “effects.” In nature, cause and effect always go hand in hand. But not in magic. Magic is the presence of an *effect* with no *cause*. More precisely, it's an effect with no possible cause within nature. This forces the conclusion that the cause lies outside nature. The cause is *supernatural*, which is to say, magic.

This leads to a vital insight. *Magic can only be established by a process of elimination.* There is no way that you can directly apprehend that you're witnessing magic. You conclude that it's magic because there is no alternative. Therefore, the primary task in giving someone the experience of witnessing magic is to eliminate every other possible cause. There is simply no other way to establish that a given phenomenon is the result of magic. If it can't have been caused by anything else, it must be magic!

Causality, therefore, is the key to answering our earlier question: What leads a spectator to conclude that something is impossible? A spectator has the magical experience when he senses a suspension of the laws of cause and effect. To create magic, we must eliminate any possibility of a *causal link* between the *initial condition* and the *final condition*. (To relate this to our earlier discussion, we might say that if we disguise the cause, we achieve deception. If we eliminate any possibility of a cause, we achieve illusion.)

To eliminate any possibility of a causal link in the spectator's mind we need to understand how the mind searches for causality. If you analyze the way you yourself search for causes whenever you're stumped, I think you'll find that you rely on four elements:

Antecedence. Experience teaches that cause always *precedes* effect. If you want to know how your child got an upset stomach, you'll ask him what he ate before he got sick. You won't ask what he ate *after* he got sick.

Correlation. Experience teaches that *whenever an* effect is present, the cause must also be present. If a doctor is called to an outbreak of stomach problems among the patrons of a restaurant, he'll try to find out what they all ate in order to identify the one ingredient that was present in *every* case. This pattern may reveal the cause.

Temporal Proximity. (These next two are the real biggies. Closeness in time and place trip up magicians again and again.) When people see an effect, they expect that whatever caused it occurred shortly before. If you want to know how your child got an upset stomach, you'll ask what he ate *immediately* before he got sick, not what he ate two weeks ago.

Contiguity. Experience reaches that, in some sense, there must always be *contact* between cause and effect. If you want to figure out from whom your child caught a stomach virus, you look to the people he came *close* to, not to people in other parts of the world.

[I'm not suggesting these as sound philosophical or scientific principles, but as insights into how people think. Hume and Heisenberg notwithstanding, we all instinctively rely on these guidelines because, as one physicist put it “they remain valid at the level of human experience.”]

This analysis sheds light on why a move that deceives in one context fails in another. Audiences don't see moves—if they're well executed. They do, however, see the handling, actions, and gestures accompanying the moves. They see any correlations and proximities that such handling, actions, and gestures produce. In one context, these may suggest causal connections. In another context, they may not.

If you tell a magician that a certain effect is flawed because it provides clues to causal connections, he may respond, “Do you really think that laypeople give that much thought to a magic trick?” Well, actually, some do. But, more importantly, it may not *require* a lot of thought. If the clues to causality are there, people will connect the dots in a nanosecond. They'll do it without breaking a sweat. They'll do it without consciously trying and without even realizing how they did it. People make causal connections so well and so fast because they've had a lifetime of practice and because it

comes naturally. It's something they do every day and it's something their brains are programmed to do.

As magicians, we may need a lot of time, effort, and analysis to figure out why an effect fails to create the desired illusion. This does *not* mean that we're assuming that the spectators will exert the same amount of time, effort, and analysis to figure it out. It's simply that it can take us a *longtime* to understand how they can figure something out in such a *short* time. The lay spectator operates on instinct. By contrast, we magicians have to proceed *analytically* to reconstruct the process that went on *instinctively* in the spectator's mind and figure out how to derail it next time.

Remember also that the spectator doesn't have to *figure out how it's done* for an effect to fail as a magic illusion. Some effects just don't seem all that impossible. If it doesn't intuitively seem impossible, it won't have a strong impact even if the spectator has no idea how you did it. If he sniffs the merest whiff of causality, the spectator knows that it's not magic. If "its solution manifestly lies within the actions that have been shown," it's just a puzzle. And laypeople have no interest in puzzles, only in miracles "outside of normal cause and effect."

The four principles I've listed are amazingly reliable as indicators of causality. They're damnably difficult to avoid when trying to fashion a secret cause to achieve a magical effect. That's precisely why humankind has relied on these principles for determining causality since time immemorial. It's also why magicians are generally easier to fool than laypeople. Magicians rely on their technical knowledge of magic. Laypeople rely on their commonsense grasp of how cause and effect work. Magical techniques are far easier to disguise than are basic causal connections.

The Design Bonus

If we do succeed in achieving the formidable task of eliminating causal cues, it will pay huge dividends. Not least of which is that it largely solves one of the most intractable problems in magic: how to get the audience to stop analyzing and just enjoy the show.

Magicians talk about getting the audience to like you and taking a non-confrontational approach. These are valuable ideas. Ultimately, however, there is only one sure-fire way to get an audience to stop searching for explanations. Convince them that there *are* no explanations.

As Piaget's research shows, it's the normal, universal human reaction, when faced with an apparent violation of the laws of nature, to search for a rational cause. It's a reflex. (Anyone who sees an apparent violation of the laws of nature and doesn't wonder how it happened must be suffering a psychotic breakdown.) This isn't a bad thing from the magician's standpoint. He wants his audience to experience the impossible. This can only happen *if they contemplate how the effect could be done long enough to realize that it can't*.

Of course, this normal reaction must be distinguished from the desperate, near-obsessive search for *any explanation* that you'll on rare occasions encounter from a spectator. The latter typically stems either from a fragile ego that imagines it's being made to look stupid or from a pathological fear

of losing control. As long as we can explain something, we're in control. The irrational (which is what magic represents) involves a loss of control that some people find frightening.

In **The Magic Way** Juan Tamariz likens the magical experience to taking flight on the wings of fantasy. Some people, of course, are afraid of flying. The literal fear of flying, which is actually a fear of losing control, is closely analogous to some people's dislike of magic. Remember, not every one enjoys roller coaster rides. If someone doesn't like roller coasters—or magic—it's best not to try forcing them to ride. Let's concentrate instead on the other ninety-nine percent of the population.

The *normal* search for a rational explanation, however, is something you can't eliminate. But the quicker you can end the process, the quicker the spectator can enjoy the magical experience. The moment he recognizes the impossibility of the effect, and no sooner, will he stop seeking a cause. In this book we'll concern ourselves with establishing the impossibility of our magic effects as rapidly as possible. Like a good martial artist, we want to avoid a protracted struggle and force a quick submission.

With such an approach, it's possible after a couple of effects to get an audience to stop even *trying* to find explanations. But this is only because their previous attempts have convinced them of the futility of the effort (as well as of the pleasure of embracing the fantasy).

You'll sometimes hear spectators say as much: "I'm not even going to try to figure these things out; it's just hopeless," or, "I don't even want to know how." But you'll seldom hear someone say that before your first trick. It only happens when a spectator has seen enough amazing effects that, even before you start the next one, there is a presumption in his mind that no explanation exists.

In the following pages we'll dissect each of the four causality cues with the goal of obliterating the tracks leading from method to effect, leaving behind a pristine miracle and an audience ready to embrace that miracle.

Analytical Tools

Now that we understand how audiences seek causality and what convinces them that they've witnessed an effect without a cause (otherwise known as a miracle), it might seem an easy task to fashion miracles. It would be, if it weren't for the pesky little matter of method.

Fashioning strong effects requires a clear and constant awareness of the ever-present interplay between method and effect. This may sound simple

but in fact, many magicians have trouble thinking clearly on this point. To help you avoid the common pitfalls in this regard, I'm going to suggest an analytical tool.

Inner Reality vs. Outer Reality

"We as magicians must not forget the duality of our business. We live in two universes, one we see and one the audience sees."

Al Schneider, **The Theory of Magic**

Not long ago I heard a magician complaining about what he considered a deceptive magic advertisement. The ad copy stated, “Effect: A spectator freely selects a card.” It then went on to describe the rest of the trick. The magician's complaint was that he bought the effect only to discover that the card was not a free selection. It had to be forced. He didn't seem to realize that the *effect* of a force is that “a spectator freely selects a card.”

This incident highlights an amazing fact. Many magicians can't clearly distinguish between effect and method. On the one hand, there are those who don't understand the *connection* between the two. They fail to appreciate that changing one usually changes the other. On the other hand, there are those, like the magician above, who can't quite grasp the *distinction* between the two.

I've found it useful to think in terms, not only of effect and method, but also of the *inner reality* (which *you* see) and the *outer reality* (which *your audience* sees). It's like one of those science fiction stories about parallel dimensions. What happens in one affects the other, but they remain separate.

The terms “method” and “effect” are not enough because they refer to the totality of the trick. The split between the two realities starts long before any effect has occurred and long before you've completed the method. I suggest *inner reality* and *outer reality* as names for the situation at any given moment in the trick. Giving these concepts names makes it easier to monitor where things stand *at each moment*, both for you and for the audience. Suppose you force a card. No effect has happened. Yet, outer and inner realities have already parted. The outer reality is that the spectator freely chose a card. The inner reality is that he chose the card you wanted.

[Incidentally, I'm not the first to recognize a need for new words to conceptualize these ideas. In **Pasteboard Presentations**, Terry LaGerould uses the terms “belief state” and “true state” to refer to what I'm calling outer reality and inner reality.]

Thinking about magic analytically requires dual-track thinking, simultaneously considering where things stand in the *outer reality* and the *inner reality*. When analyzing a trick, continually remind yourself whether,

at any given moment, you're thinking about the inner reality or the outer reality. Also, continually remind yourself of how what you're analyzing in *the* one reality will alter the parallel world of the other reality.

Magicians talk about using “any method that gets the job done.” They tend to forget that there are two aspects to “the job.” Every sleight has to further both the inner reality and the outer reality. It has to serve *two purposes*, to achieve a secret goal and to create an outward illusion.

A good example of the confusion that results when you don't train yourself to think this way is the endless argument about the pass versus other methods of controlling a card. The anti-pass argument usually goes, “There are much easier ways of accomplishing the same thing. A pinky break and a jog shuffle also get the card to the top.”

But, do a pass and a shuffle control accomplish the same thing? Actually, they only accomplish the same thing in terms of the inner reality. In both cases, the card is secretly brought to the top of the deck. But the outer realities are very different. The pass creates the outer reality that the card is in the *middle* of the deck. The shuffle control creates the outer reality that the card is lost *somewhere* in the deck. It could be near the bottom. It could be near the top. It could be on the bottom. It could be on the top. The whole point of a shuffle is to create randomness. Therefore, a shuffle control creates the outer reality that the location of the card is random and unpredictable. With the pass, the location of the card is very predictable. Its located at exactly the point where the spectator replaced. It, usually about halfway down in the deck.

If you think this is a minor point, try this experiment. Control a selected card to the top by means of a pass. Then announce that you have no idea where the card is. Someone is bound to point out that you do know that it's about halfway down in the deck. Or control a card to the top by means of a shuffle control. Then announce that the card is buried deep in the deck. Someone is likely to ask how you could know that.

Which control you should use depends on which outer reality you want to create. That, in turn, should depend on the effect you're performing. Suppose you intend to show an indifferent card and then top change it.

You'll now have the spectator blow on the card to transform it into her selection. This will be more amazing if the audience is convinced that the selection is buried deep in the deck. A pass would be ideal.

Let's assume instead that you plan to deal seconds until a spectator tells to stop. You then reveal that his unconscious psychic powers led him to his own card. Suppose you do a pass, and the spectator then stops you after you've dealt five cards. When you reveal that he stopped on his selected card, everyone will know that psychic powers had nothing to do with it. Since they saw the card buried in the middle, it could n t be sixth from the unless you used sleight of hand to get it there. If you don't use a shuffle control, you'll have a muddled effect.

Depending on the effect you're performing, the first outer reality may k more desirable or the second outer reality may be more desirable. Either, the two methods don't accomplish the same thing. Any time you've considering two different ways of accomplishing “the same thing,” make you're thinking in terms of *both* outer and inner realities.

It may seem trite to point out that, at every moment in an effect, there is what the audience thinks is true and what you know is true. My goal here however, is not to provide a great revelation, but to recommend a way of thinking. It's one thing to know something intellectually. It's another to make it a mental habit. The habit of thinking in terms of both inner and outer realities *at every point* in a trick is vital if you want to create strong effects.

Chapter Four: Temporal Distance

“The audience doesn't see the coin, the rabbit, or the girl vanish because they actually disappear either before or after the magician pretends to conjure them into thin air. The audience is watching most carefully at the wrong time.”

The Great Merlini,
Off the Face of the Earth
by Clayton Rawson

The fundamental tension in creating strong magic effects is the struggle between proximity and distance. The method, because it must *obey* the laws of nature, requires proximity. The effect, because it must appear to *defy* the laws of nature, requires distance. Fortunately, there are a variety of techniques that, applied creatively, can reconcile these opposing demands. Let's begin by considering how to build a *temporal* wall between method and effect.

The Critical Interval

What is the most dangerous moment in any effect in which to perform trickery? Most magicians would probably answer, “When the audience is watching most closely.” This answer, however, only raises the question: when is the audience going to be watching most closely? To answer that question, we have to return to Ascanio's definition of a magic effect. You'll recall that it is the difference between the initial condition and the final condition. If you're going to change an apple into an orange, showing the apple is the initial condition and revealing the orange is the final condition, (These roughly correspond to what in **Strong Magic** I called the expository phase and the magical phase. For discussing presentation I think those terms are more useful. For discussing effect design I think Ascanio's terms are more useful.)

The riskiest moment for trickery is the time between the audience's last view of the initial condition and their first view of the final condition. If you have to cover the apple with a handkerchief to change it into an orange, the danger period extends from the moment you cover the apple to the moment you uncover the orange. This time period is so central to all our subsequent discussions that it deserves a name. I call it “the critical

interval.” *The critical interval is the time between the audience's last view of the initial condition and their first view of the final condition.*

Depending on the effect, the critical interval can range from a fraction of a second to several minutes. In a color change, the period from the audience's final view of one card to its first view of the other card may be hardly more than the blink of an eye. At the other end of the spectrum, consider the classic *Card in Ring Box* as I employ it in my *Nine-Card*

Location. I start by taking out the ring box and placing it in front of a spectator. I instruct her not to take her eyes off it, I then have the selections made, the last of which a spectator signs. After these are lost in the deck. I locate each one in turn. Lastly, the signed card is found folded inside the ring box. Thus, for the *Card in Ring Box* portion of the effect, the critical interval lasts from the moment the signed card is lost in the deck to the moment it's found in the box, a period of about seven minutes.

Whether short or long, the critical interval looms large in the thinking of any audience watching a magic effect. If the initial condition differs from the final condition, common sense dictates that whatever caused the change happened during the critical interval. And remember, common sense is what laypeople rely on when reacting to a magic effect. The critical interval is when an audience *expects* the method to happen.

If you doubt that, consider this. One of the best comments you can ever hope to hear at the end of an effect is, “But he didn't do anything!” If the spectator concludes that you “didn't do anything,” the next thing he will conclude is, “That's impossible!” Because if you didn't do anything, there is no *cause* to account for the *effect*.

But what does a spectator really mean when he says that you didn't do anything? He does not, of course, mean that you never did anything at any point from the beginning of the effect to the end. (That would certainly make for a dull performance!) You took out the apple. You held up the apple. Perhaps you handed the apple out for examination. You covered the apple. You whisked away the cover to reveal the orange. Perhaps you handed the orange out for examination. All of these things constitute doing something. Yet, he emphatically proclaims that you “didn't do anything.”

What the astonished spectator really means is that you didn't do anything *during the critical interval* between his last view of the apple and his first view of the orange. In the audience's mind, this is the only time that matters. If you didn't do anything *then*, you didn't do anything.

This works the other way also. A spectator may dismiss a trick by saying merely, “You did something.” This sort of response frustrates many

magicians. They feel that the spectator should be required to either spell out *exactly* what the magician did or admit defeat. This would be true if we were speaking of a puzzle. However, if the spectator senses that you “did something” during the critical interval, it's not magic.

This is one of the reasons why magic happening in a spectator's hands can be so powerful. If the audience believes that the entire critical interval transpired while the key object was under the spectator's control, you have a miracle.

Since the critical interval plays such a vital role in the audience's thinking, it had better play a vital role in *your* thinking. The less you do during the critical interval, the stronger the effect will be.

This is why your instincts may sometimes tell you that, in a particular trick, the crucial move comes at the wrong time. If you don't fully understand the problem analytically, you might conclude that the solution is to add misdirection to cover the move. If, however, the flaw exists on the design level, adding misdirection will be like painting over cracks in a building caused by a poor foundation. A move comes at the wrong time if it comes *when the audience is expecting it*. Audiences expect the trickery to happen during the critical interval. Everything you do during that period will be scrutinized more closely both at the time and in retrospect. If the trickery really does happen during the critical interval, the weakest solution is to try to cover it with misdirection. The strongest solution is to redesign the method.

Case Studies

Let's examine some examples that illustrate how a perfect critical interval can make the difference between a miracle and just another card trick. Countless sandwich effects litter the literature of card magic. But *Monkey in the Middle* stood out from the pack the moment its creator Bill Goldman marketed it. This is despite the fact that, on paper, the effect sounds identical to all the others: a selected card appears face down between two face-up cards.

The performer has a card selected and returned to the deck. He then introduces two cards from a different deck that may be handed out for examination. These cards are then placed face up on top of the deck. The instant they're squared, the performer spreads them out to show that a facedown card has materialized between them. This proves to be the selected card.

This is exactly the kind of effect that will lead a spectator to say, "But he didn't do anything!" In fact, you do quite a bit before dropping the stranger cards on top of the deck. You even do quite a bit before introducing the two stranger cards. But you don't do anything during the brief period that matters to the audience. One moment there is no card between the stranger cards. The next moment there is. And nothing happened in between. That perfect critical interval has made the effect an instant classic.

One of the reasons the Oil and Water plot has a bad reputation among magicians is that most routines have tremendously cluttered critical intervals. After the reds and blacks have been alternated, the performer gratuitously spreads the cards, re-counts all the cards, re-counts the top four cards, replaces the counted-off cards, ad nauseam. When he then shows that the reds and blacks have separated, there isn't much mystery as to how or when it happened. Only the exact details remain obscure and that's something only another card man would care about.

By contrast, Rene Lavand's and Juan Tamariz's Oil and Water routines are so memorable precisely because there is *no* handling during the critical interval. There are moves before (and sometimes after). But between the time the colors are alternated and the time they are shown to be separated, the performer does nothing. Another outstanding routine in this regard is Derek Dingles *Oil and Vinegar*. Once the cards are alternated, you do nothing except turn them face up and show that the colors have separated.

In **Scams Fantasies with Cards**, I have a routine called *Ultimate Oil and Water that builds* on the Dingle routine. The red and black packets are alternated and magically separated twice, each time with a moveless critical interval. The third time, the colors start separated but magically alternate. What sets the routine apart is what happens next. I pick up the deck, which a spectator has previously shuffled. I give it one shuffle, and spread out the

cards to show that the *entire deck* has separated into reds and blacks. I then scoop up the segregated deck and, after a magical gesture, re-spread it. The audience sees that the reds and blacks now alternate perfectly throughout the deck. What makes this memorable is that there is absolutely *no handling* between the time that the deck is shown separated into reds and blacks and the time that it's shown alternating in color. One moment the colors are separated; the next moment they alternate.

I'll mention just one more example that will be familiar to most of you. Michael Skinner's *Ultimate Three-Card Monte* is widely recognized as a modern classic. What makes it special? The cards are laid out and there is

no further handling. One moment, the ace is here. The next moment, it's there. A perfect critical interval.

Each of these effects will elicit gasps or astonished laughter at the climax. But what really produces those reactions is what happened in the moments before the climax: *absolutely nothing*. If nothing happened between the last view of the initial condition and the first view of the final condition, nothing can account for the change from one to the other. It can only be magic.

The Magician Mentality

Ironically, magicians tend to admire the opposite approach. They often shower the greatest praise on the version with the most cluttered critical interval. There are at least two reasons for this. First, often a lousy method will fool magicians better than a good method because magicians already know the good method.

For example, the classic approach to the ace assembly plot is to switch out the aces at the beginning. When the aces now start traveling to the leader packet, people are astonished because they can see that you don't do anything that could secretly convey cards from one packet to another. With each ace they watch more closely, but there is nothing to see. They don't know that the aces were in the leader packet to begin with. That's the beauty of the classic approach. By introducing the trickery so early in the effect, you can “do nothing” during the critical interval.

Some time back I saw a video of a legendary card magician, now deceased. He performed a version in which the aces really were placed in the four different packets. The magician then palmed each ace in turn out of its follower packet and transferred it to the leader packet. This was touted as an “expert” version. The delusion that this was a superior approach could only have resulted from the magician getting great reactions when he performed it for other magicians. Magicians know that the standard approach involves switching out the aces at the start- They would be thrown for a loop when there was no initial switch-out.

But the fact is that the magician was doing exactly *what* laypeople would be looking for: palming each ace across. And he was doing it exactly *when* laypeople would be looking for it: during the critical interval. This obvious approach would have little chance of getting by a lay audience three times in a row, no matter how flawless one's technique.

The magician in question (whom I greatly admired and valued *as* a friend) heard that I was critical of this routine. The next time I saw him he brought up the subject and said to me, “I can't believe that you of all people, Darwin, have no faith in palming.” Although we discussed the matter at length, I couldn't get him to see that the problem wasn't the palming but *when* the palming occurred (Mike Close, in reviewing the video in question, commented on this ace assembly: “The construction is such that each sleight screams out for attention. I don't think it would fool anyone.”)

The psychology that produces such wrong-headed thinking might be summed up as follows: Since magicians already know the clever method, let's fool them with a dumb method they're not expecting, although it's the first explanation a layperson would think of.

There is, however, also something else at work here, a strange kind of “machismo” that other magicians respect. Since magic is usually achieved through cheating, to many magicians there is something awe inspiring about seeing a magician do the same effect “for real.” Hence, the notion that actually putting the aces in four different packets and transferring them across through raw technical skill (i.e., brute force) is the mark of an expert.

If you know my work, you know that I don't denigrate technical skill. But technical skill should be combined with cleverness, not used as a substitute for it. If your goal is to create miracles for laypeople, resist the tendency to admire the brute force approach to magic design. The doing-it-for-real approach invariably means doing it at exactly *the moment* the audience would expect you to do it (and usually in exactly *the way* they would expect you to do it.)

Forward Time Displacement

Achieving that perfect critical interval where nothing happens is one of magics great challenges. One effective approach is to alter the audience's perception of when the critical interval begins. I call this concept forward time displacement. The principle is easily stated: you make the effect appear to happen later than it really did. The techniques for doing this range from the elementary to the diabolically subtle. Let's start with the simplest application of the concept.

Time Misdirection

So far as I know, the term *time misdirection* was coined by Harry Lorayne. Time misdirection is the simplest form of temporal separation. It may be defined as follows: *interjecting a time lapse between two elements to obscure the causal connection*. That this simple ploy works so well is further proof that an audience's search for cause is more instinctive than analytical.

The classic force is a good example of where time misdirection can make a difference. The usual approach is to start with the force card on the top or bottom of the deck. You then cut the deck to centralize the card and spread the deck for a selection. Unfortunately, when the audience sees you cut immediately before you offer the cards for a selection they may sense that you're preparing to force a card—which, of course you are. (Audiences may not know the term “classic force,” but they can easily intuit the concept.)

The audience makes the connection between the cut and the selection process for no other reason than that one comes immediately after the other. This suggests the solution. If temporal proximity leads the audience to

connect the two actions, temporal separation will keep them from doing so. Cut the deck. Then patter for a few moments while holding a break. When you then spread the cards to have one chosen, no one will relate the one action to the other.

The same psychology can be applied to shuffle or cut controls of a selected card. If you shuffle or cut the deck immediately after the spectator returns his card to the deck, many audience members will suspect that you're putting the card where you want it. If, instead, you hold a break above the selected card for a few moments while you patter and then shuffle or cut, people will feel that you're further losing the card rather than controlling it. It may be hard to believe that such a small change in handling can make such a big difference in the audience's perceptions- If you doubt it, however, try it both ways. You'll quickly notice the difference.

When a card effect requires a very small partial setup, the magic books will often tell you to arrange the cards while “toying with the deck.” If you toy with the deck and then place it aside for a few moments before picking it up to perform the effect you'll probably fool everyone. If you go into the trick immediately after toying with the deck. You'll probably fool no one.

It's a basic principle of sleight of hand that sleights should be performed without any “setting action” (readjusting your grip, repositioning the cards,

etc.), Ideally, you should avoid such actions because they can telegraph that you're getting ready to “do something.” Unfortunately, this ideal isn't always attainable. In a particular effect, for example, you may have to readjust your grip on the deck before palming a card. The action you need to perform before the palm may simply require a different grip from the one needed for the palm.

In such cases, you can eliminate most of the harm of readjusting by using time misdirection. Interject a brief time delay between the readjustment and the sleight. After you alter your grip, patter for a few seconds. Then execute the palm. The brief delay is usually enough to prevent the audience from making a connection between the readjustment and the subsequent actions of the secret sleight. It will no longer look like you're “getting set” to do something.

The concept of time misdirection is so simple that it's easy to underestimate its strength. If, however, you understand how people's instincts can lead them to make the correct connections you can appreciate how powerful a tool a few moments, pause can be in derailing those instincts.

Time Displacement and Acting

“A card was named while Bert toyed with the deck, cutting the desired pasteboard of course to the top. As though all at once paying attention and summoning his forces, Bert laid the deck on the table and asked someone to place a salt cellar on top of the deck. Then turning to the person who had made the request, he asked 'What was that card?' Upon having named it, the spectator was asked to raise the cellar, and beneath it, as though in response to his thought, lay the correct card.”

The above passage from **The Close-Up Magician** describes one of Bert Allerton's reputation-making memorized-stack effects. I had the opportunity to discuss this effect with a friend of Allerton's who saw him perform it many times. He stressed that the audience always felt that the effect started when Allerton instructed the spectator to place the saltcellar on the deck. Since the performer did *nothing* once the saltcellar was placed on the deck, this perception made the trick a miracle. The method happened *before* the saltcellar was placed but, psychologically, the effect happened *after*.

How did Allerton pull off this neat perceptual swindle? The secret is in the earlier description: “As though all at once paying attention and summoning his forces...” It was all a matter of acting. Initially, Allerton acted like the trick hadn't yet started. Once the dirty work was over, he acted like

it was about to begin. His question, “What was that card?” was the signal that he was about to get down to business.

Like time misdirection, this is another psychological, rather than technical, method for creating a temporal separation between method and effect. Again, the principle is easy to state: *Act like the trick hasn't started even after it has.*

Juan Tamariz is a master of this technique. He will ask a spectator to name a card. Just as he replies, Juan absent mindedly turns away and starts talking to the rest of the audience. While doing so, he will cull the named card to the top of the deck, just then he will “remember” what he was about to do. He will again ask the spectator to name a card. When the spectator repeats the name, Juan proceeds as if he has just heard it for the first time. Indeed, the audience believes that he has. For them, this is when the effect scans although most of the method is already over. (This approach works particularly well for Juan because it plays off the scatterbrained persona that he cultivates.)

If you ever see a good Blindfold Vision Act, you'll probably be repeatedly fooled even if you know exactly how the blindfold works. You'll find yourself thinking, “How can he know what object the spectator is holding? He's not even looking in that direction.”

Someone skilled at this type of act never glimpses the object as he identifies it. He does so beforehand as he patters. Once he knows what it is, he instructs the spectator to hold the object up. He deliberately turns his head aside as he extends his hands over it. Like Bert Allerton, all at once he pays attention and summons his forces. He exerts all his super-human powers. Slowly, uncertainly at first, he begins to describe the object, all the time keeping his head averted. The illusion is compelling that the effect happens new. The method, of course, happened earlier, making for a powerful mystery. The technical device of the gaffed blindfold is only half the secret. The other half is the time displacement produced by the performers acting.

Speaking of mentalism, for some great examples of time displacement through acting, study spoon and key bending as performed by the best mentalists. Since the methods used for actually putting in the bends are often very straightforward, time displacement through acting is often the prime factor in making these effects deceptive.

Admittedly, time displacement through acting is not something that you can apply to all or even most effects. But you should always be on the lookout for situations where you can.

Time Displacement and Magic Gestures

Closely allied to creating time displacement through acting is the use of the magical gesture. A magic gesture provides a *focus* for your acting. Whether it's a wave of the hand, a tap of the wand, a snap of the finger, or just a moment of intense concentration, if you do it with sincerity and conviction, it will influence the spectators.

Of course, they won't actually believe that the magic gesture causes the effect. But they'll find it hard to resist the *feeling* that this is when the magic happens. And that counts for a lot. The force of the magic gesture is psychological rather than logical, but that makes it no less powerful. Indeed, it may make it *more* powerful.

In an essay circulated to his customers, Denny Haney recounted a beautiful example of creating time displacement simply by convincingly acting a magic gesture. He was describing a vanish used by Fred Kaps: "He would apparently place the object in the left hand and yet retain it in his right hand. When he wanted to cause the object to vanish, he would blow on his left hand, then open it just enough for him to see inside his hand. Then he would blow again, finally showing that the object had vanished. Can you see what he was doing? He was creating the impression that the object was still in the left hand. It was very subtle. It seemed that the first blow didn't do the job so he repeated the blowing at the hand and NOW the object vanished. The audience is led to think that the object vanished at just that moment rather than at the beginning when the object was first placed into the hand."

There is a circular logic that works to the magician's advantage when it comes to magic gestures. We've seen that the audience believes that whatever causes the change from the initial condition to the final condition must occur during the critical interval. It follows that, if the only thing that occurs during the critical interval is the magic gesture, that must be what caused the change. Using a magic gesture, in turn, reinforces the audience's inclination to believe that the change really did happen during the critical interval. This is a good thing if the method actually happened earlier.

Considerable ingenuity can go into the choke of a magic gesture. When Juan Tamariz performs Oil and Water, he uses a small bottle containing small amounts of oil and water. When he alternates the reds and blacks, he shakes the bottle. He then allows it to sit until the liquids separate. At that point he shows that the cards have also separated. This makes sense

in terms of sympathetic magic, something we all grasp intuitively. When this happens a grain and again, it reinforces the notion that there is a link between the two events. Consequently, it reinforces the false notion that the color separation happens after the cards were alternated.

As this example shows, the use of a magic gesture is particularly powerful in multi-phase effects. This is because it takes advantage of one of the instinctive clues to causality, that of correlation. Because the magic gesture is present *every single time* that the magic happens, the spectator's instincts will tell him that it is *why* the magic happens. This, in turn, reinforces the false impression that this is *when* the magic happens. If the spectator is wrong about when, he'll never figure out how.

Here again, because of its simplicity, many magicians will tend to underestimate the power of the magical gesture as a tool for time displacement and, therefore, for enhancing the deception. I hope you won't be one of them.

Time Displacement Convincers

In **Strong Magic**, I defined a *convincer* as, “Any minor action that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that all is as it should be.” For purposes of our present discussion, we might rephrase that as: *any minor action that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that nothing has changed yet*. In other words, virtually all convincers are time displacers. They are designed to falsely extend the initial condition in the mind of the spectator.

In *The Ring on Wand*, the initial condition is that the performer holds the borrowed ring in one hand and the wand in the other. The final condition is that the ring is threaded on the wand. A standard subtlety is for the performer to mentally note some unique feature of the ring the moment he borrows it. (He may, for example, note that it has a red stone.) He does not,

however, comment on this feature. Instead, he proceeds with the handling. He performs a false transfer with the ring and secretly threads it onto the wand. From a method standpoint, the effect is over.

Now comes the convincer. The performer glances down at the cupped fingers of the hand that supposedly holds the ring. He says, "That's a beautiful stone. Is it a ruby or a garnet?" Since he has just noticed the color of the stone while looking in his right hand, the ring must be in that hand while the wand is in the other. This subtlety reinforces the audience's belief that the initial condition still prevails even after the final condition has secretly been achieved.

In *Fastest Gun Alive* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards** there is a point where I turn over the top card of the deck and have a spectator sign it. I then turn the card face down and place it aside. In reality, I initially perform a double turnover. After the spectator signs, I turn the double face down. The card I place aside is a dummy. The signed card remains on top of the deck.

To "sell" the switch I use a convincer. After the spectator signs the card. I blow on it to dry the ink. After I turn the double face down and deal off the top card, I blow on *its* face before placing it aside. Since I'm still concerned with the wet ink, it must still be the same card. Blowing on the card before and after the switch creates a *false continuity*, linking the *selection* with its substitute.

One of the most popular convincers is Daryl's cutting display for *Triumph*. In *Triumph*, you secretly separate the face-up and facedown cards almost as soon as you've shuffled them together. Daryl's display shows face-up cards and facedown cards mixed together long after they've actually been separated, falsely extending the initial condition.

These examples illustrate the three elements that distinguish convincers from other time displacers. The first is a matter of degree. Where most time displacers are overt, convincers are covert. Where most time displacers compel, convincers seduce. Secondly, convincers have an incidental/accidental quality. You prove things seemingly without intending to. Thirdly, convincers are often more psychological than logical. If offered as proof, they might not stand up to close scrutiny. Fortunately, however,

they operate below the spectator's logical radar; they are stealth devices. (On pp.75-83 of **Strong Magic** I delve into these points in greater depth.)

The Time Displacement Device

“People do not renumber by retracing. They remember by jumping back to an earlier point and moving forward to figure out what happened. Your task, as a magician, is to get them to jump to a point after you did the dirty work.”

Al Schneider, **The Theory of Magic**

This technique is as simple in theory as it is potent in practice. You show the initial condition. You then secretly change the condition. You now employ some technique that allows you to apparently show that the initial condition has not changed. That technique is the time displacement device. When you later reveal the final condition, there is no possible explanation because nothing happened between the time displacement de-

vice and the effect climax that could account for the change in condition. *A time displacement device is anything that allows you to show that the initial condition has not changed although it actually has.*

A perfect example is the classic double-hype sequence in three-card monte. The audience knows that you have two black cards and one red card (the winning card). You apparently toss the red one to the table but actually toss one of the blacks by means of the hype. This is the moment when the method occurs: you've switched the winning red card for a losing black card.

The moment that makes the effect a miracle, however, comes next. With the remaining black and the winning red in your hands, you do the hype move again to show both of these cards as black. If both these cards are black, then the one on the table must be red. When you later show it to be a losing black card, it's not just a surprise; it's also an impossibility.

The first hype achieves the effect. The second hype covers your tracks. It does nothing to advance the method, but does a great deal to advance the

mystery. It is a time displacement device that proves that things are still the same. As with any time displacement device, its purpose is to reassure the audience. It says, in effect, “Don't worry; *nothing has happened yet.*”

A time displacement device creates a time *harrier* between the effect and the method. The method lies on one side. The audience focuses its attention on the other side. They never look back past that barrier in search of an explanation. Since that's where the explanation lies, the audience is forced to conclude that there is *no* explanation. In the monte example, the spectator must conclude that whatever happened to cause the result must have happened *after* the three cards hit the table. Yet nothing that happened after the cards hit the table could possibly account for the red card changing to a black card.

A time displacement device can be as simple as holding a break. Consider this pseudo-estimation demonstration shown to me by Gary Plants. The following description assumes that the performer is left-handed (which, by coincidence, I am). The deck is in a memorized stack. You ask the spectator to name a number from one to fifty-two. Of course, you know the card at that number. Holding the deck upright, you riffle down the upper right corner with your thumb until you spot that card. You then cut off all the cards at that point and hand them to the spectator to count. It proves, of course, to be the requested number.

If this effect has any flaw it's only that the performer must look at the indices of the cards. This could provide a clue to the method. Here is how

I perform it. Let's suppose that the spectator names the number thirty-five. I cut off the packet as in the original handling, but I don't hand it over for counting. Instead I look at the edge of the packet and announce, “Yes, exactly thirty-five cards.” I then immediately replace the cards on the deck, preventing anyone from calling my bluff.

The audience, of course, laughs at this transparent swindle. I look hurt and say, “If you don't believe me, check for yourself.” As I say this, I cut off another packet of cards, this time instantaneously and without even glancing at the deck; I hand the cards to a spectator to count and he finds exactly thirty-five cards.

Actually, I'm using the same method as Gary Plants. When I replace the packet after the first “bluff” estimation, I hold a fourth-finger break under it. This allows me to cut off the same group of cards a moment later without hesitating. The break allows me to separate the method (glancing at the indices) from the effect (cutting off the right number of cards).

The spectators won't connect my glancing at the indices to the final effect because I did it during *the previous* “gag.” When I later did it “for real” there was no glancing and no hesitation. The use of the break allowed me to create the impression that nothing had changed after the “gag” estimation. That makes the break a time displacement device. The method occurs before in. The effect occurs after it.

Earlier I described a time displacement device as a barrier with the effect on one side and the method on the other. Another way of looking at it is that a time displacement device creates a false continuity. It creates a seeming continuity between the initial condition before you perform the method and the condition after you've done the method.

In *Blockbuster* from my book **Cardshark**, I ribbonspread the deck and invite a spectator to select a card. After she has noted it, I fan the deck and insert the selection in the middle. I then give the deck a single shuffle and ask the spectator to name the color of her card. Let's suppose she says red. I perform a magic gesture and ribbonspread the deck. All twenty-six red cards are now face up. The cards are still in a mixed condition, but all the reds are face up and the blacks face down. The effect proves even more amazing when, on closer inspection, it's found that there is *one* red card among the facedown blacks. The spectator's selection is the only red card that did not turn over.

The trick is amazing because the audience *knows* that all the cards are face down at least up to the moment when I shuffle the deck. They see that

clearly both when I ribbonspread the deck for a selection and when I fan it for the return of the selection,

All of the cards are, in fact, face down when I ribbonspread the deck for a selection. By the time I fan the deck for the replacement, however, the

bottom half of the deck is secretly face up. I've devised a fanning technique that disguises this fact and seemingly shows all the cards face down. The fan is the time displacement device. In effect, it moves the picture of the facedown ribbonspread forward in time, creating a false continuity. In the audience's mind, it's as if you go directly from the ribbonspread to the magical climax. Any actions in between are edited out of the audience's consciousness by the fan that shows that *nothing has changed*.

Case Study: Carlyle's Homing Card

The final phase of Francis Carlyle's *Homing Card* from the **Stars of Magic** provides a good example of the power of forward time displacement. The Carlyle trick is a repeat card-to-pocket effect. Even to a layperson, the obvious way to achieve this effect is through palming. And the obvious time to do the palming is between the time the card goes into the deck and the time it comes out of the pocket.

The beauty of the last phase of the Carlyle trick is that the card travels to your pocket *before* that critical interval. If you're not familiar with the trick, right now you may be thinking, "That's impossible." It would seem so, and that's why it fools people.

After the previous phase, you're secretly left with a card in your pocket. That card is a pseudo-mate of the selection. You now give a mock explanation of how the card traveled to the pocket. In the course of it, you briefly insert the selected card into your pocket. In that instant, you switch it for the pseudo-mate. It is that card that you insert into the deck at the start of the next phase. Because the card is a pseudo-mate, you can partially flash its face as a convincer before pushing it square into the deck. All that remains is to produce the card from the pocket with an obviously empty hand.

Thus, as far as this phase is concerned, the *method* is over before the *effect* begins. Even as the selection is being pushed into the deck (in terms of the outer reality) it's already in the pocket (in terms of the inner reality).

Forward Time Displacement Methodology

The use of the fourth-finger break in the pseudo-estimation effort above illustrates that, in the right context, almost any method can function as a time displacement device. However, certain methodological tools particularly lend themselves to the job. As we look at these, I hope you'll notice that effects that appear very different may be very similar in methodological design.

Physical Disguise:

Any method of physical disguise has time displacement potential. In card magic, false display counts work particularly well. The point of such counts is to disguise the composition of a packet (the *number* of cards, the *identity* of the cards, or the face-up/face-down *orientation* of the cards. This means that you can legitimately show the composition of a packet of cards, secretly change that composition and then do a false count to *conceal the* change. When you later *reveal* the change, you have a miracle.

Consider how Vernon handled the last ace in *Twisting the Aces*. You start with all the aces face down. You secretly reverse one. You then Elmsley count to show that they're all still face down. When you now reveal that one has turned face up, it's inexplicable because there was no handling of any kind between the audience's last view of all the aces face down and their first view of one ace face up. That's why the last ace is the strongest.

I make frequent use of this concept in my card magic. For example, *The Color of Money*, my version of Follow the Leader (**Scams Fantasies with Cards**), I show that one packet consists of ten red cards and the other of ten black cards. These displays are convincing because the two packets really do consist of ten reds and ten blacks respectively. I then secretly transfer some black cards to the red packet and some red cards to the black packet.

A moment later, however, I use the Hamman count to show that the red packet still contains only red cards and the black packet only black cards. When, immediately thereafter, the colors start transposing there seems no possible explanation. The false count in effect erased the previous handling that achieved the secret transfers. It brought the initial legitimate showings forward in time. The audience will search for a solution sometime *after* the

Hamman counts occurred. They provide a time barrier. The effect occurs after the counts but the method occurs before the counts.

Physical disguise isn't limited only to cards. Consider Ray Grismer's great *Ring-off-Cord* move. You thread a finger ring on a cord and then secretly remove it; The Grismer move allows you to then show the ring still threaded on the cord although it's not. A moment later, when you release the ring from the cord, the audience will seek the solution somewhere *after* the Grismer false show occurred. The fact that Grismer's move, which actually accomplishes nothing (in terms of the inner reality), has justly revolutionized the *Ring-off-Cord* plot is ample proof of the value of time displacement moves.

Gaffs can also provide physical disguise. Ron Wilson's handling of Brother Hamman's *Micro Macro* is exceptionally deceptive because he really starts with a miniature deck. The spectators can handle or even shuffle it. Only after a card has been selected from it, does he switch the miniature deck for a normal one. He then immediately ribbonspreads the cards. Thanks to Brother Hamman's ingenious gaff lying on top, the deck appears to still be miniature. When the performer later scoops up the deck and re-spreads it to make it grow, the audience believes that the switch must have happened at that moment. Yet, they also know that it couldn't have. The cards never went out of sight and the performer's hands were otherwise empty. They would never suspect how much earlier the switch really occurred. The micro macro gaff functions as a time displacement device, allowing a wide temporal gap between method and effect.

The Dummy:

A second category of methods well suited to time displacement is the principle of the dummy. By this I mean an object that temporarily stands in for the real one. The audience watches the dummy while you manipulate the genuine article. In effect, the dummy principle allows an object to be in two places at once. The dummy locates the object in one place in the outer reality of the effect while you manipulate the real object elsewhere in the inner reality of the method.

This concept is so common in stage illusions that any time an illusionist dons a mask, helmet, or anything else that obscures his face you can expect the dummy principle to come in to play. A dummy in the form of an identically dressed stand-in will be substituted for the illusionist to achieve a time displacement, usually for some translocation effect.

A good close-up example is the classic *Coin in Matchbox*. A spectator initials a coin which you then cover with a handkerchief and give him to

hold. He can feel the coin through the handkerchief. In reality he is feeling a dummy coin sewn into the handkerchief. The dummy allows the coin, in effect, to be in two places at once. This gives you all the time in the world to load the initialed coin into the rubber-banded matchbox.

You now vanish the handkerchief away from the spectators grasp to show that the coin has vanished. Immediately you produce it from the matchbox. There appears to be no time for the coin to have traveled from one place to the other. This is because the audience will only backtracks far as the vanish of the coin from under the handkerchief. In their minds, that's when the critical interval began.

The coin vanish in the *Coin in Matchbox* illustrates a concept particularly useful in time displacement, what we might term *the disappearing dummy*. The dummy, in effect, vanishes automatically as soon as you no longer need it.

One of the oddest and most ingenious of vanishing dummies is the glass disc used in the *Wisenheimer Cain Trick*. This is the old trick in which a coin vanishes when dropped in a glass of water. In fact, you could easily substitute this method for the handkerchief vanish in *The Coin in Matchbox*. Switch the glass disc for the marked coin and allow the spectator to hold it through a handkerchief over a glass of water. Load the marked *coin* into the matchbox (or nest of boxes or whatever) and hand it to another spectator to hold.

Tell the first spectator to drop the coin into the glass of water. Lift the handkerchief to reveal the vanish. Then produce the marked coin from the matchbox. (A nice touch would be to arrange for the coin to be wet when

found in the container.) Again the effect is a miracle because it appears that the coin must have traveled to the matchbox *after* it left the spectator's hand. The disc allows the coin to be in two places at once. Then, the moment it has served its purpose, it evaporates.

The vanishing dummy principle has vast applications in card magic because all the cards in a deck look alike when they're face down. Therefore, any card can serve as a dummy for any other card as long as it remains face down. And that dummy can be made to “vanish” simply by allowing it to coalesce with other cards.

In my sandwich effect, *Beyond Sleight of Hand (Cardshark)*, I use the Jennings control to apparently place a selected card on the table. It is, in fact, a dummy card. The selected card actually remains on top of the deck. I then display the two sandwich cards. In the process, I secretly load the selection between them. Even as I'm doing this, the audience believes that

the selected card is in full view on the table. The card is in two places at once: on the table in the outer reality and between the sandwich cards in the inner reality, I then have a spectator push the “selection” into the deck. The dummy dissolves the instant it squares with the other cards.

There are no better examples of a dummy card “disappearing” the moment it coalesces with the deck than the classic tent vanish and rub-a-dub vanish. An indifferent card acts as a dummy for the important card. You then vanish the dummy just by secretly pulling it square with the deck. The moment it hits the top of the deck, it's gone. Indeed, showing the face of the top card *proves* that the card has vanished despite the fact that the card you're displaying was a moment ago the dummy.

This ploy is possible because all the cards in the deck look the same from the back. Of course, laypeople *realize* that all cards look alike when facedown. Therefore, to get the most impact out of the dummy principle in card magic you need a thoroughly convincing switch of one card for the other,

You can also increase conviction by altering the card in some way that appears to identify it even when it's face down. This is what makes the

popup card sequence from **Expert Card Technique** such an effective climax for the *Ambitious Card*. The performer puts a strong bend in the card, and then buries it in the deck. A moment later the audience sees the bent card pop up on top of the deck. The sequence is strong partly because the bend allows the audience to “see” the card arrive on top while also allowing the performer to *delay the revelation* that the card is on top. But another reason why it's so effective is that the bend enhances the dummy principle. Bending the card seems to make it unique. Substituting one bent card for another gives you an especially convincing dummy. The audience is more convinced that the ambitious card is really being buried in the middle and more amazed when it arrives on top.

There are many other possibilities along these lines. You might sign the back of a card in the course of a trick. Later you switch it for a dummy card you signed before the performance. Or you might tear a corner off the card and later switch in a dummy with a similarly missing corner. (I use both ideas in *The Marker* from **Cardshark**.) Or you might place a stamp or sticker of some kind on the back of the card. Of course, you've previously prepared the dummy the same way.

What all these examples have in common is that the spectator will look for the method somewhere after the dummy has disappeared. In feet, the method is on the other side of that time barrier.

Forms And Shells:

A special type of disappearing dummy is the form, something that cleans a shape simulating the stolen object. In the *Asrah* illusion, the woman is stolen away inside the couch at virtually the outset of the effect. This isn't suspected because a dummy is substituted consisting of a wire form under the sheet. When the magician later whips away the sheet to reveal the disappearance, it seems that the woman vanished at that instant. The dummy allows the effect of the vanish to happen much later than the *method*.

A smaller version of the same thing is The Vanishing Radio. A large, old-fashioned radio lies on a table. The performer covers it with a cloth. He carries it down stage and whisks the cloth away. The radio has disappeared.

In fact, the radio collapsed into the table the moment the performer covered it with the cloth. The cloth, however, contains a form simulating the outline of the radio.

A still smaller version is the Glass through Table. The newspaper used to cover the glass creates the form. The paper's natural stiffness causes it to hold the shape of the glass even after it's gone. The form vanishes when the magician slaps the newspaper flat. As far as the audience is concerned, that's when the glass vanishes, which is long after it was actually lapped.

A shell can also function as a vanishing dummy. This is why *Coins Across* using a shell coin beats any version relying solely on sleight of hand. The shell constitutes a dummy coin that can disappear whenever you want it to (simply by nesting over a real coin). The shell allows you to show a coin in the left hand long after you've actually transported it to the right hand. There is no need to show what you've got in the other hand since the audience knows the coin can't be in two places at once. (Thanks to the dummy principle, it can.) When you vanish the shell by nesting it, the audience believes the transportation must have happened at that moment.

Mimicked Sounds:

Today the Downs rattle gimmick on the arm is associated with David Roth's *Tuning Fork* routine. But its original purpose was simply to make the audience think that you had coins in your hand after they were already gone. In other words, its purpose was time displacement.

Coin magicians often use sound to make the audience believe that the coin is where it's supposed to be rather than where it really is. A convincing ploy in *Coins Through the Table* is to tap the last coin on the tabletop and scrape it along the surface before making it penetrate. In fact, the empty

hand above the table goes through the motions of tapping and scraping as the hand below the table creates the sound with the coin, which is already under the table. There are also many examples where the sound of clinking coins is seemingly produced from a hand that doesn't contain those coins.

Mimicked sounds needn't be limited to coin effects. Tommy Downs had a brilliant subtlety for *Glass Through Table*. He taped a coin inside the newspaper that he used to cover the glass. After lapping the glass, he would tap the newspaper from with his wand. The coin would create a sound mimicking the clink of the glass. As in the previous example, sound is used to confirm the initial condition (object *above* the table) even after you've achieved the final condition (object *under* the table).

Paul Harris published an effect in which he held a three-card sandwich and snapped each card audibly. In fact, one of the three cards had already been stolen out. He created the sound by snapping one of the remaining cards twice. When he then vanished the sandwiched card, the audience believed that the effect happened after the snapping while the method had actually happened before.

Janus gaffs:

The most useful type of gimmick for time displacement is what I term a Janus gaff. This is any prop gimmicked so that you can, at will, show it to be either of two different objects (copper or silver, red or blue, ace or spot card, one-dollar bill or twenty-dollar bill), or to be in either of two conditions (empty or full, blank or printed). Examples include copper/silver coins, the two copper/one silver gaff, color-changing knives, double-faced cards, double-ended cards, Hofzinser's transparent card, gaffed bills, the Himber wallet, the Svengali deck, and the Mental Photography deck.

Using a Janus gaff for time displacement can be seen in its purest form in Hofzinser's own use of his transparent card. This card, when held back outward against a light source, will show a silhouette of a different card. Hofzinser would show a three of spades and then change it for a gaffed queen. He would then hold the card up to a candle so that everyone could see that it was still the three of spades. He now performed a magical gesture and turned the card around to show that it had changed to a queen. The only thing the audience knew for sure was that the change happened after the card was held up to the candle. Of course, the switch occurred before the card was held up to the candle. The performer did nothing after he held

the card up to the candle. Therefore, the audience had to conclude, “But he didn't do anything!”

Andrew Wimhurst uses a double-ended card to achieve a devastating time displacement in his three-card monte routine *The Full Monte*. The Janus gaff in this case is a card that shows as a black deuce for most of its face but has an ace of hearts index in one corner. (Those who do Michael Skinner's *Ultimate Three-Card Monte* will be familiar with this.) Andrew starts with three ordinary cards, one of which is the ace of hearts. He begins by having a spectator sign the ace. He then performs a classic-style monte routine using the ace of hearts as the money card. Eventually he lays the three cards on the table, switching the ace for the double-ended card. He loads the signed ace into his wallet as he removes some cash to bet against the spectator. The wallet remains on the table. Now comes the part that makes this a miracle. Andrew bends up the corner of the tabled card that the audience believes is the ace. They see the ace of hearts index, proving that *nothing has happened yet*. A moment later, he turns over the card (covering the ace index with his fingers) to show that it has become a black deuce. It's astonishing because nothing has occurred that could account for this change in condition.

The real miracle, however, comes a moment later when he pulls the signed ace out of his wallet. In an instant, the ace not only vanished from the table where it was in plain view, it also traveled to inside the wallet, which was also on the table in plain view. One way of looking at this is that the Janus gaff allowed the ace of hearts to be in two places at once: on the table and in the wallet. Another way of looking at it is that flashing the false ace index of the tabled card created a time barrier between method and effect. The audience is certain that the ace was on the table up to the moment that they glimpsed the ace of hearts corner. Therefore, they won't look for any explanation prior to that moment. Still another way of looking at it is that the gaffed card created a false continuity between the earlier phases where the real ace of hearts was in play and the last phase where it has been switched out. For the spectator, it all adds up to one thing, “No way!”

A more recent innovation in Janus gaffs is Ton's Wallet, marketed by Ton Onosaka. This ingenious item combines a card-loading wallet with a Himber wallet. You can load a palmed card into a transparent window of the wallet. Yet, even after you've loaded the card, you can show the wallet empty simply by opening the *other* side. (Again the message is that nothing has happened yet.) If you now close the wallet and place it on the table,

when you later reveal the selected card, it will appear that the card traveled to the wallet while the wallet was on the table. The method happened before you showed the wallet empty; the effect happened after.

If you wanted to go nuts over time displacement, you could incorporate Ton's Wallet into Wimhurst's The Full Monte. This would constitute double time displacement.

Double Time Displacement

Time displacement devices are about falsely extending the initial condition. In some effects, however, the initial condition has *two* sides. This occurs when an object magically travels from one place to another or when two objects magically transpose. Consider the effect of making a selected card travel to your pocket. The two sides of the initial condition are: 1) the card is in the deck; 2) the card is *not* in the pocket. Naturally, one implies the other. Therefore, you can achieve time displacement through any device that proves either side of the equation.

Let's assume you've secretly loaded the selected card into your pocket. However, you're employing a time displacement technique that shows the selected card still in the deck. For example, you may use a card control that allows you to apparently leave the selected card—actually a dummy—sticking out of the center of the deck even after you've palmed it out. If the card is sticking out of the deck, it can't yet be in your pocket.

Alternatively, you may employ a time displacement technique that allows you to show the pocket empty even after the card is in it {for example, the old top-of-the-pocket dodge}. If the card is not yet in your pocket, that implies that it's still in the deck.

While a time displacement device on either side of the equation is strong, having time displacements on *both* sides is even stronger. Suppose you have a card selected and signed. Use Marlo's convincing control to leave a dummy card sticking out of the deck while bringing the selection to the bottom. Palm the card. Reach into your pocket and load the card at the top as you pull the pocket out to show it empty. Push the pocket back in. Have a spectator push the “selection” the rest of the way into the deck and shuffle the cards. Take the deck back and perform a magical gesture. With an obviously empty hand you reach into your pocket and pull out the signed selection. This combination of subtleties raises a simple effect to new heights of impossibility.

This is a fairly elementary example of the concept of double time displacement. With a little imagination, some very subtle and devastating combinations can be worked out. My earlier suggestion of using Ton's wallet for Wimhurst's *The Full Monte* gives some idea of the possibilities.

Time Displacement and Presentation

My focus here is using time displacement to raise the *impossibility quotient* of an effect. It's worth noting, however, that another benefit of separating method and effect in time is the great opportunities it offers for presentation. The interval between the end of the method and the revelation of the effect is the best time for “selling” the effect. This is something that becomes far riskier when the method is happening in “real time.”

You'll recall the classic piece of magic advice: “Never tell the audience what is going to happen in advance.” Yet, some of the most powerful and suspenseful presentations in magic involve telling the audience what you're going to do before you do it. The key to understanding this paradox is time separation. It's true that you should never tell the audience what the effect is going to be before the *method* happens. But you can—and sometimes should—tell them before the *effect* happens. This is only possible when there is time separation so that the method is not running concurrently with the effect.

The time after the method has happened but before the effect has happened is a powerful one. One of the strongest situations in magic is

when you tell the audience what you intend to do and they respond, “No way!” little realizing that you've already done it.

Backward Time Displacement

“It ain't over till it's over.”

Yogi Berra

Mr. Berra's insightful observation notwithstanding, one of the subtlest ploys in magic is to convince the audience that it's over *before* it's over. In forward time displacement you alter the audience's perception of when the critical interval begins. In *backward time displacement* you alter their perception of when the critical interval *ends*. You make the effect appear to happen *earlier than it really did*.

The strength of backward time displacement comes from exploiting the *most fundamental* belief about causality: cause precedes effect. With

backward time displacement we turn this universal truth against the audience. The cause happens *after* the effect. If the message of forward time displacement is *nothing has happened yet*, the message of backward time displacement is *its already over and you missed it*.

Backward time displacement is not as broadly applicable as forward time displacement. But when you find the right spot for it, it can create miracles. Here again, although applying the technique requires ingenuity, stating the principle is easy. You make the audience believe the magic has already happened. *Then* you perform the secret move that causes the magic to happen.

Psychological Surrender

In every strong magic effect there is a moment when the audience psychologically surrenders. However inexplicable the effect, they are forced to accept that you did succeed in doing it. Not surprisingly, most of the time you have to actually achieve the effect before the audience accepts that

you've achieved the effect. If, however, you can trick them into thinking that you've achieved it before you really have, you can attack *after* the audience has surrendered. You can do the dirty work after the audience drops its guard. Best of all, if you do it right, they will never suspect that you really won the battle after they ran up the white flag,

A classic example is the brilliant Fred Kaps/Bruno Hennig *Card in Ring Box*. The performer places a small ring box in full view. He then has a card selected, signed, and returned to the deck. The performer now places the deck aside and picks up the ring box. He opens it to reveal that the signed selection is folded up inside.

The moment the audience sees the folded card, they believe that the magic has happened. The performer has somehow succeeded in getting the selected card inside the box under the most impossible conditions. The inner reality is that, the performer hasn't yet gotten the card into the box. In fact, the selected card is never in the box at *any* point in the effect. The card the audience sees in the box is a dummy. In the process of seeming to remove the card from the box, the performer switches it for the real selected card that he has folded and finger-palmed. This switch, the central move in making the magic happen, occurs *after* the audience thinks the magic has happened.

Dan Garrett does a beautiful effect in which he produces an egg from clearly empty hands. He then cracks it open into a glass to show that it

is real. In actuality, he produces a sponge rubber egg that he had palmed. When he reaches for the glass, he switches the sponge egg for the real egg that he then cracks open, I've left out numerous details that make this effect great. The important point here, however, is that he doesn't produce the egg until *after* he has produced the "egg." You couldn't ask for less heat on a switch. Furthermore, there is no chance that anyone will hit on the truth in retrospect.

Because the spectator believes in antecedence—cause precedes effect—he simply won't look for the solution to the mystery after he saw the card in the box or the egg appear from nowhere. He will only seek an explanation

somewhere *before* the box was opened or the egg produced. Since there is none to find, he must conclude that he witnessed a miracle.

Case Study: Carlyle's Homing Card

Another classic example of backward time displacement is the first phase of Francis Carlyle's *Homing Card*. The performer has a card selected, signed, and returned to the deck. He then announces that he will make the card travel to his pocket. After a magical gesture, he shows his hand empty and reaches into his pocket. Pulling a card partway out, he glances at its face and names the card. When the spectator confirms that this was, indeed, his card, the performer removes it so that the spectator can verify his signature. (The trick also contains a terrific repeat phase that we've already discussed.)

What makes this a miracle is the fact that the performer's hand is unmistakably empty when he reaches in to pull out the card. But its only empty *the first time* he reaches in his pocket. That time he pulls out a dummy card previously hidden in the pocket. When he glimpses its face, he miscalls it as the card he forced on the spectator. This force card is a near match to the pocketed card. (For example, if the force card is the seven of clubs, the pocketed card is the eight of clubs.) Therefore, the performer can flash a portion of its face before pushing it back into his pocket.

At this point the audience concludes that the performer has succeeded in making the card travel to his pocket invisibly. The evidence seems compelling. They saw a card partially emerge from the pocket. They saw enough of its face to see that its identity (apparently) matches that of the selection. This is confirmed when the performer glances at the card and names it. Everyone believes that the magic has already happened.

It's only now that the performer palms the selection off the top of the deck and apparently removes it from his pocket. This seems almost an afterthought just for the formality of verifying the signature. Most of the method occurs *after* the effect has happened—at least after it's happened in the spectator's minds.

Case Study: Oral Hygiene

Some years ago, as an exercise, I created a version of the Card to Mouth effect that I dubbed Oral Hygiene. It relies largely on backward time displacement for its success. I'll explain it here, not only for the benefit of any who may care to perform it but, more importantly, to illustrate how you can creatively apply the principles in this book to develop new, highly deceptive performance material. I believe it contains lessons even for those who, like me, are not fans of the Card-to-Mouth plot.

In your right pants pocket, have a card folded back outward into eighths. This card should match the deck you're using. Also have a marking pen in the same pocket. Have a handkerchief in a different pocket. Take out the pen, finger-palming the folded dummy card, and drop the pen on the table.

Explain that people sometimes accuse you of talking during tricks in order to distract them. Therefore, you'll perform this entire effect without uttering a word. To illustrate this comment, cover your mouth with your hand and perform the classic zippering-it-shut gesture that parents and teachers often use with children. In the process, load the dummy card into your mouth. You will perform the rest of the effect in silence. You'll convey any instructions to the spectator through pantomime,

Spread the deck face up and have a card selected. Have the spectator sign the face of the card. Insert the selection face up into the middle of the facedown deck. Spread the deck to show the selection, at the same time spread-culling it to bottom. (Alternatively, you can catch a break below the card as you insert it and perform a pass to bring it to the bottom.)

Perform Tommy Wonder's card fold. This leaves the selected card folded in eighths back outward. Keep the card finger-palmed in the left hand under the deck. With your right hand, remove the handkerchief from your pocket and drop it on the table.

Perform any magic gesture. Ribbonspread the cards and point to the center of the deck with your right hand to indicate that the selected card has vanished. Point to your mouth and push the dummy card out so that

it protrudes between your lips. Reach up with your left hand to remove the card from your mouth. Actually, you push the dummy card back into

your mouth as you produce the finger-palmed card.

Use the handkerchief to unfold the card—a touch that the more fastidious in your audience will appreciate. Have the identity and signature verified by the spectator. Crumple the card inside the handkerchief. Wipe your mouth with the handkerchief, secretly spitting the dummy card into it. To clean up, pocket the handkerchief and its contents.

It doesn't require any analysis on the audience's part to appreciate the impossibility of the effect. The card traveled from the deck to your mouth. The deck never approached your mouth. Your hands never approached your mouth. Nothing ever approached your mouth (the no-contact condition). Therefore, the card couldn't have traveled to your mouth. Yet, it did. It adds up to a miracle that can be grasped instantly and instinctively by anyone.

Backward Time Displacement Methodology

The Dummy:

Interestingly, the dummy principle that works so well for shifting time forward is also useful in shifting time backward. A dummy allows you to have an object in two places at once. That means that it can be somewhere *before* it's there. The *Homing Card*, *Card in Ring Box*, and *Oral Hygiene* all convince the audience that the effect has happened before it really has by passing off a dummy card as the selected card. *After* the audience has mistaken the dummy for the selection, you switch the dummy for the selection.

This idea can be applied to many translocation effects, In **Carneycopia**, John Carney has an excellent trick called *Seconds On Jack Sandwich* that uses this idea in a sandwich plot. In the cleanest possible manner, a selected card buried in the deck appears between two jacks lying on the table. In reality, the card that the audience initially *sees* between the jacks is a dummy. Only after the audience *sees* this card and assumes that it is the selection does the performer load the palmed selection between the jacks, (In fact, the entire Carney trick is structured *exactly* like the Carlyle trick. Even aside from the inherent merits of Carney's effect, it's worth studying

as an example of how principles can be extracted from one plot and applied to another.)

Mimicked Sounds:

Just as a mimicked sound can be used to suggest that “nothing has happened,” it can be used to suggest that “it’s already happened.” Peter Kane published a wonderful little effect called *The Ring in the Card Case*. A borrowed finger ring vanishes from the performer’s hand and appears in a card box that has been lying on the table. The secret is that most wonderful of magic principles, a hole cut in the container. The subtlety that really *sells* the effect, however, is that the box also has a rattle gimmick built into it. Shake it and you get a sound similar to what you would expect if it contained a ring.

After vanishing the ring, the performer draws attention to the box. This already plants in the audience’s mind the thought that the ring may be inside. With an obviously empty hand, he picks up the box and shakes it. The audience hears the rattle, confirming their suspicion that the ring is inside. Only after the audience has psychologically accepted that the ring is already in the box does the other hand containing the palmed ring load it through the hole in the underside of the box.

Transpositions And Translocations:

When audiences see a good performance of the *Metamorphosis* illusion, they believe that the effect happens extremely fast. This is because they think that the effect happens when the assistant disappears and the magician appears in her place.

Strictly speaking, the effect does end at that point. But the *method dots* not. While the magician is raking his applause, unlocking the padlocks, removing the chains from the trunk, and opening the trunk, the assistant is completing the method. She is sneaking inside the trunk and then inside the sack and, in some cases, even changing costume.

When people see a transposition effect, they believe that the entire transposition is over when the first half is revealed. As soon as they see the

magician, they assume that the assistant is already in the trunk inside the sack *If he is where she was, she must now be where he was*. The rest of the effect is just a matter of confirming what everyone already believes. As this example shows, that assumption may allow you to perform part of the method *after* the effect has concluded in the minds of the audience.

This concept is just as applicable to close-up. *Oil and Water* is at heart a transposition effect. In my routine, at the climax, the black cards can be shown cleanly. However, the red cards below them still require a secret

move to rearrange them. As soon as the audience *sees* the black cards, they believe the effect is over. Therefore, there is no heat when I make the necessary adjustments to the red cards.

Like transposition effects, translocations are often revealed in two steps. First you show that the object has vanished from point A. Then you show that it has arrived at point B.

In **Scams Fantasies with Cards** I published an effect called *Triple Cross*. It's a version of the Cards Across plot using ten red cards and ten black cards. Three cards travel from the red packet to the black packet. Part of what makes it seem impossible is that the red cards end up distributed throughout the black packet. This seems to eliminate any possibility that the three cards were simply palmed across. In fact, it seems to eliminate any explanation.

After the gesture that signals the magic, the first spectator counts the red packet and finds only seven cards. I verify the count by dealing the cards face up. The second spectator counts the black packet and finds thirteen cards. The audience doesn't know it but, at this point, the three red cards are on the bottom of the black packet. Once again, I verify the count by dealing the cards face up. In the process, I execute three stud bottom deals at various points. These have the effect of distributing the three red cards among the ten black cards.

In all these examples, part of the dirty work happens in the act of merely confirming what the audience believes has *already* happened. This allows you to embellish and improve the final result.

Acting:

Keep in mind that, as important as technical devices are, they need to be supported by your own conviction, communicated to the audience, that the effect is over (before it's over),

One of the strongest effects in Juan Tamariz's book **Mnemonica** is *Mnemonicosis*. This triple location is based on the concept of Vernon's *Trick that Can't be Explained*. What baffles both magicians and laypeople is that it's obvious that Juan couldn't have controlled the selections. He doesn't have to. He simply *asks* each spectator what card he chose before he finds it.

So how come even magicians don't realize that they themselves are giving him the one piece of information he needs to find their card? Because he *acts* as if he has already divined and strategically positioned their card

before he asks what it is. He conveys through his attitude that the trick is over before he casually asks what card the person selected. Just as Allerton acted as if the trick hadn't started yet, Tamariz acts as if it's as good as finished. In his book, Juan emphasizes the importance of such techniques. He writes, "I don't think anyone will ever be able to stress the importance of these psychological, or behavioral, subtleties too strongly. I find them more deceptive than the most exquisite manipulative method or the most ingenious trickery."

I have an unpublished effect in which a spectator names a number and I divine the card at that number. To verify the divination, I write the card's name on a business card. When the spectator first names the number, I concentrate intently. After a moment, I relax and announce that I've received the card's identity. I then reach for the business card to write it down.

In fact, I have no idea what the card is until I reach for the business card. That's when I perform the necessary glimpse. By conveying the notion that I know the card before I really know it, I avoid any heat on the glimpse.

The audience isn't looking for a move because they think it's all over. Writing down the information is just a formality.

In **The Artful Mentalism of Bob Cassidy**, there is a book test that goes even further. Cassidy starts calling out the letters in the chosen word before he has any idea what the word is. Once again, the method is based on a peek (in this case performed under cover of riffling through the book). The act of calling out letters before doing the peek is a bluff, but an important part of disguising the method. As Cassidy writes, “Remember, though, it should appear as if you know the word before you do the final riffle. [The riffle] should seem to be a mere afterthought designed to accentuate the difficulty of the test.”

In each of these examples, the main tool for achieving backward time displacement is nothing more than your acting ability. The audience believes the effect has already happened simply because you act as if it's already happened. But even in effects that use technical devices such as dummies or sound, acting plays a role in pulling off the con.

Earlier I mentioned Peter Kane's excellent *Ring in the Card Case*, which uses a rattle device to create the impression that the ring is in the case before it is. Kane says this of the moment after you've shaken the box but *before* you've loaded the ring, “Your whole attitude should convey this feeling as if the effect is practically over.”

Technical mastery is important here. If you're performing Carlyle's *Homing Card* and you're sweating bullets over the top palm that you're going to have to do in a moment, you'll never convince people that the trick is over. If you're performing Hennig's *Card in Ring Box* and thinking, “My God, I'll never get away with this shuttle pass,” you probably won't be able to convey the notion that the magic has already happened.

If you do have complete confidence in your ability to perform the technical requirements deceptively, the next step is to *believe* that you've already brought the effect to a successful conclusion. It requires only the most rudimentary acting skills. Convince yourself and you'll convince the audience.

I mentioned earlier that a magic gesture can provide a focus for your acting. I remember, many years ago, seeing Al Schneider perform what was then a novel coin effect called *Matrix*. At the start of each phase, he would gesture with both hands—with his entire body really—as if willing the coin to travel from one spot to the other. It was similar to the body language you see in bowlers who are trying to will the ball to shift to the right or left as it rolls down the lane. It was so compelling that you felt that the coin was moving in accordance with this action. Lifting the cards just confirmed what one expected, that the coin had traveled across.

In reality, of course, lifting the cards didn't confirm the effect. It caused it. The pickup move was the key sleight in the effect. Yet, there was little heat on it because, psychologically, it came *after* the audience felt that the effect had already happened. All of this resulted from convincingly acting a magic gesture.

Backward Time Displacement and Intensity Misdirection

In **Strong Magic**, I talked about two kinds of misdirection. In directional misdirection you make the audience look over there while you do something over here. In intensity misdirection, however, the spectators don't look away; they just watch less closely. As a result, they see less. One advantage of backward time displacement is that it automatically generates intensity misdirection.

In the *Card To Ring Box*, when you open the box and the audience sees the folded card, they believe that you've already succeeded and relax their attention. That's when you perform the shuttle pass that is the key to the method. In Carlyle's *Homing Card*, when the audience *sees* you pull the dummy card partially out of your pocket, they conclude that you somehow

succeeded in sneaking the selection into your pocket right under their noses. They let down their guard, allowing you to sneak the selection into your pocket right under their noses. In Dan Garrett's trick, when the audience sees the egg appear at your fingertips, their focus turns inward to wonder at the miracle they've seen, not outward to guard against the switch you're about to perform,

In each case, because they believe that the effect has already happened, the spectators relax their vigilance at exactly the moment that you perform the central move. This is a bonus byproduct of this kind of effect design worth keeping in mind.

Time Displacement and Sleights

Where the Dirty Work Happens

This book is about the design of effects rather than the design of moves. Yet, considerations of time displacement pervade every aspect of magic. That's why I think it's worth taking a few moments to see how it can provide an insight into how sleights deceive or fail to do so. Just as effects have a critical interval, in many moves there is a critical moment. This is where the audience feels, "if he's going to do something, now is when he is going to do it." I've already given as an example the moment immediately after a selected card is returned to the deck. Moves in which the cheating occurs *before* or *after* this critical moment are often particularly deceptive.

In a typical multiple shift, you insert the four aces into the deck, leaving them outjogged. It's what you do next that the audience will scrutinize most closely. In the classic Vernon multiple shift, you go straight from this condition into a Hindu shuffle to control the aces. I've always thought that the Neal Elias shift was a more deceptive approach. You square the aces cleanly into the deck. This convinces the audience that all is fair and makes them drop their guard. Only then do you perform the strip-out cut that controls the aces to the top. The cheating happens after the critical moment has passed. (Andrew Wimhurst delays the moment still further. By employing his fan subtlety idea, he can fan the deck and then close the fan after squaring the aces and before performing the strip-out cut.)

For the right situation, the Veesser/Dingle bluff multiple shift may be the most deceptive of all. You insert the aces into different parts of the deck, leaving them outjogged. After the audience has registered that they are, in fact, well separated, you square them cleanly into the deck. There can be no question that the cards are legitimately squared. At that point,

the move is actually finished except for giving the deck a legitimate cut (You also have the option of delaying the cut as long as you wish for a little time misdirection.) In fact, the bluff shift is based on a switch of sorts, so that the move is virtually over before you even finish outjogging the aces. The Elias shift does the dirty work *after* the critical moment so that the audience has had a chance to relax its guard. The bluff shift does the dirty work *before* the critical moment so that the audience is not yet on guard. Both are superior to the Vernon shift, which does the dirty work *during* the critical moment when the audience is most on guard.

The Zarrow shuffle is one of the great innovations in modern card magic and is extremely deceptive. As many magicians have proven, it often deceives even when performed very poorly. But I've always felt that for an effect like *Triumph* where emphasis needs to be placed on the shuffle itself—its thoroughness, etc.—that a push-through or strip-out shuffle is superior. The critical moment in a riffle shuffle comes when the cards are pushed together. Having performed *Triumph* countless times over many years, I've noted that, once the cards are pushed together and squared, the audience always relaxes its attention. In the audience's mind, the shuffle has reached the point of no return. The strength of the push-through and strip-out shuffles is that they do the dirty work after that critical moment. By contrast, the Zarrow requires you to do the dirty work right at that moment. That's why it would not be my first choice for an effect like *Triumph* where the thoroughness of the shuffle is a selling point.

Where the Move Happens

“The resourceful professional finding a way to improve the method changes the moment; and by this expedient overcomes the principal obstacle in the way of accomplishing the action unobserved.”

S.W. Erdnase,
The Expert at the Card Table

Most magicians don't appreciate how context sensitive sleights are. One of the classic effects in card magic is the *Stop Trick* where you deal until the spectator tells you to stop and you then reveal that the selected card is at exactly that spot. Some argue that a bottom deal is a better method for this

effect than a second deal because it requires you to do fewer sleights. With a second deal, you have to keep false dealing until the spectator says stop. With a bottom deal, you can deal legitimately until the spectator stops you and then do just one false deal. It's a case of perhaps a dozen or more

false deals versus one. What this analysis ignores is the matter *of when* the moves occur.

If you've done this effect, you've probably noted that it's once the spectator calls “stop” that the audience really focuses on the cards. With a bottom deal you have to do the move at that moment. With a second deal, you can cleanly deal the stopped-at card off the top. You can even, as I do, let the spectator take the card off the deck himself. A well-executed bottom deal will fool the audience even if performed at this moment of maximum scrutiny, but it doesn't allow that cleanliness of handling. This shows how you can't compare sleight of hand by the pound. *One move at the wrong moment may be worse than ten at the right moment.*

The last example showed how you could change the moment by using a different sleight. However, creative thinking can sometimes allow you to use the same move for the same task, yet change the moment for the better. One of the problems with the Mexican turnover is that it usually comes at the worst possible moment. It happens when the audience is focused on the tabled card, eager to find out its identity. It's also the moment when the audience instinctively feels that, if you're going to do something, this is when you're going to do it. In **Sonata**, Juan Tamariz explains an extremely clever method of getting around the problem. Before drawing attention to the tabled card, he tries to turn it over with the card in his hand. But he fumbles and has to try again. When he does succeed in turning over the card, it's as clean and fair as could be desired. In reality, he did the switch during the “accidental” fumble, allowing a fair turnover a moment later.

Erdrase's quote above refers specifically to shifting the cut in card game. As he explains, the challenge is that, “the object of a shift is well known, and especially the exact moment to expect it, immediately after the cut.” For this move, “immediately after the cut” is the critical moment. His solution: “The dealer holds the location of the cut [with a pinky break] until the hands are dealt, and makes the shift as he lays down the deck. Then the

desired cards can be dealt from the bottom during the next deal.” In other words, having performed the shift long after even the most vigilant player would expect it, you can now exploit it when dealing draw cards or dealing subsequent rounds at stud. (Today, you could use this approach to control the board cards at Texas hold'em.) The underlying concept is just as valid in magic. Any move becomes safer if you do it when, in Erdnase's words, “there is less cause for close scrutiny.”

Finally, to round out how time considerations relate to sleights, I suggest you go back and look at the discussion of time misdirection.

The question of which sleight to choose for a particular job is a complex one. It depends on many factors, including how well you perform a given move. I'm not suggesting that time displacement should be the only consideration. It is, however, an important factor to consider. Being sensitive to that factor will help you think about sleight of hand analytically rather than in the fuzzy manner so common in magic.

To sum up this chapter, apply the tools we've discussed and you'll be able to do the dirty work before the critical interval or after the critical interval. Your reward will be astonished spectators exclaiming, “But he didn't do anything!”

Chapter Five: Spatial Distance

On one of Tommy Wonders DVDs, he performs three versions of the *Borrowed Watch to Nest of Boxes*. If you want to do this effect, you're faced with an embarrassment of riches. Each version is so clever in conception and ingenious in detail that picking one could be a challenge. Trying to compare and evaluate all the intricate aspects of their methods could easily overwhelm you.

If, however, you appreciate the importance of proximity, the comparison becomes easier. The first version, as clever as it is, requires the performer to be near the box for what seems like an eternity. Through most of the long handling, the performer is *close* to the box and the spectator is *far* from it. This is the opposite of the ideal. In the second version, the performer

handles the box, but more briefly. In the third, he never touches the box or even comes all that close to it. Wonder underscores this with his patter: “I haven't been near that box. I haven't touched it. And I'm not going to touch it.”

That's why the second version is stronger than the first and the third is stronger than the second. Not surprisingly, this is also the order in which Tommy Wonder created them. The third, no-contact version is the one he preferred. The development of Wonder's versions is an evolution toward *distance*.

In **Totem and Taboo**, Sigmund Freud observes that, in magic (the real kind), “distance plays no part.” A magic spell will be just as effective no matter how far away the individual being targeted is. No doubt, the reason that he thought this worth commenting on is that it isn't true anywhere except in magic. And everyone knows that instinctively

Remember David Roth's observation? “Once you open your left hand to show that the coin is gone, the spectators will look at the other hand.” *Why* do they think the coin is in your other hand? Why don't they suspect that it's in your mouth or your ear? Because your left hand was never near your mouth or your ear. It was, however near your other hand. When seeking causality, people always look nearby. To defeat this universal tendency, we'll now consider how to build a *spatial wall* between method and effect.

Positioning Effect and Method in Space

Overcoming the tip-off of contiguity (physical contact) is the central challenge in constructing a deceptive magic effect. Each of the basic effects in magic has a contiguity problem. In a *transposition*, the problem is the need for contact between the objects that will change places. In a *translocation*, it's contact between the object that will travel and the place it will eventually travel to (i.e., violating the no-contact condition discussed in **Strong Magic**). In a *production*, it's contact with the point of the steal. In a *vanish*, it's contact with the point of the ditch (e.g., the sleeve, the topit, the table edge). In a *transformation*, it's contact between the two object! being secretly exchanged. (The card and the deck must touch during a top change. The copper coin and the silver coin must almost touch in *Spell-bound*).

In each case, contiguity can provide a clue to the method unless you take steps to camouflage it. This leads to a fundamental goal in strong effect **design**: *separate effect and method in space*.

The first step is to analyze the effect you're working on from two perspectives. First, identify the *locus of the method* (where the key element of the method happens). Second, identify the *locus of the effect* (where the magic happens in the minds of the audience). It's only after you've clearly positioned the method and the effect in space that you can strive to interpose distance between them.

Time and Space

Spatial distance and temporal distance are linked because you can't flee the scene of the crime unless you have enough *time* to do so. You can have temporal distance without spatial distance (as the previous chapters examples show). But you can't have spatial distance without temporal distance. Separating effect and method in time gives you the *opportunity* to separate them in space.

In a sense, spatial distance is an added subtlety that you can graft onto temporal distance. Any time you succeed in achieving some temporal distance, the next question you should ask yourself is, "How can I use this time to put some space between the locus of the method and the locus of the effect?"

We saw last chapter how the use of a form in the *Vanishing Radio* allows the magician to perform the effect of the vanish (whisking the cloth

away) several moments after the method (collapsing the radio down into the tabletop). However, the great time delay this clever method allows would be largely wasted if the performer failed to do one important thing: walk away from the table. Typically, he walks all the way to the edge of the stage before revealing the vanish. The method happens upstage; the effect happens downstage. When people wonder, "Where did the radio go?" They won't be looking all the way back there for the answer,

Removing the Evidence

In **Conjurers' Psychological Secrets**, S. H. Sharpe explains a valuable concept that he calls “removing the evidence” Sharpe's example is the *Asrah* illusion. A woman lies on a couch. The magician covers her with a sheet. He then causes her draped form to float up into the air. Higher and higher she rises. Suddenly the performer whips the sheet away. The woman is gone, vanished in midair.

The secret is that, as soon as the sheet covers the woman, she drops into a hidden compartment in the couch. A wire form supports the sheet. (You'll recall that forms are one of the primary types of time displacement devices.) Invisible wires pull the form into the air as the assistants wheel the couch offstage with the woman inside. When the performer whips the sheet away, the wire form is invisible against the black backdrop and the miracle is complete.

Sharpe makes the point that, as clever as this effect is, if the couch were left on stage, the moment the woman vanished, the audience would suspiciously turn its attention toward it. The couch in this effect is like the “other hand” in a coin vanish. It's the last place the vanished object/ person was seen, so it's the first place they'll suspect. At least it would be were it not for one important point. When the vanish occurs, the couch is nowhere to be seen. The couch is never suspected because you remove the evidence *after* the method happens but long *before* the effect happens. It's a case of “out of sight, out of mind.”

This is the principle of “removing the evidence” *ensure that, by the time the magic happens, the device necessary to make it happen is no longer in sight*. This, of course, applies only in cases where a *device* is used to achieve the effect. When it is, however, removing the evidence is the ultimate application of separating method and effect in space. There is so much space between the two that, when the latter occurs, the former is out of view.

Stage illusionists use this idea all the time. Their assistants are forever, quietly wheeling away objects in the background that are secretly responsible for the effect that will soon occur. By the time the magician vanishes, the set of stairs he sneaked into is no longer on stage. Even the *Vanishing Radio* benefits from having an assistant wheel away the table

while the audience still believes that the radio is under the cloth that the magician is holding.

But you don't need an army of assistants to employ this concept. It applies just as much to close-up magic. Numerous close-up mental effects involve using some kind of impression device or peek wallet to secretly obtain information. All of them benefit from removing the evidence. It will be that much more amazing if you stick your Thought Transmitter back in your pocket before reading the spectator's mind.

I first came to appreciate the value of removing the evidence many years ago when I began performing *Darwin's Wild Card*, later published in **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**. I've always followed the practice of carrying the Wild Card set in a mini-Himber wallet. The other compartment contains a matching ungaffed packet. At the end of the effect, I replace the cards in the wallet. As an afterthought, I then remove the cards and give them to a spectator as a souvenir. (Of course, they really get the ungaffed set.) Having just seen these cards undergo a truly amazing transformation, the spectator will sometimes look them over for a few moments.

One of the first times I performed the routine, the spectator scrutinized the cards carefully. She then pointed to the Himber wallet lying on the table and asked if she could examine it. After that I always placed the wallet in my pocket as soon as I removed the switched-in packet of cards and before I handed them to the spectator. In thousands of subsequent performances the problem never arose again.

Many years later I devised an effect that uses a mini-Himber wallet to make a card vanish from a sealed envelope (*Appointment in Samarra*, **Scams Fantasies with Cards**). Having learned my lesson, I always cover my tracks by putting the wallet in my pocket before I tear apart the envelope to reveal the vanish. When the magic happens, the wallet is out of sight and out of mind. All of the heat is on the envelope, which is ordinary, rather than on the wallet, which is not.

In **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**, I also published an effect called *Do as I Did*. The spectator secretly reverses a card in the deck. This proves to

match a card that I had previously reversed in another deck. The spectator's deck is ordinary. Mine is an Ultra-Mental Deck. When I reveal a

card face down in my deck, I remove it and place it, still face down, on the table I then put the gaffed deck back in my pocket. Only then do I spread the spectator's deck and remove the card she reversed. The audience experiences the magic a few moments later when the two matching cards are turned over. By then, the gaffed deck responsible for that magic is nowhere to be seen.

Earlier I discussed the Kaps/Hennig *Card in Ring Box* as a beautiful example of backward time displacement. A while back someone marketed a version with a box gaffed in such a way that it could be shown empty at the end. This is an example of something often seen in magic, a clever solution to a non-existent problem. In the many years, and literally thousands of times, that I've performed this effect, I've never had anyone express a desire to look inside the box after I removed the folded card. Of course, I always pocket the box with one hand as I hand the folded card to a spectator to unfold with my other hand. If I didn't take the precaution of *removing the evidence*, I'd be needlessly tempting fate.

You'll find more opportunities to apply this concept if you define *device* broadly and creatively. In **Scams Fantasies with Cards**, I have a two-card transposition called *Ace in the Pocket*. It uses the classic approach of a duplicate card and two double lifts. The duplicate card can be considered the device that makes the effect possible. More broadly, however, the deck itself is the device since it permits both the double lifts and the introduction of a duplicate.

Here is how I apply the “removing the evidence” principle to it. After the two cards have been shown and placed in their assigned locations, I casually drop the deck in my pocket. (This looks like a matter of convenience since I usually perform this effect away from any tables. Its real motivation, however, is strategic.) I now dramatically cause the two cards to change places. At the magical climax, the only props in sight are the two transposed cards. This subtly conveys the notion that the trick involved two cards and nothing else. As long as the audience perceives it that way they have no hope of penetrating the mystery.

Removing the evidence is a simple concept that is easy to overlook or underestimate. But there are many situations where you can further protect an effect's secret just by casually dropping a prop in your pocket at the right moment.

Secret Transfer

There are many tricks where the effect is that an object travels magically from one place to another. (*Ring Flight* and Carlyle's *Homing Card* are two well-known examples.) However, secretly transporting an object from one place to another can be used as an aspect of *method even* when it has nothing to do with the *effect*.

There is an old effect in which the performer puts his pen away in his inner jacket pocket. A moment later the pen has magically rematerialized in his hand. The secret is simple. When the magician pretends to place the pen in his pocket, he actually drops it into the armhole of his jacket. It falls down his sleeve into his other hand where a moment later it seems to appear magically. Years ago I applied this idea to Al Koran's *Gold Medallion*. The Koran trick uses the principle of double writing. The spectators choose a number, which the performer openly records on a pad of paper. At the same time he secretly writes the number on the back of a medallion that he has palmed. He then reaches into his pocket, loads the palmed medallion into a box, and removes them to reveal his prediction. My idea was as follows. After writing the number openly on the pad (and secretly on the medallion), you place the pen in your inner right jacket pocket. At the same time, drop the palmed medallion down your sleeve. Keep your right arm bent so that the medallion stops at the elbow. Hand the pad to a spectator and make some gesture that allows both hands to be seen empty. Then drop your right arm to the side so the medallion falls into your curled fingers. Now reach into your pants pocket, load the medallion into the box, and remove the box to reveal your prediction.

The sleeve provides a chute to secretly transfer the medallion from the left hand to the right hand. In the process, you can show both hands empty. When you reveal the prediction, no one can suspect that you wrote it just a moment before because there is no way it could have gotten from your hands to your pocket, (Incidentally, In **Al Koran's Legacy**, author Hugh

Miller reveals that Koran himself had a version of this trick in which he had a secret chute sewn into his jacket that allowed him to load the palmed medallion into his outer breast pocket and remove it from his inner breast pocket.) Notice that transporting the medallion from one place to the other is not part of the *effect* (as it is in *Ring Flight* for example). Its sole purpose is to help conceal the *method*.

Like double writing, pocket writing is a classic way of producing predictions. The performer has a pencil stub and a piece of paper in his pants

pocket. With his hand in his pocket, he secretly records the spectator's choice. Later he presents the paper as a prediction, supposedly written before the performance.

If, however, the performer was to just pull the paper out of his pants pocket and hand it to someone to read, the audience would have a good chance of guessing the secret. A much better approach is to palm the paper and pretend to remove it from the inner jacket pocket. The method happens in one pocket; the effect is produced from another pocket. A simple secret transfer by means of palming provides the distance needed to protect the secret.

If you want to be really subtle, you can incorporate a gaff created by Stew Bedwell. This is a chute that leads from your inner left jacket pocket to your outer left pocket. Anything dropped in the former ends up in the latter. After you've finished your secret writing, fold the paper in your pocket. Palm it as before. Reach into your inner jacket pocket under some pretext, perhaps to remove a pen or a pair of glasses clipped there. As you do so, drop the billet down the chute. You can now have a spectator reach into your outer left jacket pocket and remove the prediction. There is simply no way that the audience will associate anything that went on in your right pants pocket with a prediction that a spectator removes from your left jacket pocket. That's the power of secret transfer.

Del Ray used to feature the classic *Glass Through Table*. But, when he did it, the glass didn't penetrate the cable. It simply vanished. A moment later, Del Ray produced it from his pocket. After lapping the glass, he

would slam his hand down on the empty paper form. He would then crumple the paper between his hands, emphasizing the disappearance of the glass. As the audience recovered from the shock, he dropped his hand to his lap and grabbed the glass. He then brought it up under his jacket and appeared to remove it from his inner jacket pocket.

Making the glass penetrate the table is subtle because the method happens at the edge of the table but the effect happens at the center of the table. Making the glass vanish and appear in your pocket, however, is even subtler. The method in this effect is lapping. Producing the glass from the pocket moves things farther away from the lap than does the traditional penetration version.

Your jacket in this case acts much like your sleeve in the medallion trick or the pocket chute in the pocket writing effect. Each allows a secret conveyance that moves the final revelation away from the scene of the crime: your cupped fingers, your pants pocket, or your lap.

Shifting Location of Revelation

When Slydini did his revolve coin vanish, he would begin with the palm-up hand at the table edge. He would revolve the hand palm down, lapping the coin and closing his hand into a fist. In a continuing action, he would move his fist to the center of the table and make the coin penetrate the tabletop. The method happened at the table edge, but the revelation of the effect happened at table center.

If, instead, Slydini had caused the penetration of the coin to happen near the table edge, he would have fooled few people no matter how perfectly he executed the move. Most magicians, I think, can immediately see the validity of that claim. They may even think it so obvious as not to be worth commenting on. What many don't appreciate is that the underlying principle—doing the move one place but revealing the results elsewhere—can strengthen countless other effects.

As with the earlier concept of delayed revelation, this is an area where design meets presentation. Consider two different ways of transforming a card using a double turnover. In the first case, you turn over the double to

reveal a king. You turn the double face down. You now take the top card into your other hand. Holding it right next to the deck, you snap the corner of the card. Still holding it within an inch or two of the deck, you turn it over to reveal that k has changed to an ace,

In the second case, you turn over the double to reveal a king. You turn the double face down. You take the top card in your other hand. You rub it against the tabletop. You then turn it over to reveal that it has changed to an ace.

On the surface, the two sequences seem identical. In the first case, however, the effect occurs two or three inches from the deck. In the second case, it occurs two or three feet from the deck. The reason this matters is that the *method* (a double turnover) occurs *on* the deck. The more distance you put between effect and method, the more you stretch and attenuate the causal thread linking the two. Therefore, the harder it becomes for the spectator to trace that thread back to its source.

If you mistakenly believe that the average layperson painstakingly tries to reconstruct effects step by step the way the average magician does, you'll think that I'm making a great deal out of nothing. If you appreciate the instinctive, intuitive manner in which laypeople pick up clues to causality, you'll appreciate how much more deceptive the second approach is.

In my gambling act, when discussing bottom dealing, I show how I can control four queens to the bottom despite a spectator cutting the deck. The method is as follows. I openly insert the queens into different parts of the deck and multiple-shift them to the top. I then overhand shuffle them to the bottom. Next I gamblers' cop the queens and hold them out at the table edge as I offer the deck to be cut. In squaring up the deck after the cut I replace the copped cards. I then lean forward on my elbows and turn the deck face up to reveal the queens on the bottom.

All of these actions have to be performed perfectly if the audience is *to* be deceived. Experience has convinced me, however, that the most important action is leaning forward on my elbows. This is what puts distance between method and effect. The essential element in the method is the gamblers' cop holdout. That takes place at the *edge* of the table. By

leaning forward as I turn the deck face up, the effect registers at the *center* of the table. During the holdout, no one knows what the effect will be, so location isn't very important. It's the revelation that's memorable, and that draws the audience away from where the dirty work happened.

One reason magicians don't use this simple but powerful idea more often is the natural tendency to focus on method rather than effect. Were so relieved to have gotten away with the secret move that we can't be bothered to think of a little detail such as where to reveal the effect.

Yet you probably already make instinctive use of this concept in some tricks. If you perform *Glass through Table*, you probably move the covered form away from the table edge before performing the vanish. If you do a chop cup routine, you probably move the cup to the center of the table before revealing the load. I'm willing to bet, however, that if you go through your repertoire, you'll find more opportunities to effectively move the location of the revelation away from the location of the method. This is the value of raising awareness of craft from the instinctive to the conscious. It allows you to apply techniques systematically rather than haphazardly.

Whether you're switching, ditching, or stealing a load, there are many cases where, after you've done the dirty work, you have a chance to flee the scene of the crime. You can move the closed hand, the facedown card, or the draped handkerchief pretty well anywhere you want before revealing that the magical effect has occurred. You should virtually always seize any opportunity to do so.

Isolation

A special case of spatial separation involves isolating the spot where the magic occurs, in *Strong Magic* I described my ending for Vernon's *Twisting the Aces*, which I titled *Twisting the Case*. The effect proceeds as in the original until you reach the point where you're about to make the final ace turn over. As in the original, you secretly reverse the last ace and then do an Elmsley count to show all four cards still face down. You then place the packet in the card case and give it a 180-degree twist. When you now spill the packet out of the case and spread it, the final ace is face up. This creates the true impossibility of a card turning over while enclosed in the card case.

The Elmsley count provides the time displacement. But you exploit, that temporal distance to create spatial distance and isolation. The method happens in your hands, as is usually the case with sleight of hand. But the effect happens in the box, apparently eliminating any possibility of sleight of hand.

Most experienced magicians know the power of magic happening in the spectator's hands. However, some effects of this kind are stronger than others. A key factor is how convincing it is that the magic must have happened while the object was in the spectator's hands and *not before*. Like most things in magic, this can only be established by a process of elimination. If you can prove that it didn't happen before the object went into her hand, it must have happened *while* it was in her hand.

Time displacement devices are invaluable in this situation. Show the initial condition. Secretly change it to the final condition. Use the displacement device to show that the initial condition has not changed. Then place the prop in the spectator's hand. A moment later, she opens her hand to discover that the magic has happened. It must have happened in her hands. There is no alternative.

Time displacement will often allow you to take an effect to the next level, that of isolation. You just have to look for ways to do it. I've already mentioned my effect *Beyond Sleight of Hand*, which uses the ribbonspread hideout to delay the revelation of a card sandwich. It wasn't until a couple of years after I published it that I realized that I could make it an in-the-spectators-hands effect.

As in the original, I ribbonspread the deck to show the red jacks face up in the middle, seemingly with no card in between. I now have the spectator gather up the spread by placing one hand on either side. I instruct her to

finish squaring up the deck as it lies on the table. Finally. I have her pick it up and hold it between her hands, I perform a magic gesture and have the spectator table the deck, In the fairest possible manner, I ribbonspread the cards. (You can have the spectator do this part also if you prefer.) Between the jacks is a facedown card that proves to be the spectator's selection, (See also *Pass The Garbage* in **Scams Fantasies** for an effect where I use a

version of the ribbonspread hideout to cause a Triumph-type effect to happen in the spectators hands.)

Creating time displacement is good. Having the magic happen in the spectator's hands, in the card box, or in some other isolated location is even better. Always look for ways to parlay the former into the latter, A critical interval that occurs in isolation is the best proof you can give the audience that what they're witnessing goes “beyond sleight of hand.”

Producing a Distant Duplicate

In *The Stanley Collins Aces*, the performer places three cards on each ace. There is no doubt that there really is an ace on the bottom of each pile. He then changes each ace into an indifferent card. He returns the sixteen cards to the deck. He now deals out poker hands, one of which contains the aces. Or he spells to the aces or otherwise produces them from the deck.

These endings all have dramatic problems. The ace productions are long and procedure-heavy at just the point when you need a quick, snappy revelation to punctuate the effect. My concern here, however, is not with the dramatic flaw but with the *design* flaw. Before producing the aces from the deck, the magician must return the sixteen cards to the deck. This might lead a perceptive spectator to wonder whether the aces were hidden among those sixteen cards all along, (They were.) In fact, *producing an object from the same place from which it vanished is always problematic*. It suggests hiding and revealing rather than vanishing and producing.

The best ending I ever saw for the Collins trick was Jimmy Grippo's. After vanishing the aces, he simply pulled them out of his pocket and tossed them on the table. It was short, dramatic, and amazing. What made it amazing is that he had never gone near his pocket throughout the effect. As you may have guessed (especially if you knew Grippo), the method was four duplicate aces.

The Two-Out-of-Three Rule

This is a good time to discuss the most deceptive way to use duplicates. I've written elsewhere that duplicate cards is one of the three explanations

most likely to spring to a layperson's mind when watching a card trick. (The other two are a marked deck and cards in the magician's sleeve.) If a card travels from one place to another, the first thing people will suspect is that it's *not the same card*. And why shouldn't they? It's the commonsense explanation. In fact, we magicians know that this really is the easiest way to achieve this type of effect.

That's why card-to-impossible-location effects aren't worth performing unless you can conclusively eliminate the duplicate-card hypothesis from the audience's mind. If you're not using a duplicate card, the easiest way to do this is to have a spectator sign the card. If you *are* using a duplicate, however, that's not an option. So how can you use a duplicate deceptively?

I have found that you can dispense with having the card signed as long as the effect you're performing incorporates any *two* of the following three conditions:

The card in question is indisputably a *free selection*. (You couldn't have planted a duplicate of the chosen card in advance because you didn't know what card the person would choose.)

The card is shown to have vanished from its original location *prior* to showing that it's arrived at its new location. (Showing that the card has vanished creates the presumption that it must be somewhere else. When you then show that it *is* somewhere else, the audience is more inclined to believe that it's the same card.)

The location that the card eventually travels to is shown empty at the outset. (You couldn't have placed a duplicate card there ahead of time because there wasn't *any* card there,)

Suppose you have someone select a card from the deck in standard fashion. Let's assume that it's the three of clubs. You have the card returned to the deck. You now instruct the spectator to pick up the card case, which has been lying on the table. He looks inside and finds the three of clubs. *No intelligent person will believe that it's the same three of clubs.*

Suppose, instead, that you do it this way. Have a spectator pick up the card case and examine it to satisfy himself that its empty. Turn the deck face up and spread through it slowly as you ask the spectator to touch the face of any card he wishes. When he does, give him the opportunity to

change his mind. Once he has settled on a card—we'll assume it's the three of clubs—square up the deck and turn it face down. Perform a magic gesture over the cards. Then hand the deck to the spectator, instructing him to remove his card from the pack. He finds that the card is missing. With empty hands you pick up the card case that the spectator had previously examined and pull out the three of clubs.

No one will doubt that it's the same three of clubs. I don't have a method for this version. But I'm sure that, if I came up with one, no one would suspect a duplicate *despite the fact that the card is unsigned*.

This latter example incorporates all three of the conditions I listed. 1) The spectator has an indisputably free choice of a card. 2) The card case is established to be empty at the beginning of the trick. 3) The card is shown to have vanished from the deck before it's found in the card case.

You don't have to go that far, however. I once saw a sign in a printing shop that read, “Speed, Quality, Low Price. Pick any two.” The same can be said of the three conditions I listed above. Experience has shown that if you can incorporate any *two* of them into an effect you can get away with using duplicate cards unsuspected.

The first is usually the toughest one to achieve. There are, of course, many ways to force a card. But not many forces are so convincing that afterward the audience will be positive it was a free choice even in the face of strong evidence to the contrary. (And that's just what producing an unsigned card from an impossible location is). Generally, the only selection procedures that can carry that weight are having a spectator *think* of a card, *name* a card, or pick one from a *face-up* deck (complete with the option of changing his mind). If you've salted away a duplicate in an impossible location, you probably won't be able to use any of those procedures. (However, Simon Aronson's *Red See Passover* proves that sometimes you can.)

The Vanish and the Production

It's the second and third conditions that offer the most possibilities. Establishing the vanish before producing the duplicate is based on the premise that it's easier to avoid arousing suspicion than to quell it *after* it's been aroused. It's also based on the fact that the sequence in which a person receives information helps determine how he'll evaluate it. Compare the following two scenarios.

Scenario one: You have the spectator return his three of clubs to the deck. You then have him look in the card case where he finds the three of club.

This will immediately raise the question in his mind, "Is it the *same* three of clubs?" Even if you then allow the spectator to look through the deck to establish that the three of clubs is gone, this doesn't really answer the question: Is it the *same* three of clubs? Once raised, the suspicion of a duplicate will linger.

Scenario two: The spectator selects the three of clubs and returns it in the deck. You then have him look through the deck in search of his card. He finds it missing. This will immediately raise the question in his mind, "*Where* is my three of clubs?" If you now have him look in the card case to find the three of clubs, you've answered his unspoken question. His three of clubs is in the card case.

Both scenarios involve the same set of facts. But because the spectator receives those facts in a different sequence, what happens in his mind is different. (And I'm sure I don't have to remind you that the spectators mind is where the magic happens.) If you're going to use a duplicate, if at all possible, establish the vanish *before* revealing the duplicate in another location.

There are many different ways to accomplish this. One would be to palm the card out. Another would be to deal through the deck, dealing a double to conceal the selected card. (A particularly subtle approach would be to conceal the selection with the double deal method and *then* palm it out of the deck as the spectator looks inside the card case.) If you favor gaffs over sleights, there are other possibilities. You could use wax to create an

automatic double deal. Or you could use any of several gaffs that allow you to force a card that was never in the deck to begin with. Annemann's double-card gaff is one. Marlo's "Opportune Miracle" gaff is another. (I'm not going into a lot of detail on methods because I'm not concerned here with methods, but with how to apply them to achieve strong design.)

The third condition that will camouflage the use of a duplicate in a translocation effect is showing the destination (card case, pocket, etc.) empty at the outset of the effect. Later when the card is shown there, the audience can't just say, "He simply put a duplicate card there before he started."

Again there are various ways to accomplish this. In **21st Century Card Magic** Jim Swain has an excellent method for producing a duplicate card from a card case that a spectator has previously inspected and *found* empty. Similarly, the Himber wallet allows you to show your wallet empty, yet later produce a duplicate card from it.

To my mind, this is the one feature mining from Jimmy Grippo's ending for *The Stanley Collins Aces*. As good as his ending is, a skeptical spectator might dismiss it with the thought, "Those aren't the same aces. He just had four other aces in his pocket to begin with."

Suppose instead that you speak of how some card cheats like to steal the aces out of play during a game so they can switch them in later when a big pot develops. A good place to hide them, you explain, is your wallet. You can then secretly retrieve them any time under cover of getting more cash. You take out your (Himber) wallet. Show it empty and leave it on the table in full view. Perform *The Stanley Collins Aces*. After vanishing the last ace, pick up the wallet with obviously empty hands and open it to the other side to reveal the four (duplicate) missing aces.

This handling has all the dramatic benefits of Grippo's. But it also incorporates two of our key conditions. You convincingly vanish the aces *before* producing their duplicates and you start the trick by showing the wallet empty. Point A contained aces at the beginning but does not contain them at the end. Point B did not contain aces at the beginning but does contain them at the end. That combination of facts makes it easy to believe

that they're the same aces. (You could afford to eliminate one of those two conditions only if you did the trick with free selections, something that's not practical in this case.)

If you want to see these principles in action, watch Paul Gertner perform his well-known effect *Photocopy*. He first shows the folded photocopy of his hand. Clearly, it does not contain a playing card. Paul then has a card selected and vanishes it. He goes through the entire deck to show that it really is gone. Only then does he reveal that it is now within the folds of the photocopy. He both shows the destination empty at the outset and establishes the disappearance before reproducing the card. That's why the effect deceives despite the fact that the card isn't signed.

Finally, if you check out *Harry in Your Pocket* from **Cardshark**, you'll see another illustration of applying the two-out-of-three rule for effectively using a duplicate.

Subverting the Timeline

These examples illustrate an advantage of producing a distant duplicate. It allows you to load the object at point B *before* you vanish it from point A. This, of course, ties in with time displacement and the principle of antecedence. This illustrates how all these concepts are interrelated.

A number of magicians have come up with the idea of ending Vernon's *Travelers* by reversing the plot. The deck travels to the pocket, leaving the last ace behind in the performers hand. This is done through one of two methods. The performer palms the deck and pretends to remove it from pocket or he dumps the deck into a pocket under misdirection and later openly removes it. In his *Travelers Under Pressure*, Steve Ehlers shows how producing a distant duplicate can enhance this approach. After pull the first three aces from different pockets, he squashes the deck between his hands, leaving only the fourth ace. He then shows that the deck has returned to the card case that has been lying untouched on the table. The real deck ends up in his pocket. The one he produces has been in the case since the beginning.

If you wanted to stick to the theme of pulling the cards from your pockets, you could still use the distant duplicate concept. Start with the cold deck in one pocket. (This deck would, of course, be minus the aces.) The important thing is to choose a pocket that you won't be going anywhere near during the effect. In the last phase, you can either dump the deck, except for the last ace, into a side pocket under misdirection or you can palm it. In the latter case, you reach into a pocket searching for the ace. Leave the deck there and come out empty handed. Continuing to search for the ace, you reach into the pocket holding the duplicate deck and pull it out. Finally, reveal that your other hand is holding the ace.

The distant-duplicate approach offers a couple of advantages here. One is that it allows you to introduce a stacked deck in a subtle manner. More relevant to our discussion, however, it injects distance between method and effect. You ditch the deck one place; you produce it from another. Producing the deck from a location that you haven't gone anywhere near throughout the trick can only make the effect more miraculous,

Nor are these ideas limited to playing cards. In the three-shell game, the usual approach is to palm the pea out of one shell and load it under another. This violates the no-contact condition since, before the pea can travel from point A to point B, the hand has to touch point A and then point B. However skillfully the sleights are performed, the direct path is there to be seen. That's why the operator typically throws in various feints and acquitments to make the path a little less direct. This is good enough to get the money on the streets and to entertain a close-up audience. But it's not enough to create a miracle.

Let's apply the principles we've been discussing by adding a duplicate pea (an idea long used by street hustlers). The pea you've been using is in

full view and the three shells have been shown empty. Load a duplicate pea under shell number one. Then isolate this shell by placing it under a glass or other cover or by having a spectator place his finger on it. Place the visible pea under shell number two. Steal it out as you move shells number two and three around. Ditch the pea to reveal the climax, first turn over shell number two and then shell number three. Finally, have the spectator turn over shell number one to reveal the pea.

The audience would have expected the pea to be under shell number two where they saw you place it. They would have accepted its appearance under shell number three since you also came in contact with it. But there is simply no path from shell number two to shell number one that could account for the result.

Many years ago, Arthur Emerson marketed a marvelous effect called *Encased in Glass*. The performer shows an empty drinking glass. He spreads out a handkerchief and places the glass in the center. Gathering the ends of the handkerchief to form a bag, he gives it to a spectator to hold. Another spectator peeks at a card in the deck. The magician makes a magic gesture. When he now deals through the deck face up, the spectator finds that his card is gone. It is found jammed inside the drinking glass.

The selected card is forced, and later vanished, by means of Annemann's double-card gaff. A duplicate is hidden in a secret pocket in the handkerchief. In the process of wrapping the glass, the card is loaded into it.

This effect neatly illustrates the advantages of producing a distant duplicate. First, you defeat the law of *antecedence* by loading the card in the glass *before* it vanishes from the deck. Second, you *isolate* the site of the final climax by allowing a spectator to hold the wrapped glass suspended from his fist. Third, you eliminate any *causal path* for even the shrewdest spectator to uncover leading from the deck to the glass. Finally, by showing the glass empty at the outset and establishing the vanish before revealing the reappearance, you eliminate suspicions of a duplicate.

Creating False Proximity

One of the underlying premises of this book is that, if the spectator doesn't realize *when* the method happened, he'll never figure out *how* it happened. There are two sides to achieving this. The first is to prevent him from realizing that it happens when it does. The second is to make him feel that it happens when it doesn't. Interestingly, distance plays a role in both. Create the illusion of distance when the method actually happens. Create

a false proximity when you want them to feel that it happens. The belief that causality requires contiguity is so ingrained in the human mind that if

the audience sees contact, they tend to be psychologically compelled to feel that *this* is when it happened,

Consider the classic *Ring on Wand*. You appear to take the ring in your right hand. Actually, you retain it in the left. Your left hand picks up the wand, secretly threading the ring onto it. You then have a spectator hold the ends. Now your right hand, apparently holding the ring, rubs the center of the wand. When the hand moves away, the ring is on the wand. The impression is irresistible that the penetration happened at that moment.

Suppose that, instead of bringing the right hand over to the wand, you merely make a tossing motion in its direction and then move the left hand away to show the ring hanging on it. In theory, this should be even more amazing. Not only did the ring penetrate the wand, it traveled invisibly through the air to do it.

In practice, of course, this latter handling would only serve to expose the method. Everyone would realize that the ring was never in the right hand and was already on the wand before the spectator grabbed the ends. Since, you've contacted the wand only with your right hand, it must have been your right hand that threaded the ring on. That's enough to overthrow the presumption that the ring was ever in your left hand. From there it's easy to see how you could have threaded on the ring before the spectator grabbed the ends of the wand.

By contrast, in the traditional handling, contact serves to *reinforce* the belief that the ring was in your right hand rather than to subvert it. The audience instinctively feels that contiguity is necessary to thread the ring on the wand. Since the only moment when you bring the ring and wand together is when your right hand rubs the center of the wand, that must be when the threading occurs. Since this only happens after the spectator is already holding the ends of the wand, the result is a small miracle. Bringing the right fingers down on the center of the wand and rubbing it before revealing the link is the false proximity that misleads the audience as to *when* and prevents them from figuring out *how*,

Like *Ring on Wand*, Roy Walton's *Collectors* plot is a penetration effect. The aces are dropped face up on the deck and immediately spread to show

that the three selections are now interlaced between them. Apparently they have penetrated upward through the deck. In some versions, the aces never touch the deck, turning the effect into a translocation. There is nothing wrong with that. However, if the method consists of nothing more than

palming off the selections and adding them to the aces, a spectator might be able to retrace that kind of linear method. It might be worth considering dropping the aces on the deck before revealing the interlace even though the method doesn't require it. The false proximity you create would tend to compel the audience into thinking that the "collection" had to occur at that moment. What might be a less-than-baffling translocation effect becomes a highly baffling penetration effect.

Paradoxically, in versions or the Collectors that require a lot of fiddling as the aces are placed on top, the contact between aces and deck is a necessary evil because the method actually happens during the contact. In the earlier example, it's worth considering dropping the aces on the deck precisely *because* it has nothing to do with the method. It can, therefore, both act as psychological misdirection and encourage the feeling of magic.

This is a key point. You use false proximity in situations where it will help mentally box the audience into a corner, not in situations where it will offer a way out. In the *Ring on Wand*, it's worth leading the audience to believe that the magic happens when the right hand contacts the wand because it would be impossible to put the ring on at that point, the spectator is already holding both ends. The spectators' instincts say that the penetration happened then; the facts say that it couldn't have happened then. That's the box we want to put the audience in.

I'm not advocating using false proximity to offer the spectator an easy explanation. (That is the sort of thing Rick Johnsson advocates in his Too Perfect Theory.) I am instead suggesting using it to encourage the feeling that the effect happened by magic. This means that you never create a false proximity that could allow the spectator to conclude that you really did something sneaky then. You do it when it's clear that trickery would be impossible.

For example, some magicians, when performing a Coins Across effect, will bring their closed fists together to signal the magic moment. The danger is that a spectator might wrongly conclude that you secretly transferred the coin through sleight of hand when the fists came together. Here, false proximity might not work well. Remember, we want to cut off all exits, not provide the audience with a way out.

Suppose instead that you're performing a transposition between a coin in the spectator's closed fist and one in your closed fist. At the magic moment you touch your fist to hers. The audience's inborn tendency to see contiguity as a requirement of causality will encourage the feeling that this is when the exchange happened. Yet they also know that exchanging the

coins at that moment would be impossible. And, of course, that's just what we want them to feel—that they're seeing the impossible.

In the *Collectors* example, if the selections are already secretly interlaced between the aces, dropping them on top of the deck and immediately spreading the cards would work well because nothing that happens at that moment can possibly explain the result. Both the *Ring on Wand* example and the *Collectors* example offer the choice of presenting the effect as a penetration or a translocation. Which is better? Whichever is furthest from the real method.

Consider on final example. Earlier I described John Carney's *Seconds on the jack Sandwich*, which uses a dummy card for time displacement. The performer places the red jacks on the table. He then has a card selected and lost in the deck. With no further handling he spreads the jacks to show a facedown card trapped between them. The audience assumes that this must be the selected card. Only then does the magician palm the selected card and load it between the jacks. The lack of contact makes this an amazing card-to-impossible-location effect.

By contrast, I have an unpublished sandwich trick called *Hard Target*. In one phase, I square the two red jacks on the deck, stealing the selection under them. In displaying the jacks, I secretly load the card between them and place them on the table. (The situation is the same as in Carney's effect except for one key point. I don't isolate the jacks until *after* the card has

been selected and returned to the deck.) I now hand the deck out for shuffling. After the spectator's shuffle, I dribble the deck on the table and toss the jacks into it. I then show the selection trapped between them.

The implication is that the jacks “caught” the selection as they landed in the shuffled deck, a true impossibility. Tossing the jacks into the deck provides the false proximity that makes people believe that the selection was trapped at that moment rather than when it really happened.

Would it be stronger if I ended my trick as Carney does, just spreading the tabled jacks? No because, without the false proximity, the audience would search for the one moment when the jacks and the deck came together. Some might remember when I squared the jacks on the deck and suspect that this was when I loaded the selection between them. *Hard Target* would make a weak card-to-impossible-location effect. But the false proximity makes it a strong demonstration of impossible skill. Would it be stronger for Carney to end his trick as I do mine, by tossing the jacks into the deck? No because bringing the jacks in contact with the deck after the selection is buried in the deck would only provide the audience with an

“easy out.” A false proximity in this case would just make the effect less amazing.

Remember, these are all techniques for solving problems. If you feel that an effect you're doing is fine as it is, you may not want to change anything. If you're not getting the reaction you want, you may be able to use false proximity to lure the audience in the wrong direction. Use *distance* to conceal when the method really happens. Use *proximity* to falsely position the moment of the effect in the audience's mind.

Chapter Six: Conceptual Distance

“If an effect can be solved simply by the application of logic, the effect is no good.”

Bob Cassidy

In this chapter we'll consider how to build a *conceptual* wall between method and effect.

Let me start by clarifying an important point. In discussing conceptual barriers, I'll often say things like, "If the spectator considers the correct solution, he'll be forced to abandon it because..." It's important to understand that this phrasing is merely an analytical device. Our goal is not that the spectator will consider the correct solution and eventually decide, "No, that can't be it because of [the conceptual barrier]." Rather our goal is that, because of the conceptual barrier, the correct solution *will never occur* to the spectator in the first place.

We often speak figuratively of someone running into a brick wall. But have you ever seen anyone *literally* run into a brick wall? Of course not. The reason is that, if a runner sees a brick wall, he doesn't run towards it. As soon as he sees it, he turns off in a different direction. This is an automatic, almost unconscious, reaction.

Imagine that you were lost in a maze of alleys. If you saw a brick wall off to your right you would hardly give it a moment's thought. You're looking for an exit, not a barrier. You wouldn't run toward the brick wall and you wouldn't waste time speculating about what might be on the other side. You would simply look elsewhere for a way out. It's the same with an effective conceptual barrier. It doesn't talk the spectator out of a solution he's considering. It ensures that he'll turn away from the correct solution *before* considering it.

Conceptual barriers can take many forms. By way of example, let's look at two of the most common types: *physical* barriers and *information* barriers.

Physical Barriers

A physical barrier is just what the name implies. The spectator never suspects that you took the path you did because he can see that there is some physical object blocking the way.

In **The Card Secrets of Brother John Hamman**, Brother Hamman has a bold method of producing a selected card from the pocket. He apparently deals the selection off the deck but actually retains it on top, dealing off an indifferent card instead. He then places the deck in his pocket. After vanishing the “selection” he merely reaches in his pocket and removes the top card of the deck,

While I appreciate boldness, I like to back it up with subtlety. Therefore, I handle Brother Hamman's idea this way. Before putting the deck in my pocket I place it in its case and close the case. Later, when I effortlessly remove the selected card from my pocket, anyone who remembers that the deck is in the same pocket will also remember that it's enclosed inside the case. Therefore, the card I just pulled out couldn't have come from the deck.

What the audience doesn't know is that, when I place the deck in its case* I insert the flap between the top card and the rest of the deck. Later I can instantly pull the card out with no hesitation or fumbling. The barrier of the card case prevents the correct solution from occurring to anyone,

Let's look at another example where the card case acts as a physical barrier to the true explanation. I've always felt that Vernon's *Travelers* is weakened by the fact that you keep the deck in your hands and the audience can see your hands repeatedly traveling from the deck to your pockets. If the aces are also traveling from the deck to your pockets, it doesn't take a genius to sense what the delivery system must be.

José Carroll solved the problem with a brilliant version called *Travelers Through the Case*. After the aces are buried in the deck, the deck is placed in the card case and (thanks to an ingenious gaff) the performer's hands are clearly seen empty just before the aces start traveling to the pockets.

In the original version, if someone were to explain to the spectator that the performer was merely palming the aces out of the deck and pretending to pull them from his pockets, that explanation would make sense. In Carroll's version, it wouldn't. The spectator might well respond, “How could he? The cards were in the box.”

A physical barrier need not be a box. It can be *anything that stands in the way of something getting from here to there*. In *The Unholy Three* (**Card-**

shark). A blue-backed card serves the same purpose. Three cards from a red-backed deck travel to a blue-backed deck. Although the red deck passes over the tabled blue deck, the audience never suspects that the transfer happens at that moment because the top card of the blue deck remains blue. If I had dropped cards onto it from the red deck, wouldn't it have suddenly turned red? The top card of the blue deck is a physical barrier to such a transfer.

Because most mental effects are about the transfer of information, physical barriers often play a major role. Al Koran's *'the Medallion* uses the principle of double writing. The spectators select a three-digit number. As the performer openly writes the number on a pad, he also secretly writes it on the back of a palmed medallion. The performer then pretends to remove the medallion from his pocket and reveals the prediction.

In Larry Becker's version, the performer has a Lippincott box in his pocket. When he reaches into the pocket, he loads the palmed medallion into the box. He then removes the box and hands it to a spectator to unlock and open. Clearly, the performer couldn't have just written the number on the medallion since the medallion was locked inside a box. The walls of the Lippincott box provide a solid physical barrier between the effect and the correct explanation to that effect. (Just as an aside, if you combine my idea, described earlier, of dropping the medallion down your sleeve with Becker's Lippincott box idea, you'll have a hell of a strong version of Koran's trick.)

Alan Shaxon's *Confabulation* uses the same concept with a different gaff. The prediction is loaded into a gaffed wallet before being produced. The wallet is the physical barrier that conceals the feat that the performer was secretly writing the prediction as he openly recorded the spectator's choices.

Notice that this is very different from a trick where the *effect* is that something is magically transported into a locked box or the performer's wallet. In the two previous examples, the whole point is to make sure that the spectators *don't suspect* that something was transported into the box or wallet. In *The Dream Card* (**Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**), I use a

gaffed wallet the same way as in *Confabulation*: not to achieve a card-to-wallet effect, but to make the audience think that the card I pull from my pocket must have been there since before the effect began.

There are other ways of exploiting (and circumventing) a physical barrier in a prediction effect. Suppose you use a nail writer to record a prediction on a card sealed inside an envelope, (The envelope has a window cut in it to permit the writing.) The basic method that achieves the deception is the nail writer. The audience doesn't suspect you of writing because you don't have a pencil in your hand. But your insurance that the audience won't even *consider* the correct solution is the physical barrier of the envelope. You can't write on the card if it's sealed in an envelope,

In *Windex*, T.A. Waters takes this concept to the ultimate. A number chosen by a spectator is found previously written on a playing card reversed in the middle of a cased deck. Not only does the card case have a hole cut in it, so does half the deck. Under such conditions, who could suspect a nail writer?

The Hole Container

Indeed. I've always felt that one of the greatest principles in magic is *the container with a hole*. Take almost any kind of container (wallet, key case, card box, envelope, drinking glass, paper bag), cut a hole or slit in it, and you can baffle people just by sneaking objects or information (as in nail writing or billet reading effects) in or out.

This is because many of people's strongest assumptions grow out of function. Everyone understands that containers are designed to contain and they can't do that very well if they have a hole in them. Therefore, they'll assume that any given container *doesn't* have a hole in it. And they won't question that assumption unless you blatantly abuse the principle. The number of truly miraculous effects that can be achieved using slit wallets, slit key cases, slit envelopes, window envelopes, X-ray card cases, and bottomless glasses is legion. (The bottomless glass is particularly diabolical. What could be more useless than a drinking glass with no bottom? It follows, therefore, that any glass you introduce *will* have a bottom.)

I once saw a magician use this concept as a gag. He repeatedly guessed what color billiard ball a spectator placed in a paper bag. He then turned the bag around to show that it had a huge, clear-plastic covered hole in the side that allowed him to see within. The audience laughed at the fact that they could have been fooled by something so blatant. But they were fooled, and that's the point.

And new applications of the concept are still being devised, David Harkey has a clever effect in **Simply Harkey** whose sole modus operandi is a shopping bag with a hole cut out, A recently marketed item achieves a hilarious effect just by means of a secret hole in a bucket. Nor is the concept limited to sneaking items in or out of the container. Gaetan Blooms baffling, ungaffed version of the *Card Lasso* employs a slit in a hat to permit secret manipulation of the rope. None of these examples involves a penetration *effect*. Secretly penetrating the container is part of the *method*, not the effect. The container is there to prevent people from suspecting the method.

Adding a physical barrier can make your magic more inexplicable. And, often, all you have to do to secretly overcome that physical barrier is cut a hole in it.

Information Barriers

An information barrier simply means that *the correct solution to the miracle doesn't seem plausible because you (apparently) didn't have access to the information needed to make that method work*. Let's look at some concrete examples.

Case Study: The Trick That Can't Be Explained

Perhaps the most elaborate development of the equivoque concept in card magic is Vernon's *The Trick That Can't Be Explained*. The performer writes a prediction and spreads the deck face up. The spectator then makes a series of choices that lead to a card. That card proves to be the one the performer predicted.

Since the performer interprets the meaning of the spectator's choices the way ancient seers interpreted animal entrails, there is a danger that a

skeptical spectator might suspect that, in interpreting his choices, the performer pursued a hidden agenda. After all, the deck *was* face-up. The performer knew which card he had predicted. He could easily see where the predicted card lay. If he had the choice, for example, of counting *toward* the predicted card or *away from* the predicted card, which direction would he likely choose?

Like most effects, the Vernon trick didn't develop in a vacuum. Other magicians were experimenting with the same ideas around the same time. Consider Dr. Stanley Jaks' brilliant approach to this plot. He would begin by having the spectator shuffle the deck and freely select a card. Neither the spectator nor the performer got to see the face of this card. Instead, the spectator initialed the back of the unknown card. (Today, you could place a pressure-sensitive sticker on the back of the card and have the spectator initial that. The sticker could be peeled off later, leaving an undamaged deck.)

The spectator then returned the card to the deck. The performer secretly peeked this card as he handed the deck to the spectator, asking him to shuffle the cards face up. (Instead of glimpsing, you could force a known card.) The deck was then ribbonspread face up and the effect proceeded as in the Vernon version. The climax came when the card that the spectator arrived at was turned over to reveal that it was the previously initialed card.

In terms of the outward reality, the performer himself didn't know what card the spectator had initialed. Therefore, he couldn't steer things in the direction of that card even if he had wanted to. His apparent *lack of knowledge* eliminates the true explanation from consideration.

Another first-rate approach is Lu Brents *A Prediction Supreme* from his 1956 book **Fifteen Star Card Effects**. Here is a slightly condensed description:

The performer has previously pencil-dotted a known card. He begins by writing a prediction naming the pencil-dotted card. The spectator now shuffles the deck and cuts it into two halves. The performer ribbonspreads both halves *face* down. The spectator selects a card from one half (the one not containing the pencil-dotted card). This becomes an indicator card that

he inserts face up into the other spread. The performer then uses the identity and location of the indicator card to arrive, by spelling and/or counting, at the pencil-dotted card. (Since you're working with only a half-deck, the two cards can't be all that far apart.) All that remains is to have the prediction read.

What distinguishes this from the Vernon approach is that the cards remain face down at all times. In the Jaks version, you know the locations of all the cards since they're spread face up. But you don't know the *identity* of the target card. That's the information barrier. In the Brent version, you know the target card because you predicted it. But you don't know the *locations* of any cards since they're spread face down. That's the information barrier.

We can go further and incorporate both information barriers into one effect. Here is my elaboration on the Lu Brent effect. I call it *The Trick That Takes Forever to Explain*. Prior to performance, pencil dot, or otherwise mark two diagonally opposite corners of any known card. Force this card on a spectator. Hand him the deck so that he can bury the selection while the cards are in his own hands. Have him shuffle. Finally, instruct the spectator to cut the deck into two roughly equal piles.

Ribbonspread the two halves face down, one above the other. As *you* do so, note the location of the marked force card. Tell the spectator that you want him to select a card and ask him which half he wishes to choose the card from. His answer determines what happens next. If he chooses the half that doesn't contain the force card, tell him that you want him to choose an indicator card. Have him remove any card. You then gather up the rest of the spread and discard it. Have the spectator turn his indicator card face up.

It now remains only to somehow get to the selected card in the remaining half using the indicator card. If the selected card is near either end of the spread, you can spell the *suit* of the indicator card, spell the *value* of the indicator card, or *count* the value of the indicator card from that end of the spread. (If you spread the cards from your right to your left, working from either end will look natural. Working from the bottom up will look natural to the audience because you'll be working from left to right from their perspective. Working from the top down will look natural if you first have

the spectator scoop up the cards and hold them in dealing position as he counts or spells.)

Alternatively, if the selected card is more or less centralized, instruct the spectator to insert his indicator card face up somewhere in the spread. The card can't end up all that far from the selection. Indeed, he may insert it right next to the selection. If not, you can spell or count the value and/or suit of the indicator card to arrive at the selection.

Finally, since you forced the selection, you can use *its own identity* to arrive at it. Your patter might run as follows: "You've made two decisions. You selected a card earlier. You also chose to insert your indicator card at exactly this point in the spread. We'll use both of those choices to arrive at a card. I'm going to spell the value of the card you chose earlier, counting one card for each letter. And I'll start at the point at which you inserted the indicator. [Illustrate the procedure with a fictional example.] By the way, what was the value of the card you chose?"

Of course, when you initially ask the spectator which half he wishes to choose a card from, he may, instead, pick the one containing the selection. In this case, discard the other half. Have the spectator touch the back of a card in his chosen half. He might, of course, touch the selected card, in which case, it's "Miller Time." Otherwise, depending on how close the touched card is to the selection, you either instruct him to turn the card face up and replace it in the same position or turn it face up and insert it, elsewhere in the spread. From here you proceed as before.

Naturally, in each of these cases, you have the choice of going in either direction from the indicator card and starting your count with the indicator card itself or the next card and removing either the card arrived at or the next card.

It will sometimes happen that, as soon as you ribbonspread the two halves, you realize that the selection is in position to spell or count to from the top or bottom of the spread using its own identity. In this case, simply use a magician's choice to eliminate the other half. Then explain the procedure you intend to use. Have the spectator name their card, and then proceed to arrive at it. You explain the procedure first, so that you're clearly

committed to it *before* you find out what the selection is. (Remember, in the outer reality, you don't know what card they chose.)

Many other situations can arise. You might both count the value of the indicator and spell the suit of the selection. Again, you would explain this procedure *before* asking the spectator the suit of his selection.

On another occasion, you may realize that you could just as well spell either the value of the indicator or the suit of the selection to arrive at your goal. (For example, the indicator is the queen of diamonds and the selection is the two of clubs.) You can then use an equivocation to create a truly baffling situation. Cryptically ask the spectator, "What's more important to you, value or suit?" If he says value, you spell *queen* to arrive at the selection. He will be doubly puzzled when you point out that, if you had spelled diamonds, you would have arrived at a different card. The same puzzling situation arises if he chooses suit and you spell *clubs*. Spelling "two," you point out, would have led to a different result.

Keep in mind that you can deliberately choose your force card so as to maximize your options. A good choice might be the two of clubs. You can count the value (2), spell the value (3), or spell the suit (4 or 5, depending on whether you include the "s"). Additionally, you have the option of turning over either the card arrived at or the next card. This will cover number 6. Also, various ways of spelling or count/spelling value and suit combined will cover numbers 7, 8, 9, and 10. (I'll let you work out the details.) You're thus set to reveal the card if it is anywhere from one to ten cards from the top or bottom of the spread or one to ten cards from the indicator card. (With a spread of only half the deck, it will be almost impossible for it to be anywhere else.) And you still have the added option of using the identity of the indicator card.

Finally, if you have a serious interest in this type of trick, you might want to *consider* applying the Brent procedure to the Jaks effect for a very direct and natural way of arriving at a spectator's unknown, initialed card. After, shuffling, the spectator would cut the deck into two halves that would be ribonspread face up. You would then direct him to select an indicator card, which he would insert into either the same half or the other half (at your

direction) to arrive at the target card. (I can attest to the effectiveness of this combination, having used it with considerable success.)

Let's not, however, get so bogged down in technical details as to lose the real moral here. In Vernon's *The Trick That Can't Be Explained*, there are no information barriers. The audience knows that you know the identity of the card you predicted and the identity and location of every in the face-up spread. In the Lu Brent/Ortiz version, the audience believes that you don't know either the location or the identity of the selection. A further information barrier arises on those occasions when you use the selection's own identity to arrive at it. Since you know neither what card they chose nor where it's located in the deck, using its identity to arrive at its location is a miracle.

Information Barriers and Conservation

In **Magic and Showmanship**, Henning Nelms talks about what he calls “the conservation principle.” The essence of the concept is that you shouldn't always show your full hand. The fact that, after vanishing the aces, you can palm them and produce them from your pocket doesn't mean that you should. The fact that you may be able to, not only reveal the location of the selected card in the deck, but also announce its name doesn't mean that you should. The fact you forced the selected card doesn't mean that you should throw in a kicker in which you reveal that you had predicted what card the spectator would choose.

This can be a hard lesson to learn. It's natural to want to include every possible climax, reveal every piece of knowledge, and squeeze every potential drop of magic out of a trick. It's easy to fail to realize that, in magic effects, there are many situations where adding a part weakens the whole.

One reason the concept of conservation can be difficult to apply is that, while Nelms tells us that there are times when it should be observed, he provides little help in figuring out what those times are. In **Strong Magic**, I pointed out one situation for applying the principle: conservation may be necessary to avoid an anti-climax.

In connection with information barriers we can provide another rule for applying the conservation principle: *Don't reveal that you possess a piece of information if doing so will put the audience on the path to the correct method.* In other words, don't destroy what the audience perceives to be an information barrier just to get another round of applause.

In José Carroll's *Suit Appearance*, a spectator selects any one of the four aces. You then proceed to produce the remaining twelve cards of that suit in a variety of flourishy and amazing ways. In reality, you must force the ace that matches the suit you've previously stacked. Since the suit is forced, you could add a kicker, At the start, hand the spectator a sealed envelope. At the end, have him open the envelope and read the enclosed message, "I predict you will select the ace of hearts."

This is a bad idea for several reasons. One is that the prediction is likely to register as an anti-climax. Another is that a mental effect (prediction) doesn't really fit what is otherwise a demonstration of card control. The most important reason, however, is that the prediction would reveal that you knew in advance which suit you would be called upon to produce. That, in turn, would give the audience a clue as to how the effect is done. Better to conserve your strength- Hide the fact that you knew which ace would be chosen, and get credit for being able to produce any suit at will.

Creating Information Barriers

Applying the conservation principle means that we don't destroy information barriers that help conceal the method. But we can go further and *create* information barriers to further conceal the method.

Let's continue with our example of Jose Carroll's *Suit Appearance* The spectator must select one of the four aces. In fact, the ace is forced. Let's assume the force ace is hearts. You might lay out the aces in a face-up row and force the heart by means of equivoque.

No matter how well you handle the equivoque, an astute spectator might, in retrospect, ask himself whether, in narrating the multi-phase selection process, you might not have been following a hidden agenda. In other words, he may suspect that you steered things in the direction of the ace of

hearts (which, of course, you did). After all, you could clearly see where the ace of hearts was. You made up the rules. And forcing a particular suit would make the trick easier for you.

Suppose instead that you place a subtle crimp in the ace of hearts, one that *you* can see but the audience won't notice. You have the spectator mix the aces and deal them in a *facedown* row. Since the crimp allows you to spot the ace of hearts, you force it using equivoque just as before.

Will even an astute spectator suspect that you steered the selection process toward the ace of hearts? How could you have? You didn't know which ace was which. The selection must have been a free one, and you must really be able to produce any suit at will.

This concept can be applied to many effects. When analyzing an effect, ask yourself these questions: What do I have to know to make the effect work? Does the audience realize that I know this? If the answer is yes, ask yourself: Would the effect be a greater mystery if they thought I *didn't* know? If the answer is again yes, consider how you might obtain the information *secretly*. Finding a solution to that challenge can often produce an ironclad mystery.

Let's consider some more examples. Since mental effects center around obtaining information, it's natural that they provide a fertile field for the concept of information barriers. Consider the Ultra-Mental Deck type of prediction. This is the effect in which, after a spectator thinks of a card, you show that you had previously predicted that card by reversing it in a deck. If this classic effect has any weakness, it's that the spectator has to tell you his card before you can reveal your prediction. This might suggest to the skeptical-minded that you did something *after* the card was named that allowed you to show it reversed in the deck (which, of course, you did).

Removing and isolating the prediction card *before* you knew the spectator's card would eliminate that explanation. This thinking led me to create *Do As I Did*, which I published in **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**. Others have used different approaches to achieve the same goal. For example, more than one magician has come up with the idea of using a peek wallet to obtain secret knowledge of the spectators thought-of card before

reaching for the Ultra-Mental Deck, Whatever the specific method, putting your prediction card on the table while the audience thinks you still don't know the spectator's choice places a massive brick wall squarely across the path to the correct solution.

Steve Bryant published an interview with Danny Orleans about the code mentalism act that he and his wife do. Bryant describes their method of “adding an additional layer of deceptiveness” to disguise the fact that they're using a code. “For example, Danny and Jan will sometimes combine their code work with a book test or psychometry. If there is no way for Danny to know what is being transmitted, how can it be a code?” That question perfectly sums up the concept of information barriers.

Case Study: Note Under Cup

Bob Hummers *Note Under Cup* is a classic mental effect in which a spectator hides a crumpled dollar bill under one of three identical cups, while the performer's back is turned. He then mixes the cups. The performer now turns around and immediately reveals which cup conceals the bill. This is usually repeated once or twice.

The inner reality is that the cups are not identical. One contains a small imperfection. When the performer turns back to face the audience he spots the position of the marked cup. This information, combined with the nature of the mixing instructions he gave the spectator, allows him to determine which cup hides the bill.

The audience doesn't know that one of the cups is marked, but they do know that the performer always looks at the cups before revealing which contains the bill. Would it deepen the mystery if he didn't look? I think so. Suppose we do it this way. The performer dons a blindfold. As an added precaution, he turns his back while the bill is hidden and the cups mixed. He then turns around and, while still blindfolded, holds his hand above each cup in turn. Eventually, he lifts one cup; it's the one covering the bill. He then repeats the process once or twice to prove that it wasn't just luck. It's the same method but with the addition of the venerable down-the-nose peek (or any fake blindfold). As the performer holds his hand over each cup, he spots the hidden mark.

Whether the *Note under Cup* is worth the elaborate buildup of donning a blindfold is a matter of opinion. However, if you're already doing a blindfold act, the *Note under Cup* might well be a worthwhile addition to the routine. In fact, as part of a longer blindfold routine, the *Note Under Cup* offers a double-barreled benefit. The blindfold proves that you're not relying on any visual cues from the cups. The cups prove that you've not just somehow seeing through the blindfold. After all, even a trick blindfold couldn't explain how you can see through a solid cup. (This is an example of the veils principle discussed below.) The blindfold makes the *Note Under Cup* more baffling; the *Note Under Cup* makes the blindfold act more baffling. The only explanation seems to be that you really can see without benefit of your eyes,

To create a truly impenetrable mystery, you might go further still. Combine the blindfold/*Note Under Cup* combination with a switch of a borrowed bill. You can then conclude with a last phase in which you again hold your hand over each cup until you identify the one containing the bill. Then, still holding your hand above the cup, you call out the bills serial number, which a spectator records. When the number is verified, your X-ray vision will be unquestioned and an old puzzle will have been raised to the level of a miracle. (You would, of course, switch the borrowed bill before the *first* phase of the *Note Under Cup*, thus providing strong time separation between method and effect.)

If you're particularly analytically-minded, you might be interested in noting that an information barrier might well take the form of a physical barrier. If the information you need is apparently protected by an envelope (actually a window envelope), the envelope is a physical barrier enforcing an information barrier. If you understand the concepts, you don't have to be overly concerned with categorizing them. Just use them to make your magic stronger.

You'll need creativity to find ways of improving standard effects by adding information barriers. But the analytical practice of asking the right questions—What does the audience realize that I know? Would the effect be stronger if they thought I didn't know?—will focus your creative efforts In the right direction.

The Veils Principle

The Amazing Kreskin once performed a great card trick on his old TV show. A spectator shuffled the deck. He was then instructed to scatter the cards all over a tabletop and cover them with a sheet of newspaper. Kreskin now gave the spectator a knife and had him stab down through the paper. The newspaper was torn away and all the other cards pushed aside, leaving only one facedown card pinned to the table. Kreskin then showed that he had previously reversed a prediction card in another deck. The performer's prediction card and the spectator's stabbed card proved identical.

The secret was a marked deck and an Ultra-Mental Deck. The beauty of the effect's construction, however, lies in the *combination* of the two methods. If Kreskin had simply announced the name of the card that the spectator had stabbed, every viewer would have realized that the deck must be marked. If he had simply had the spectator name any card and then shown that card reversed in a deck, some might have correctly surmised that he could somehow show any card in the deck reversed.

With the two methods combined, however, each protects the other. If the thought of a marked deck occurs to a viewer, he'll think, "But Kreskin had reversed his card *before* the guy stabbed his card." If the possibility that

the performer could show any card in the second deck reversed occurs to a viewer, he'll think, "But Kreskin didn't even know what card the guy had stabbed." It's even better than that, though. Because each method places a brick wall in front of the other method, neither method will even *occur* to the viewer.

This illustrates what I term the *veils principle*. Imagine that you have a fine translucent silk veil. Although the veil is colored, if you hold it up to the light you can *see* through it. Now imagine that you have several of these veils. You can easily see through any one of them. If, however, you superimpose two or three veils, one on top of the other, and hold them up to the light, they are now opaque. It's impossible to see what's on the other side. In the same way, you may build two or three conceptual barriers into one effect. An astute spectator might be able to see through any one of them. But when they're combined in one effect, they resist penetration,

Telekinetic Timber is a small gaffed piece of wood that, if balanced on an object, will tip over after a few moments. If you simply demonstrate this item in its naked form, people may well suspect that the block is somehow gimmicked. The only puzzle will be exactly how it works. One of the best effects with a Svengali Deck is to force the card and cleanly lose it in the deck. Then hand the deck to the spectator and instruct her to deal cards until she feels like stopping. When she does, you show that she stopped at her own selected card. Unfortunately, the effect may lead some spectators to suspect that the deck is somehow gimmicked.

Both of these effects, by their very nature, bring heat down on the gaffed item, I've created an effect that I call *Deadwood* that solves this problem by combining the two gaffs as follows. Force the card on a spectator and lose it in the deck. Then introduce the block of wood, explaining that it comes from the coffin of a famous nineteenth century card cheat. You have found that he sometimes still manifests his card skills from beyond the grave through the medium of the coffin fragment.

Balance the block of wood on something and instruct the spectator to deal cards slowly into a pile until she receives some sign from the card cheat. When the block of wood falls over, place aside the card the spectator had reached at that moment. Show that, if she had stopped one card earlier or one card later, she would have arrived at a different card. Then turn over the card stopped at to show that it's her selection, identified from beyond the grave by the card shark's ghost.

Since neither prop alone can explain the mystery, each one takes the heat off the other. You've combined two veils to create an opaque mystery where either veil alone might have been too transparent to fool a perceptive spectator.

The classic Card to Wallet effect provides another example of the veiling power of combining two methods. Magicians who've never performed this effect often waste a lot of time searching for a wallet that can be examined. Magicians who do perform the effect know that no one ever asks to examine the wallet.

But why don't they? After all, the idea that the wallet might have a secret opening to facilitate inserting the card isn't so tough to fathom. I believe that it's because the audience confronts *two* mysteries in Card to Wallet. How the card got into the wallet is only one of them. The other is how the card traveled from the deck to your pocket. Each mystery obscures the solution to the other.

If you doubt this, try this experiment. Have a card selected and signed. Openly place the card in your pocket. Perform a magic gesture. Then remove your wallet and show that the card is inside. This is not as farfetched as it may sound. There is, after all, a legitimate magic effect here. The fact that the card was in the same pocket as the wallet doesn't explain how it got *inside* the wallet. The effect becomes one of penetration rather than translocation as in the standard Card to Wallet.

Can you doubt, however, that everyone seeing this effect will ask to examine the wallet? As soon as the only question is how the card got into the wallet, suspicion falls on the wallet itself.

Similarly, a straightforward Card to Pocket consisting of simply palming the card and pretending to pull it out of your pocket will get a good response from most audiences. But it may occur to at least some people that the card may have just been hidden in your hand (although they may marvel at how well you did it).

But when you combine the method of palming the card from the deck to the pocket with the method of a gaffed wallet, the two veils can't be penetrated. The fact that the card travels invisibly from the deck to the pocket keeps people from suspecting the wallet. The fact that the card penetrates into the wallet keeps them from suspecting palming.

Nor do you have to limit yourself to only two veils. In my effect *The Showdown* from **Cardshark**, a signed card ends up folded up inside a key case that has been under a spectator's hand since the effect began. This constitutes a single translocation effect, but it superimposes three veils. There is the mystery of how the card got folded. There is the mystery of how the card got inside the key case. Finally, there is the mystery of how the card got under the spectator's hand. Laypeople's tendency to seek one

explanation to cover everything ensures they'll never come close to a solution.

The veils principle works by overloading the spectator's circuits, you overwhelm his ability to reason his way through the various components of the deception so that, instead, he throws up his hands and says, “That's impossible.”

This does not, of course, mean that you must build an endless number of conceptual barriers into every effect. It simply means that you should build in as many as you need to ensure that no one can see the method on the other side. Once you've accomplished that, anything more is gilding the lily (to use a common cliché of magic literature).

How many barriers are enough to ensure an impenetrable mystery? You'll have to determine this case by case. But, understanding the concept of conceptual barriers and the principle of cumulative veils offers you one more tool to call upon whenever an effect that you're fond of just isn't proving as deceptive as you had hoped,

Barriers to False Explanations

It's been rightly said that, if a spectator *thinks* he knows how a trick is done, that's just as bad as if he really does know how it's done. This relates to our early observations about deception vs. illusion. If the spectator thinks he knows how you did a trick but, in fact, his theory is *false*, you *have* succeeded in fooling him. Unfortunately, you have failed to create an illusion of impossibility.

The only way to ensure that the spectator doesn't walk away *thinking* that he knows how you did the effect is to conclusively disprove, not only the correct method, but *all* possible methods, (Juan Tamariz's book **The Magic Way** has an excellent discussion of this point that I recommend to you. He uses the term “stops” to mean essentially the same thing I call conceptual barriers.)

It should be obvious that it's much easier to disprove false explanations than it is to disprove the true explanation. Yet, amazingly, many magicians

don't bother. When a spectator then offers a false but plausible explanation for the effect, the magician simply takes this as proof of how stupid laypeople are.

Taking the time to disprove false explanations is perhaps the most neglected aspect of strong effect design. There are several reasons for this. First, we tend to think that it should be obvious that we didn't use any of those *other* methods to achieve the effect because, after all, we *didn't*. We know we didn't, so why don't they know it too? The reality, of course, is that the only way the audience can know that we didn't use a certain method is if we take the trouble to prove we didn't.

Second, because we have extensive technical knowledge of how magicians do things, we know that certain methods are seldom used or perhaps not even practical. We know that magicians don't really switch cards by slipping them up and down their sleeves. It's natural to assume that what's obvious to us should be obvious to others. Of course, if something is obvious to us only because of our technical knowledge of magic, it won't be obvious to someone who lacks that knowledge.

Third, if like most amateur magicians, you perform mainly for other amateur magicians, your notions of what an audience is likely to suspect is going to be distorted by the experience. Here is one of the most reliable principles you'll ever find in guiding your magic: *Any generalization about lay audiences that is based on your experiences with magician audiences is likely to be wrong.* Magicians* reactions, including what possible explanations they will or will not suspect, are determined by their technical knowledge of magic. Laypeople's reactions are determined by common sense.

What kinds of explanations does common sense usually suggest? *Obvious ones.* Not all laypeople have heard of Occam's razor, but they all understand it intuitively. Amazingly, magicians often don't bother to eliminate the obvious explanations. Again, this is because *magician audiences* tend to overlook the obvious explanation in their search for clever methods.

In fact, magicians often succeed in fooling other magicians simply by using a method so obvious that other magicians don't even consider it. In **The Card Expert Entertains**, Dariel Fitzkee tells of how he badly fooled a bunch of fellow magicians with a marked deck. It just never occurred to them that he would use something so obvious. Other magicians have had similar experiences using Svengali decks or stripper decks on their magician victims. In many cases, a trick deck is the first thing that a lay audience would have suspected.

I once attended a Fred Kaps lecture in which he provided a particularly dramatic example of this phenomenon. Kaps explained that he had been hired to appear in a television commercial. The script called for him to make a cigarette penetrate through a handkerchief. After considering several methods, he decided to simply cut a slit in the handkerchief and pass the cigarette through it. (I suspect he may have realized that, no matter what method he used, viewers would simply assume there was a slit in the handkerchief. Or they would just figure it was trick photography. Since, within the context of a TV commercial there was no way to prove otherwise, he might as well take the easy way out. Furthermore, the client probably had no interest in creating a magical experience for the viewer. He simply wanted the effect to serve some dramatic purpose in the storyline of the commercial.) Afterwards, on a lark, Kaps decided to try the method out on an audience of magicians. To his surprise, he fooled them completely. It just never occurred to them that a magician of Fred Kaps' status would stoop to such an obvious method.

By contrast, I'm sure he never would have fooled a lay audience with this method. Common sense would have immediately suggested this as the most likely explanation. With a lay audience, even if you're using some really clever method to put a cigarette through a handkerchief, you'd better take the trouble to prove you don't just have a slit in the handkerchief. (Handing out the handkerchief for examination or using a borrowed one would set up airtight conceptual barriers to such an explanation.) This illustrates a fundamental difference between magician audiences and lay audiences: *the obvious explanation is usually the last one to occur to magicians but the first one to occur to laypeople.*

Of course, you don't want to waste time disproving theories that would never occur to the audience in the first place. (I believe that this is the sort of thing that Al Baker had in mind when he advised, "Don't run when you're not being chased.") Here again experience performing for other magicians can be misleading. You'll often see a magician who is performing for a lay audience take great pains to disprove some explanation that would only occur to another magician. A good example is the guy who, before doing a bill transposition, insists on forcing the spectator to check all eight of the bill's indices.

The hard part is identifying which false explanations are likely to pop into a lay audience's minds. Once you do, the appropriate conceptual barriers to disprove them will usually be obvious. If they may suspect that you're sliding cards up your sleeves, roll up your sleeves before you start. If they may suspect the deck is marked, have the card selected in such a way that you never see its back (for example, by means of a spectator peek).

How do you identify possible false explanations? The first step is to use your own common sense (if it hasn't completely atrophied from hanging around other magicians). Ask yourself what would be the obvious way to achieve the effect in question.

The second step is to pay attention to audience feedback. Admittedly, there are some stupid people out there and there also are people who have such a strong emotional need to walk away from a performance believing they know what happened that they'll convince themselves of the most ridiculous things. So don't lose too much sleep over one individual who offers what strikes you as an absurd explanation to one of your effects. If, however, more than one person suggests the same solution, no matter how silly the explanation might sound to you, take the time to eliminate it.

If a certain effect isn't playing as strongly as you expected, ask people after the performance how they think it was done. You might be surprised by the answers. If the same theory comes up again and again, take steps to prove it wrong. The effect can't help but become stronger.

It's true that, as Al Baker wrote, "Some magicians always want to prove something that the audience doesn't question." However, you do have to

educate yourself as to what sorts of things the audience *is questioning*. If an effect you're performing has an obvious possible explanation, take the trouble to prove that explanation wrong.

Keep in mind that you can prove something without the audience realizing that your goal is to prove something. We should distinguish here between motivation, intention, and result. I'm using the word motivation here in the way an actor would, to mean your reason for doing something in terms of the outer reality of the effect. By intention I mean your *real* reason for doing it. By result I mean the effect your action has on the audience's thinking.

Suppose I hold up my hand and say, "Notice that my hand is empty." Both my motivation and my intention are to show my hand empty. Suppose instead that I gesture with my open hand toward some object as I say, "Would you please hand me that?" My motivation is to indicate the object, but my intention may be to show my hand empty. In the first case, the result may be to suggest the possibility of palming to a spectator who might otherwise never have thought of it. In the second case, the result may be to *eliminate* any suspicion of palming before it can even occur to the audience.

When I talk about proving or disproving I'm talking about your *intention*. Your *motivation* is a presentational matter for you to determine individually in each case. (If, however, in order for an *effect* to register as a miracle, it's *vital* that the audience realize that your hand is empty there is nothing wrong with saying, "Notice that my hand is empty.") The important thing is the intended result, to eliminate false explanations that might weaken an effect in the mind of the audience.

Eliminate Suspicion Before It Forms

"The most powerful magic tends to consist of utterly impossible events happening under 'test conditions' including examination, open-handedness, and repetition."

Jay Sankey, **Beyond Secrets**

Any talk about *disproving* theories that might occur to a spectator and *proving* that you're not using a certain method invariably meets resistance from some magicians. They feel that taking the trouble to prove things focuses the audience's attention on method and turns the effect into a puzzle. This argument sometimes takes the form of the claim that a "real magician" wouldn't waste time proving things. (To this I respond that he would if he wanted others to *realize* that he was a real magician.) Although different magicians will frame this argument differently, it boils down to the belief that taking the trouble to eliminate possible explanations interferes with the magical experience.

What these magicians fear is that, when the magical climax occurs, instead of reacting emotionally, the spectator will react analytically. He will sit there with knitted brow, puzzling over questions of method rather than enjoying the effect. This is a legitimate concern, but the solution is not for the magician to shirk his burden of proof.

As I observed earlier, magic produces an emotional reaction to an intellectual conclusion. That reaction is the thrill of realizing that you've witnessed the impossible. As magicians, we cannot achieve the *emotional* reaction without first producing the *intellectual* conclusion that what the spectator has just witnessed really is impossible.

To do that, we have to recognize a fundamental fact. One can only conclude that something is impossible through *a process of elimination*. There is no other way. We conclude that a witnessed event is impossible only by eliminating all *possible* explanations. If you're unwilling to help the spectator do that, he will never experience the emotional reaction you're seeking.

Every magician loves to hear a spectator exclaim in astonishment, "*That's impossible!*" But that *very* statement implies that the spectator has considered ways the effect might be achieved and has been forced to reject them all. Only a psychotic would conclude that something is impossible without first considering whether it *might* be possible.

Many people, upon seeing David Copperfield's *Flying*, have thought, "That's impossible!" Suppose you were to say to such a person, "Maybe he

is suspended on wires.” Do you think he might respond, “Gee, I never thought of that”? Of course not. He would respond by pointing out that he couldn't be on wires because the Plexiglas case rules that out. In other words, the spectator considered that explanation (and all others he could think of) and rejected it *before* concluding, “That's impossible!”

Since magic is, by definition, a phenomenon with no natural explanation, it follows that one can't experience magic until he is convinced that there *can be* no natural explanation. Taking the trouble to eliminate possible explanations doesn't interfere with the magical experience. It's vital to the magical experience.

Yet the magician who doesn't want the spectator responding analytically to the effect's climax has a valid concern. We want the spectator to respond to the magic instantly and emotionally, not by rubbing his chin pensively and saying, “Hmm, let me think about that for a while.”

Fortunately, there is a solution. The U.S. military calls it “preparing the battlefield.” This means that, before the battle, they spend a couple of days bombing the hell out of the enemy. When U.S. ground forces finally attack, the battle goes a lot more easily because the enemy has already been softened up. The same strategy works in magic. The human mind provides countless defenses against experiencing magic. Before the spectator can have a magical experience, you must first demolish those defenses. The best way to guarantee that the spectator isn't thinking about method when the magic happens is to ensure that he gets all that thinking out of his system *before* the magic happens.

The most succinct formula I've ever heard for creating a magical experience comes from Al Koran, quoted in T.A. Waters' **Mysteries**. Asked how to create miracles for an audience, Koran responded, “Very simple, really. You start with a strong effect—well, that almost goes without saying, doesn't it?—and you build up the conditions so that you can point out to the audience that if you can succeed under these conditions, it's a miracle. And then, of course, you succeed—so they have to admit you work miracles!”

Notice the temporal sequence. You get the audience to accept the impossibility of what you're going to do *before* you do it. Later, when the

magic happens, you can expect an instant emotional reaction. People may, for example, exclaim, “No way!” That's because they had already accepted that there was no way of doing it *before* you did it. When you finally do it, they have no need for intellectual analysis. Indeed, the emotional reaction may begin even a moment *before* the magic happens. This is why people will sometimes exclaim, “If those aces are under her hand, I'll [fill in the blank]!”

This is the approach Copperfield takes in *Flying*. He eliminates any thoughts of wires *before* he flies. When he finally takes off; the spectator doesn't have to ponder whether Copperfield is suspended from wires. That possibility has already been disproved, leaving the spectator free to experience the magic.

The Koran formula is perfect for *suspense* effects, those in which the audience knows what is going to happen before it happens (as in the Copperfield trick). It works just as effectively, however, in *surprise* effects. When Scotty York does the *Hundred-Dollar Bill Switch* he has a spectator run her thumbs all over his palms as he holds the borrowed bill stretched between his hands. At this point, the audience doesn't even know what the effect is going to be. But it does know, beyond any doubt, that there is nothing in Scotty's hands except for the borrowed bill. Later, when the effect occurs, the spectators don't have to stop to ponder whether the hundred-dollar bill might have been concealed in his hand from the outset. Knowing already that it wasn't, they can respond instantly to the magic.

In each case, by the time the effect climaxes, all of the spectator's rationalizations and theories—all of his defenses—have been bombed into oblivion. He is completely vulnerable to the magical experience that is about to invade him. He is open to the *emotional* experience because the *intellectual barriers* to that experience were removed in advance. When the magic happens, you'll get the raised eyebrows and open face of astonishment rather than the furrowed eyebrows and closed face of puzzlement.

Lei's strip the concept down to its essentials. You pick up a coin with your right hand and do a fake transfer into your left hand. You then drop your right hand to the table edge for a moment and lap the coin. You now

open your left hand to show that the coin has vanished. As David Roth warned us, the audience will immediately look at your other hand. You casually show your right hand empty. The audience is now left with no explanation, That's good. However, at the moment the magic occurred the audience was thinking about method. Could the coin be in his other hand? That's bad.

Let's try it this way instead. You perform the fake transfer and the lapping move as before. In his time, however, you gesture with your right hand to clearly show it empty *before* revealing the vanish. The audience does not yet know that the coin is going to vanish. But they do already know that your other hand is empty. When you now reveal the vanish, the audience isn't thinking. "I wonder if it's in the other hand [focusing on method]." They're thinking, "That impossible [focusing on effect]."

If you follow this approach, some magicians will accuse you of emphasizing method. In fact, you're emphasizing the *absence* of any possible method. It's precisely when you *don't* lay the proper groundwork in advance that the spectator is likely to respond to the climax analytically, running various theories through his head. By the time he has evaluated and (hopefully) rejected them all, the magic moment has passed. He may finally conclude that he doesn't know how you did it, but it will just be a sterile, intellectual judgment.

There is also an important pragmatic advantage to dealing with suspicions preemptively. It's just much easier to prevent a suspicion from forming than to disprove one that has already formed. Indirect proofs will often suffice in the former case. Only direct proofs will suffice in the latter.

If you perform a routine with a stacked deck, an occasional false shuffle will throw people off the track. If you leave out those shuffles, a spectator might voice the suspicion that the cards are stacked. At that point, it won't do any good to say, "Well then, I'll shuffle the cards." The spectator will almost certainly insist on shuffling himself. Suppose you're performing a gaffed packet trick and want to end cleanly. If you can switch the cards before it occurs to anyone that they might be gaffed, you should have no problems. But once a spectator asks to examine the cards, you'll never get away with a switch. Touches like the Kaps subtlety can prevent a spectator from

suspecting that you have a coin palmed. If that suspicion has already formed, however, those subtleties won't help. Nothing short of opening your hand completely to show it empty will do. Once things have reached the crisis stage only direct proofs will work.

One of the maxims that has guided me through life is: the best way to deal with problems is to prevent them before they happen. When applied to this subject, that translates as: eliminate suspicions before they occur.

Chapter Seven: The False Frame of Reference

“An audience, watching magic, gets impossible answers because the magician so arranges things that the spectators ask themselves the wrong questions.”

The Great Merlini,
Nothing is Impossible
by Clayton Rawson

The Straight and Narrow Path

Some effects point directly to their methods with the vividness of a flashing neon arrow. Indeed, the arrow image suggests the nature of the problem. The design of the effect is too *linear*. The method may be hidden, in the sense that it happens under the surface, but it follows exactly the direct path the audience expects it to.

Imagine a secret tunnel. You see the tunnel entrance and, some distance away, you see the exit. Since the tunnel is underground you don't see the passage itself. But by tracing a straight line from entrance to exit you can get a pretty good idea of the tunnels path. Dig anywhere along that line and you're likely to uncover the tunnel.

In a magic effect, the initial condition is the entrance and the final condition is the exit. The method is the tunnel. If it follows a straight line from entrance to exit, there is a risk that a spectator may uncover the method by following the path until he stumbles on a clue. In fact, it's

enough that he simply senses the general path of the method. Either way, there is no illusion of impossibility.

Suppose instead that the tunnel follows a broad curve from the entrance to the exit. A person could dig hole after hole along the straight-line path and never uncover the tunnel. If the tunnel incorporates a couple of serpentine twists, it becomes even harder to detect. The more a person digs between the two openings, the more convinced he'll become that there is no way leading from one to the other. The quintessential response to magic: "No way!"

At this point, you may be thinking, "But I've always heard that magic should be direct. Now you're telling me that it should be indirect." Certainly, the *effect* should be direct. It's the design of the method that should be indirect.

The problem with direct methods is that laypeople *think* in terms of direct methods. A direct method is what the audience is searching for. Therefore, it's precisely the kind of method they're most likely to uncover. Another term for direct methods might be *linear methods*. Linear thinking is intuitive. It's the way most people normally think. It's what they can be expected to do if faced with an apparent impossibility. Does it make sense to provide a linear method for them to analyze in their linear way?

Far better to take a counterintuitive, nonlinear approach. Consider the *Copper-Silver Transposition* in the spectator's hand. The spectator asks herself, "How did he make the coin in his hand change places with the coin in my hand?" In fact, the two coins never change places. In reality, coin A is exchanged for *coin C* (which the spectator doesn't even know exists). Then coin A is substituted for coin B (which is not even in evidence at the climax of the effect). Because the spectator is thinking in terms of the copper coin changing places with the silver coin, she looks for a straight line between them. Instead, the magician used a bank shot.

Another good example of the nonlinear approach is *The Hitchcock Travelers* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards**. I place four signed aces face down on the table, I then immediately remove them from four different pockets. The audience wonders how I made the aces travel from the table to

my pockets. In fact, the aces actually travel from the *deck* to my pockets. They were never really on the table to begin with.

Compare this to the original Vernon *Travelers*. In that case, the audience wonders how you made the aces travel from the deck to your pockets which, unfortunately, is exactly what you did. Furthermore, your hands continually travel from deck to pockets, providing the linear path the spectators are looking for.

Now perhaps you're thinking, "This sounds good in theory, but I hate over-handled tricks." So do I. A nonlinear method, however, needn't mean a lot of handling. We're talking about the directness or indirectness of the *concept* at the core of the method, not the handling that implements that method. Furthermore, the amount of handling that matters to an audience is the handling that occurs during the critical interval. That's what will determine whether or not they walk away thinking, "But he didn't do anything!" Switching from linear to nonlinear methods tends to shift handling from the critical interval to the far less sensitive before or after periods.

Consider the *Color-Changing Deck*. The nature of the effect suggests to the audience some secret switch of the blue deck for the red deck. In fact, you're using a red deck from the outset. It's only *disguised* as a blue deck, (Very counterintuitive!) This creates a false frame of reference because the audience asks, "When could he have switched decks?" instead of, "How did he initially make that red deck look blue?" A version of the *Color-Changing Deck* based on switching decks would be a more direct method. It would also be a less deceptive method and would require more handling where it hurts, during the critical interval.

As we proceed, consider each example I provide of revamping an effect to create a false frame of reference. You'll see that they all preserve a direct, clean handling while utilizing a devious, indirect method.

The "Too Obvious" Theory

In issue 5-6, pp,247-50, of the Hierophant, Rick Johnsson published an essay entitled "The 'Too Perfect' Theory." Tommy Wonder wrote that, "This

theory has been rather widely accepted.” He may be right, but that's not my impression. Almost every time I've seen someone bring up the Too Perfect Theory it's been only to attack it.

Let me begin by stressing that I don't entirely agree with the Too Perfect Theory. Yet, I think the essay raises some important points. Admittedly, Johnsson's reasoning is so obviously flawed and some of his advice so inimical to good magic that it's easy to understand why many would rush to poke holes in his logic and condemn his position. In doing so, it's easy to overlook that some of his examples are valid, though the conclusions he draws from them may not be.

For instance, he considers an effect in which you have a spectator shuffle a deck, place it in his pocket, and go into another room. He then reaches in his pocket, pulls out any card, and notes its identity. He buries the card back in the pocketed deck and returns. You immediately announce, correctly, that the chosen card is the ace of spades. Johnsson points out that any intelligent spectator will immediately realize that all the cards in the deck must be aces of spades.

As a preferable alternative, he suggests using the same method (a forcing deck) and having the spectator follow the same procedure to select and replace the card. This time, however, when the spectator returns, you take the deck, give it a cut, and deal cards as the spectator spells his card (which will, of course, be the ace of spades). Finish by revealing that the spectator's card appears on the last letter. Johnsson argues, correctly I think, that the spectator is far less likely to suspect a forcing deck.

From this example Johnsson draws some questionable deductions about perfect tricks vs. imperfect tricks. Let me suggest an alternative analysis. In the first case the spectator asks himself, “How did the performer know what card I chose?” Considering the conditions under which the effect was performed, the answer is obvious. In the second case the spectator asks himself, “How did the performer control my card to a position where it could be spelled? After all he didn't know where the card was in the deck or how many letters would be required to spell the name.” (It would seem that both these things would be required to achieve the effect.)

The reality, of course, is that you *didn't* control the position of the selected card in the deck. The spectator is simply asking the wrong question. Consequently, he has no chance of finding the right answer. Indeed, the question itself falsely assumes that the card you produced at the end is the same one he selected at the beginning. In fact, it's almost certainly a different ace of spades. By contrast, in the first case the spectator was allowed to ask the right question. As soon as the question was formulated the answer was apparent.

Another example Rick Johnsson discusses is the old effect of pulling out a handful of change and pretending to take a coin in the other hand as you replace the change in your pocket. In reality, you only mime the action of taking a coin. You now proceed to vanish the nonexistent coin. Johnsson maintains, plausibly enough, that this is just not something that will fool all of the people all of the time.

Instead, he suggests that you follow the same procedure of taking out a handful of coins with your left hand and pretending to pick one up with your right hand. This time, however, as you pocket the change, you secretly retain a coin in your left hand. You now rub the (supposed) coin against the back of your left fist and reveal that it has penetrated the hand.

I have to agree that this is much more deceptive. Why? Again I'll substitute my own analysis for Johnsson's. In the first case, the spectator asks himself, "Where did the coin go?" Falling back on his instinctive analysis of proximity in time and space, he thinks back to the last place the coin was near before it vanished. That place was, of course, the handful of change. The rest is obvious.

In the second case, however, the spectator asks himself, "How did the coin get from his right hand to his left hand?" Since the coin *didn't* travel from hand to hand, there is no chance of the spectator finding a satisfactory answer. Note again that the question itself assumes that there was a coin in your right hand at the outset. The very act of asking the question blocks the path to the correct answer (As an aside, notice how rubbing the "coin" on the back of the hand provides a false proximity to further mislead the audience.)

Here is the real lesson of these examples: *If you can get people to ask the wrong question, you'll guarantee that they never arrive at the right answer.* Aim to generate a false interpretation of what has happened in the effect. Create a *false frame of reference*. This determines the *mental set* with which the spectator views the effect. You've put blinders on him that keep the correct solution out of his field of vision.

Method as Effect

Keeping the audience focused on the wrong question is why you should generally avoid tricks where the method is the effect. For example, you have a card selected. Its then returned to the center of the deck and you immediately perform a pass to bring it to the top. You then snap your fingers and turn over the top card to show that the selection has jumped to the top.

If you've mastered a really illusive pass, you may be tempted to perform an effect like this to showcase the move you've worked so hard to perfect. Here is why you might want to reconsider. The effect is that the card jumps from the middle to the top. The method is that you have a move that shifts a card from the middle to the top. The method is the effect. This kind of linear design guarantees that the spectator will ask himself the right question: How did he get my card from the middle to the top?

He will logically focus his thinking on the short period between when he placed the card in the middle (initial condition) and when you revealed it on top (final condition). He might then recall that you moved your hands forward rapidly or riffled the deck or that both your hands converged on the deck for an instant or just the fact that he looked away from the deck for a moment. He then concludes, quite correctly, that in that moment you “did something” to bring the card to the top.

You may feel that you've brought your pass to such a level of perfection that there is little risk the spectator will be able to latch onto anything that suggests you did something. You may be right, but why take the risk when it's a needless one produced by poor design?

Consider another case where the method is the effect. You do a double turnover to show a king. You turn the double face down and deal off the top card. You now snap your fingers and turn over the dealt card to show that it has changed to an ace. The method is that a double turnover allows you to show one card and deal off another. The effect is that you show a card and yet, after you deal it off it is another.

When you reveal the change, the spectator will undoubtedly be shocked. Yet, a moment later, he may ask, "Can I see the top card?" This doesn't mean that he has figured out what a double lift is or that you did the move badly. It does mean that his instinctive understanding of contiguity gives him a good idea where and when the trickery must have happened, which is just as bad. A potentially good trick has been ruined because the spectator was allowed to ask himself the right question: "How did the performer switch the top card for an ace?"

By contrast, consider a simple effect combining both the pass and the double turnover. Have a card selected and buried in the deck. Do a pass to bring it to the top. Perform a double turnover as you comment that, of course, the top card of the deck cannot be the spectator's card. Turn the double face down and deal the top card onto the spectator's hand. Now snap your fingers and have the spectator turn over the card to reveal that it has changed to her card.

The shock impact of this effect will be at least as strong as that of the two previous examples. But the lasting mystery will be much stronger. Why? Because the spectator will ask herself: "How did he make a card that was in the middle of the deck change places with one in my hand?" There is no chance that she can find even a vague or general answer since, of course, that's not what happened.

But you can't do a pass, you say, only a double turnover? Then try this. Have an ace on top of the deck, a king second from the top, and a duplicate ace third from the top. Perform a double turnover to show the king and deal it to the left. Perform another double turnover to show the ace and deal it to the right. Snap your fingers and turn over the two cards to reveal that they've changed places. The spectators will ask themselves, "How could he have switched the two cards on the table when they never came anywhere

near each other?” The answer, of course, is that you couldn't have. The only conclusion left to the audience is that they've witnessed a miracle. (Like the copper/silver transposition mentioned earlier, this is an example of the bank shot approach.)

One last example should make the point. A young would-be magician acquires a marked deck. He uses it to immediately tell people what card they chose. The effect is that he can identify cards without seeing the faces. The method is that he has a deck that allows him to identify cards without seeing the faces. Needless to say, this effect will fool no one.

By contrast, a deviously minded pro might use a marked deck in the following manner. He has the cards arranged in a memorized stack. He pretends about his ability to determine the number of cards in a packet by weight. He has a spectator cut off a packet and hand it to him. While pretending to weigh the cards in his hand, he reads the back of the top card of the remainder of the deck. He then announces the number of cards he is holding (one less than the stack number of the card he read). The spectator counts the packet and verifies that the number is correct.

The spectator walks away asking himself, “How can the performer determine how many cards there are in a packet handed to him?” Because he asks the wrong question, the answer won't be marked cards, (If the performer introduces a conceptual barrier by false shuffling the deck at the outset, the secret will be even safer.)

This is why I consider Gene Finnell's free-cut principle a brilliant concept but consider *Spelling the Aces*, the effect usually associated with it, an inferior use of the concept. The free-cut principle is a method of controlling the positions of cards despite the fact that a spectator buries them in a seemingly random fashion. The effect of *Spelling the Aces* is that the aces end up in the positions the performer wants despite the fact that the spectator buries them in a random fashion. The spectator is left to ask, “How did the aces end up where he wanted despite the fact that I buried them?” Because of the ingenuity of the principle, he is unlikely to ever arrive at a detailed answer. Nevertheless, the effect degenerates into a puzzle rather than a miracle.

Compare this to an application of the free cut principle that Martin Nash and I devised independently and published virtually simultaneously. The spectator “randomly” buries the aces. The performer shuffles the deck, and then shows that he has controlled the four aces to the top. The spectator asks himself, “How could he control those aces despite the fact that I buried them wherever I wanted?” The false premise (that the aces were randomly positioned by the spectator) becomes a “given” in the spectator’s speculations rather than a subject for speculation.

Bob King has accomplished something similar in his version of *The Ten-Handed Poker Deal*. He has the spectator bury the aces. He then gives the deck one riffle shuffle and deals out a ten-handed game. The aces fall to the performer. The inner reality is that the free-cut principle positioned the aces every tenth card from the outset. The false shuffle changed nothing. The outer reality is that the performer stacked the aces in one shuffle. The fact that the spectator buried the aces wherever he wanted before the performer shuffled makes it a particularly astonishing display of skill. The shuffle creates the false frame of reference. If you omitted the shuffle and simply dealt out the ten hands immediately after the spectator buried the aces, you would be back to the same flaw found in *Spelling the Aces*.

The Method/Effect Shift

The goal then is to get the audience to ask the wrong question by *widening the gap* between the method and the effect. But how do we do it? One approach I have found effective is to *use a method associated with one effect to achieve a completely different effect*. Rick Johnsson did this in one of the examples I cited. He used a method associated with a coin *vanish* to achieve a *coin penetration*.

On the **Convention at the Capitol Live 2000** DVD, Mike Caveney teaches the *Impromptu Linking Coat Hangers*. The secret is that one of the hangers is suspended from an invisible wire attached to the performer. The magician holds the other hanger against it to create the illusion that the two are linked. This explanation doesn’t do the effect justice, but it’s good enough for our purposes.

At one point, Caveney jokingly suggests that the gaff could be used to achieve the “amazing floating coat hanger” effect. The audience's laughter confirms that this is not a good idea. The reason why, however, is worth analyzing. Since the *method* is a means of secretly suspending a hanger in midair, using it to create the *effect* of suspending a hanger in midair is not very subtle. The audience will wonder, “What's holding that hanger up?” The question points to the answer: something attached to the performer. Why? Proximity. He's the closest thing to the hanger.

The brilliance of the *Impromptu Linking Coat Hangers* is that it uses a *suspension* method to achieve a *penetration* effect. The linking effect puts all the heat on the hangers, which can withstand examination. The floating effect would put all the heat on the performer, who cannot. The linking effect changes the frame of reference. When people think, “How did he link those hangers together?” they're asking the wrong question.

Many years ago I created a simple Hindu fakir-type effect that I call *The Fire Test*. The performer concentrates intensely for a few moments. He then places a lit match into his left fist. A moment later he opens his fist to show the now-extinguished match and no injury to his hand.

My starting point was a standard effect using a standard method. In the original, the performer makes a lit match vanish from his fist. The method is a metal thumb tip in the left fist. The lit match goes into the thumb tip and, in a continuing action, the tip is loaded onto the right thumb. This is an excellent quick impromptu effect—as long as no one in your audience knows what a thumb tip is.

I used the same method to create a different effect. Before beginning, I hide a burnt match in the crease between my left fingers and palm. Otherwise, the handling is identical to the match-vanish trick. I use a method associated with a *vanish* (the thumb tip) to achieve a *switch* (of the lit match for the burnt match) which is perceived by the audience as a *demonstration of invulnerability*. At the end of the effect, no one will ask himself, “Where did the match go?” And that, of course, is the only question that could possibly lead to the right answer.

Another example of keeping the method but shifting the effect can be found in *Quick Draw* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards**. A spectator selects a card and signs it. He himself inserts the card into the deck and shuffles. I place the shuffled deck in my pocket. I then reach in and instantly pull out the signed selected card.

For this effect I use methodology usually associated with the card-to-pocket plot. Simply put, I palm the selected card and load it into my pocket long before the spectator inserts “his card” (actually a dummy) into the deck and shuffles. Later when I place the shuffled deck in my pocket, it's an easy matter to keep the previously pocketed selection separate from the deck so I can later pull it out.

If I performed this as a card-to-pocket trick, a perceptive spectator might remember when I had casually put my hand in my pocket and proceed to put two and two together. Presenting it as an instantaneous, impossible location changes the frame of reference. Instead of asking, “How did the selected card get into his pocket?” the spectators ask, “How did he find the selected card by sense of touch in a shuffled deck, and in only a split second?” In that context, my having casually put my hand in my pocket earlier seems irrelevant.

In his book **Don't Blink**, Jim Swain has a beautifully constructed effect called *New Wave Prediction*. Four spectators select cards from a faceup deck, thereby eliminating the possibility of a force. The magician then apparently buries the four cards in the deck (actually retaining them on top). He now palms them off and loads them into a gaffed wallet. When he removes the four cards face down from the wallet, he identifies them *as predictions* that he had placed there before the performance. For the climax, he reveals that his predictions match the selections. (They ought to; they're the *same* cards.)

The prediction angle is reinforced by the fact that the back designs of the four cards in the wallet differ from those of the selections. This is a good example of a conceptual barrier blocking off the true explanation. (If you want to learn how Jim achieves this feature you'll have to read his excellent book.)

The point I'm concerned with now, however, is that Jim has taken card-to-wallet methodology and used it for a prediction effect. This guarantees no audience member will even think to ask the one question that could lead to a solution to the mystery: "How did those cards get in his wallet?" Instead, he asks the *wrong question*: "How did he know what cards we would pick?"

From the standpoint of inspiring creativity, I have found it a very useful exercise to examine standard tricks and ask at various points in the effect, "In what different direction could I go from here?" Try it and you may pleasantly surprise yourself with some of the answers you come up with.

From the standpoint of our present discussion, there is an additional moral. When an effect points directly to its method, we tend to look for a different method. This is fine. However, it's also worth experimenting with *keeping the method but changing the effect*. Ask yourself what alternative effect you might achieve using the same method—an alternative effect that generates a false frame of reference.

The final false Solution

We've seen that falsely framing an effect, not only leads people to ask the wrong question, but also causes them to accept the effect's major false premise as a given in formulating that question. Another great tool for getting the audience to unwittingly embrace the false premise can be found in Juan Tamariz's wonderful book **The Magic Way**. He introduces a concept he labels *the final false solution*: "...a solution that will later turn out to be false. But it must appear possible for a few seconds. You must now conclusively demonstrate that the solution is incorrect, totally false, almost absurd!"

The idea is to fashion the effect and presentation in such a way that the audience initially perceives a possible explanation. You leave that possibility open until almost the end. It provides the audience something to cling to. When you finally disprove this hypothesis, the audience has nowhere left to turn. That's when the trapdoor opens under their feet. That red herring is the final false solution.

Tamariz describes the characteristics that a final false solution must possess as follows: “On the one hand, it must be easy to perceive. That is, we should not have to point it out or make it too obvious, in order to get the spectator to see it and follow it. On the other hand, it has to be easy to demonstrate that it's not the real solution, and this demonstration has to be definitive and complete, leaving no room for doubts or confusion of any kind.”

Marlo's spider-grip vanish illustrates the final false solution in its most stripped-down form. You place a coin in your hand and vanish it through the simple ploy of keeping it classic-palmed. It's such a simple ploy that it could never succeed without some psychological cover. The cover is that after you transfer the coin to your right hand, you keep the left hand closed and slightly cramped. In other words, you encourage the audience's natural tendency to suspect the other hand. Now you reveal the vanish by opening your right hand (palm downward to conceal the palmed coin). To the audience, this merely confirms that you kept the coin in the other hand. That belief is the final false solution. When, a moment later, you gesture with your palm-up left hand, showing it empty, the audience is left with no explanation.

Keep in mind that this is not a Ramsay-style sucker move. The audience should never suspect that you deliberately lured them into a false suspicion. Even after you've disproved their theory, they should think that it was all their idea. Although you orchestrate this little drama in the audience's mind, you must appear unaware of its existence. When their theory is disproved, as Tamariz writes, “The spectators will think, 'Oh no. How suspicious I am. The truth is that there is no logical explanation.'”

Here is the fascinating part. To embrace the false solution—that the coin is in your left hand—the audience must also embrace the false premise that the coin is *not* in your right hand. Yet, even when their final solution is proven false, they never go back and question the false premise. If they did, the spider-grip vanish wouldn't fool people. Many coin men can attest that it does.

Here is an example straight from **The Magic Way**. Since I've incorporated it into my own Ambitious Card routine, I'll explain it as I do it.

The ambitious card is supposedly in the middle but actually second from the top. By means of a double turnover I show that it has returned to the top. I turn the double down and push the top card into the middle of the deck

but leave it protruding from the side at an angle, I then push it further in until only about a quarter inch is protruding. Finally, I carefully push the card further until slightly less than the white border is protruding. I hesitate for a moment, then turn to a spectator and ask her to press her forefinger against the side of the deck to push the card the rest of the way.

The point of this by-play is to get the audience to suspect that I may be trying to keep track of the position of the card. Of course, I would have no reason to do that if the card in question weren't really the selection. Every time I hesitate in squaring the card, the spectators become convinced more and more that I'm trying to control the card. At the same time, without realizing it; they are convincing themselves more and more that the sidejogged card really is the selection. Having bought into that premise, they've unwittingly painted themselves into a corner. When I have the spectator push the card squarely into the deck, the audience has to accept that I have no way of locating the selected card. Better still, they have long since accepted that it *is* the selected card.

Another good example is the tent vanish of the final ace in Larry Jennings' *Open Travelers*, (If you use the rub-a-dub vanish instead, the following analysis still applies.) Your immediate goal is to vanish the card in a convincing manner. Your more fundamental goal, however, is to perpetuate the lie that the card in your hand is an ace. In fact, the ace is already on the table with the other three. You place the "ace" cantilevered on the deck and pretend to palm it. If you've done the actions of the tent vanish well, the audience will believe that the ace is hidden in your hand. They will, therefore, be quite startled when you turn your hand over to show it empty. But the moment that the surprise wears off, most people will suspect that the ace is actually on top of the deck. (It's like looking at the right hand when the coin vanishes from the left hand,) This is a good thing because it provides the final false solution.

Sensing this suspicion, you turn over the top card to show that it's not the ace. Now the audience has nowhere to turn. They've hit a dead end. They have to accept that the ace has truly vanished. Just as importantly, in suspecting that the ace was on top of the deck, the audience locked itself into the false premise that the card in question was an ace. From the moment they asked themselves, "Where did the ace go?" they were doomed. Turning over the top card of the deck disproves the false solution but leaves them committed to the *false premise*.

One of the cleverest applications of the final false solution that I've seen is in Mac King's performance of Looey Simonoffs *Earth Shoes*. The effect consists of the performer taking off his shoe and dumping out a huge rock. The method consists of secretly loading the rock from your pocket as you bring the shoe up to waist level. The usual handling is for the performer to invert the shoe so that the rock falls out and hits the ground. The resulting crash proves that it's a real rock, not a collapsible foam-rubber fake. Mac King's alteration is that he doesn't drop the rock from the shoe to the floor. Instead, he catches it in his hand and then drops it to the floor.

Doesn't sound like much of a difference, does it? Not unless you look at it from the audience's point of view. When that huge rock drops from the shoe to the performer's hand, the audience knows that he couldn't have been walking around with a real rock in his shoe all this time. Therefore, it can't be a real rock. Everyone has seen the very convincing foam-rubber rocks sold in novelty stores. Clearly, that must be what the magician has been walking around with in his shoe. King holds the rock in his hand just long enough to allow this final false solution to form in the audience's mind. He then crushes the theory by allowing the rock to smash to the ground.

The moment that the audience assumes that the rock is a foam-rubber fake, they're accepting the premise that it's been inside the shoe throughout the entire performance. Having bought the false premise that underpins the whole effect, they've boxed themselves in. When the rock hits the floor, they hit the wall.

Frame of Reference and Kickers

Many years ago Hen Fetch created a classic coincidence effect called *Smith's Myth*. Two spectators mentally select cards. They then shuffle the deck and divide it in two. The performer deals cards face up simultaneously from the two piles as the spectators are instructed to call out stop when they see their cards. Miraculously, the two mentally selected cards turn up together.

The secret is that, through a clever procedure, both spectators are led to think of the same card. Naturally they will later call out stop at the same time. Each thinks that the indifferent card paired with the selection is the other persons card.

Years ago a magician, now deceased, showed me his kicker to this trick. After the coincidence effect had registered, he had both spectators call out the names of their cards on the count of three. The big surprise was, of course, that they both named the same card. The bigger surprise is that anyone could have thought that this was a good idea.

This is an extreme case of destroying the effect just to get *one* more climax. Many magicians, however, make the same error in subtler, but equally damaging, ways. Like many magicians, this man was enamored of kicker endings. To achieve one, he was willing to destroy a beautifully constructed false frame of reference. Before the kicker, the audience had been asking. "How did he make those two cards turn up together?" (Wrong question. Therefore, no possible answer) After the kicker, they were asking. "How did he get them to both pick the same card?" (Right question. Answer: who cares?)

Recently. I witnessed for the first time a performance of Pavel's *Super Walking Knot*, Since I'm pretty much of a layman when it comes to rope magic. I think my reaction in this case may be indicative of a lay audience's.

The effect consists of stretching a rope across the stage over the backs of two chairs. The performer cuts the rope near one end and ties the ends together He then *drag* the knot to the center of the rope and unties it. The cut has actually moved from one part of the rope to the other. He ties the ends together again and drags the knot to the other end of the rope. Once more he unties the knot to show that the cut has traveled yet again.

I thought this a truly wonderful effect—until the magician performed the final phase. He tied the ends together one more time. He then pulled off the knot and showed the rope restored. At that point I realized that he was merely using some kind of tricky rope that can be pulled apart and stuck together at will I don't know how such a rope works and I don't care. (I'd be willing to bet that a layperson would care even less than I do.)

As long as I had been held captive by a false interpretation of the effect—the knot moves—I was enchanted. The second that the kicker restoration of the rope reoriented me toward a true interpretation of events—the rope pulls apart and sticks together—I was bored. The kicker ending had literally “dis-illusioned” me.

Recently an ingenious self-working effect was published that quickly gained popularity. While the performers back is turned, two spectators randomly cut to cards and return them to the deck. The performer then turns around and announces the locations of the two selections. When the cards are counted down, his divination proves correct. As a kicker, he reveals two written predictions, showing that he knew the locations of the two selections even before the trick started.

Several magicians observed on Internet boards that they had found that the second climax seemed to weaken audience response. The spectators were more impressed *before* the predictions were revealed. Intense discussions ensued as to why this might be. I would suggest that the problem here is the same as in our two previous examples. The performer's desire to add another climax leads him to reveal too much of the truth.

This effect is based on an ingenious placement principle that allows the performer to control the locations of the two cards. Wisely, the initial presentation falsely frames the effect as a divination. The kicker, however, reframes it in a more accurate light. Only after the second climax is the audience led to ask the right question: How did the performer control the two cards to predetermined positions? Admittedly, the spectators are not likely to ever be able to answer that question in detail. Yet, the mere act of asking it begins to suggest the vague outlines of a solution. That's enough to weaken the sense of impossibility.

In fact, prediction kickers often have this unwanted result. The “I knew it all along” type of blow-off to an effect is risky because it tends to invalidate everything that came before. One always has to decide on a case-by-case basis, but consider carefully before adopting such a kicker.

I have nothing against kicker endings. I perform and have published several effects that incorporate them. However, they can easily lead you into a seductive trap. Your goal should not be to provide as many climaxes as possible. It should be to provide as strong an experience of impossibility as possible. A kicker that replaces a false frame of reference with a true frame of reference won't serve that goal.

This leads us to another specific application of Henning Nelms' conservation principle: *Don't add a kicker to an effect that would allow the audience to accurately reinterpret what happened previously.*

The Crooked Path

“I love an outer simplicity that conceals an inner complexity.”

George Santayana

The moral of frame of reference is simple: always look for ways to lead the spectator to perceive the *outer reality* of the effect in ways totally divorced from the *inner reality* of the method. Avoid anything that pushes these inner and outer realities toward each other. When the spectator asks himself, “How did he do that?” he should be asking about something you never did.

Presentation can play a major role in creating a false frame of reference in an audience's mind. That, however, is a subject for another book (one that I've already written). Our concern here is how effect design can contribute to this goal. The answer is that your methods should be nonlinear and as divorced from the perceived effect as possible.

Chapter Height: Visual Magic

“Harbin told me that the bare hand vanish of a cane was no good because the viewer could guess that the stick must collapse somehow. On the other hand when he wrapped it in a newspaper the moment of the vanish is not apparent and a real mystery occurs.”

Martin Lewis

“The less they see, the more they believe.”

Jacques Tourneur,
director of **Cat People** other classics

I'm sure that there have been several points in the discussion so far where many of you have thought, “But what about visual effects, tricks like *Spellbound* and color changes with cards? Don't they violate all of these principles and don't they work great?” The answer is: not necessarily. Depending on the specific effect, they don't necessarily violate the above principles and, when they do, they don't necessarily work great.

Defining Visual Magic

The phrase “visual magic,” like most magic terms, is often used imprecisely and inconsistently. Magicians sometimes use the phrase “very visual” simply to mean highly *visible* effects, those that can be easily seen by a large audience, that's not what I'm talking about here. Also, it goes without saying that virtually all magic effects have a visual component in the sense that you need your eyesight to follow what's happening.

Other than that, when I've asked magicians what they mean by visual magic, the answers are usually: magic that “happens visibly” or “without any cover,” “effects where people *see* the magic happen.” In fact, with the exception of animations and levitations, there are almost no close-up effects that fit these descriptions,

Spellbound is one of the most visual of coin effects. Yet one never *sees* the copper coin transmute into silver. The change happens under cover of the fingers as they rub the coin. The same is true of most color changes. Yet, if a color change isn't visual magic, what is? Most magicians would

agree that Guy Hollingworth has created an exceptionally visual version of the *Torn and Restored Card*. Yet, we never actually see the edges of the torn pieces fuse together. It always happens under a momentary cover of the fingers.

Similarly, the Pendragons' version of the sub trunk is generally regarded as one of the most visual illusions of all time because of the transformation from Charlotte to Jonathon. Yet, we don't see Charlotte transform into Jonathan the way we often see one person morph into another in TV commercials. (Compare the Pendragons illusion to the classic carnival illusion *Girl to Gorilla*, which does involve a visible transformation. You'll see the difference.) The transformation from female Pendragon to male Pendragon happens behind a sheet, not “visibly”, not “without any cover.”

Therefore, I'll offer a definition of what I think most magicians actually mean most of the time when they talk about visual magic. Since we used Ascanio's definition of a magic *effect* as the difference between the *initial condition* and the *final condition*, let's use the same concepts to define visual magic. *A visual effect is one in which minimal time elapses between the audience's last glimpse of the initial condition and their first glimpse of the final condition.*

Robert-Houdin said that before you change an apple into an orange you should make sure the audience knows it's an apple. The elapsed time mentioned in my definition refers to the *critical interval* between the audience's last glimpse of the apple and their first glimpse of the orange.

What constitutes “minimal time” elapsed? There can be no hard and fast rule. Visual magic is not an either/or proposition. It's a matter of degree. This much we can say: *the shorter the critical interval the more visual the effect.*

Consider three different ways of transforming a card: 1) I do a double turnover to show a king. I turn the double face down and deal off the top card. I rub it against the tabletop and then turn it over to reveal that it's now an ace, 2) I show that I'm holding a king. I turn it face down and snap it against the deck. In the process I execute a Hofzinger top change. Then I turn over the card to reveal an ace. 3) I show a king on the face of the deck

and then perform a color change to transform it into an ace. Clearly, the second version is more visual than the first and the third version is more visual than second. The difference is the length of the critical interval between the last time they see the king and the first time they see the ace. This illustrates how visuality in magic is a continuum with every effect being a point somewhere along that continuum. It's a matter of degree.

Here's an example for non-cardmen. If I seal an English penny in an envelope, have the spectator initial the flap, wave a magic wand over the envelope, and direct the spectator to rip open the envelope and spill out the contents to reveal that it has changed to a half-dollar, this *is* not visual magic. If I rub my fingertips across an English penny and, as the fingers slide off the coin, the audience sees that it's changed to a half-dollar, this is visual magic. If I place an English penny in a spectator's hand, have her blow on her fist and then open it to reveal a half-dollar, this is more visual than the first version but less visual than the second. It's just a matter of how long the coin was out of sight.

The Pendragons' version of *Metamorphosis* is so visual because so little time elapses between your last glimpse of Charlotte and your first glimpse of Jonathon—despite the fact that the actual transformation happens behind a sheet.

I'll introduce one last term that I think will help in our discussion: *the visual moment*. In visual effects we might say that the visual moment is *the instant that the final condition is revealed to the audience*. The first glimpse of the orange is the visual moment. The card and coin transformations I described above differ in terms of conditions and procedures. But for purposes of this discussion, the key difference is in how long the performer waits before revealing the visual moment.

Visual vs. Mental Components

“Deception through the senses only is not as strong as deception which not only attacks the senses but also influences the reasoning.”

Dariel Fitzkee, **Magic by Misdirection**

I've heard some magicians describe magic as pure visual entertainment. A fireworks display is pure visual entertainment. A kaleidoscope is pure visual entertainment. Juggling comes close. (Even here, there is an intellectual component involved in appreciating the performers skill. This is a major source of juggling's entertainment value. The other major source is the aesthetic appeal. That part is pure visual entertainment.) Magic, however, is *not* pure visual entertainment.

Doc Shiels' observation that “all magic is mental” applies equally to visual magic. The spectator's eyes don't determine that he has seen a miracle; his mind does. Even in a visual effect, it's the audience's intellectual decision—comparing the initial condition to the final condition—that makes the trick a miracle. That's why visual impact alone isn't enough. The visual element only provides shock value. It's the context you create for the visual element that determines how powerfully it works as magic. Spellbound is only a miracle. If you don't answer certain that your hands are empty except for the one coin. This is something you must establish before and after the visual transformation without this conviction in the spectators' Minds. I'll simply say he's really fast with his hands.

Magicians have coined an apt term for visual magic that lacks a “mental” component. They call it eye candy. I define eye candy as visual magic that has no lasting element of mystery to support the visual moment. Eye candies is like cotton candy. It looks good, but lacks substance.

Beyond even eye candy is the type of effect that magicians often term visual gags. These are effects that fool the eye without fooling the mind or that full the eye and mind initially, but become transparent the moment the surprise wears off. Such effects include the venerable illusion of pulling off your thumb, the old Mummy's finger achieved with a hole at the bottom of box and the Cigarette Up The Nose. The term gag is that since the usual audience reaction is laughter. People laugh out of surprise and at themselves for being so easily momentarily deceived.

These effects don't fail as mystery because the visual illusion isn't compelling. Indeed, part of the humor comes from how such an obvious method can look so elusive. These effects lack mystery because they have nothing going for them except visual illusion. They don't fool the mind. No

matter how good it looks. The spectator knows that the cigarette didn't really go up your nose. And if it didn't go up your nose, it must have gone into your hand. If it didn't come out of your ear. It must have come out of your hand.

Such bits of business do offer laughter and surprise? And there is nothing wrong with that. Unfortunately, many people believe that such gags are all there is to magic. It would be a pity to live down to their expectations. Purely visual magic often comes close to doing that. In many cases, the only difference between visual gags and the visual magic so popular today is one of degree. The difference can be measured in how long it takes the audience to put two and two together.

Magic that offers the audience nothing beyond visual impact may provide momentary shock value and perhaps aesthetic appeal. It may also impress the audience with your skill, but it evokes no lasting sense of wonder. To use an analogy I've employed before this kind of “flashy magic” is like watching a rerun of *The Dukes of Hazzard* — diverting while it's on, but forgotten the moment it ends.

Magic is all about implications. Nothing you can actually doing a magic trick is ever going to be all that important or all that impossible. Therefore the true impact of magic must come from the implications that the audience reads into what they see. Your goal should always be to fill their imaginations with such implications. Visual magic, no matter how eye-popping, has value only to the extent that it ignites in the audience's imagination thoughts about what you could do or supposedly are doing beyond what they actually see you do in the visual moment. No matter how startling it may be, the only valid purpose of the visual elements in any effect is to *stimulate the audience's imagination*. If it fails to do that, it fails as magic.

Laying the groundwork

The importance of mental component in effective visual magic leads us to a key principle: it's what comes before the visual *moment that determines whether that moment register as a miracle*.

Larry Jennings' *The Open Travelers* has three very powerful magic moments: each time an ace materializes from your *empty* palm. When the effect is properly performed (from both a technical *and* presentational standpoint), each of these moments produces gasps, dropping jaws, *and* popping eyes from a lay audience.

Yet, what are you doing at the moment that you get these reactions? You're merely spreading a tabled double with your hand. Of course, even this simple action has to be performed properly to get the desired audience response. It has to look like a card fell from your hand, not like you spread over a card that was already lying there. Nevertheless, the mechanics that produce the magical moment—spreading the double are so elementary in concept that any audience could easily figure out what must be happening if they saw the move in isolation. What keeps them from doing so are the techniques that come before the spreading.

There are two keys to the deception in the Open Travelers. The first is the techniques that conceal the presence of a fifth card, the second is the technique, that secretly transfer each ace from one packet to the other long before the audience suspects it has happened.

All these techniques occur before each visual moment, the audience reacts in astonishment to the spreading of the double, but it's not the spread of the double that fools them. It's the convictions you create in their mind prior to spreading each double that make the effect a miracle. The design of *The Open Travelers* is such that those groundwork-laying techniques brilliantly incorporate temporal and spatial separation, concept barriers, and raise frame of reference.

The importance of prior groundwork is also well illustrated by two examples from the world of stage illusions. Certainly, there can be few grand illusions more visual than David Copperfield's *Flying*. If ever there was a visual effect that would seem to speak for itself with no need to mentally prepare the audience, this is it. The guy just takes off and flies around the stage. That's the effect. Pure visual magic. No preamble needed.

If you've seen the effect, however, you know that Copperfield provides a lot of preamble. He brings two spectators on stage and proceeds to construct

a large clear plastic cage within which the illusion will take place. He has the spectators inspect every component of this cage. In other words, he takes the time and trouble to eliminate every possible explanation before performing the effect. In fact, he spends more time on these preliminaries than he does actually flying. (I know. I timed it.)

Suppose that, instead of taking the time to lay this groundwork, Copperfield merely delivered his patter about dreams of flying and then lifted off. All the time that he was flying, the viewer would simply be thinking, "I wonder how they hide the wires so you can't see them."

Even with an effect as visual as this, the magical experience is not what happens in front of the spectators' eyes. It's what happens in their minds. That means that you must, as Copperfield does, take the time to create the proper mental set to ensure that what the spectator sees will register as a miracle rather than as just a pretty picture.

By contrast, here is an example of a visual stage illusion that lacked the proper groundwork and suffered as a result. In the off-Broadway show Ricky Jay on the Stem, one scene features a sideshow theme. In the background is a table with a covered serving dish. At one point, Ricky walks upstage and lifts the lid to reveal a severed human head. After a few moments, the head opens its eyes and looks around. Ricky then covers it again, and continues with the show.

When I saw the show, this effect received nothing more than mild chuckles from the audience. Within the context of the scene, it was merely fended as a throwaway and adequately served that purpose. Nevertheless, it's worth considering why this classic effect that is still capable of stunning audience failed to do so.

This effect, called 'The Sphinx' has traditionally been presented starting with a bare tabletop. The performer enters carrying a box, which he places on the table. He opens the front of the box to reveal a human head. The head then comes to life and answers questions.

The difference between the two presentations may seem trivial. However, the bare table and the magician carrying out the box are important groundwork. They're calculated to create the belief that the disembodied head is inside the box. With this mental set, the audience asks the question. "How can an unattached head live?" Of course, there is no answer. In Ricky Jays presentation, the head is on the table from the start. Nothing is done to plant the prior assumption that the head is truly unattached. A living head on a table will immediately lead people to assume that the head's owner must be *under* the table. With this mindset, the only question to ponder is the correct one: "How do they hide the guy's body under the table?" The answer: puzzles bore me.

Strengthening Visual Magic

Momentary Delay

It follows from the above that, even in a visual effect, you need temporal and spatial distance and conceptual barriers if you're aiming for lasting mystery rather than just momentary shock. A particularly effective approach is to introduce a very brief time delay before revealing the visual moment. Even the smallest delay can allow you to achieve distance in time and/or space. This leads to a paradoxical but potent concept, the *delayed visual effect*.

There is an interesting psychological point that makes delayed visual effects possible. *In visual magic, the audience believes that the effect happens when the effect is revealed to them (the visual moment).* This is something peculiar to visual magic. If you do a selected-card-to-pocket effect, the audience doesn't assume that the card arrives in your pocket at the instant you pull it out. But in a visual vanish, they do believe that the coin vanishes the moment your fingers open to reveal the vanish. This is just as true of a visual production, transposition, transformation or penetration. There is a quasi-visual retention—really a *psychological retention*—that you can exploit in these situations.

Slydini's *One-Coin Routine*, one of the most visual of coin effects, provides a perfect example. The performer holds a coin at his fingertips. His fingers brush against the table edge, at which instant he laps the coin.

The hand continues traveling toward the center of the table, the coin apparently hidden behind the fingertips. The fingers now spread, revealing that the coin is gone. To the audience, the vanish appears to happen mid-table. The two seconds between lapping the coin and revealing the vanish allow the performer to create considerable distance between the method (at the table edge) and the effect (at mid-table).

As anyone who has seen the routine properly performed can attest the vanish is still extremely visual despite the brief interval between the audience's last view of the coin (the initial condition) and their first view of the empty hand (the final condition). It could be argued that the vanish would be even more visual if the fingers opened the instant the coin was lapped. But, of course, it would fool no one. On balance, it seems worth the sacrifice.

In fact, you're not sacrificing anything. When you allow the coin to disappear from view as your hand travels from the table edge to the center of the table, the mind's eye still pictures the coin behind your fingers. So strong is this mental image, that the spectators will think *they see* the coin disappear at your fingertips at the center of the table. This is what I mean by psychological retention.

Here is an analogous case from the realm of card magic. In **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table** I published an effect called *Darwin's Aces*. It involved vanishing the four aces one at a time. I vanished the last ace by placing it face-up on top of the deck and performing a side-steal color change. By stealing a facedown card off the bottom of the deck and depositing it on the face-up ace I appeared to make it disappear.

Since publishing the effect I've changed the handling of this last vanish. I now use the Elmsley vanish from **The Collected Works of Alex Elmsley**. The Elmsley vanish uses an Erdnase color change rather than a side steal color change to deposit a face-down card on the face-up ace. This is not, however, the important difference. In the Elmsley version, you execute the color change in the act of apparently openly palming the ace. You then move the hand with the "palmed ace" to the center of the table. There you rub it against the tabletop, slowly spreading your fingers. The card appears to melt away at mid-table.

In my original handling, both method and effect happened on top of the deck. Now the method still happens on top of the deck but the effect happens a couple of feet from the deck. (Remember, in visual magic, the audience believes the magic happens when it is revealed—and consequently *where* it is revealed.) Clearly, with this latter handling there is less chance of a spectator suspecting the real method.

Yet because of the concept of psychological retention, the effect is as visual as ever. Ironically, I think it's now *more* visual in spite of (because of?) the brief time delay. The illusion of the card dissolving as I rub the table is uncanny. This has been driven home to me not only by my own observations in the mirror but also by the reactions of countless audiences.

Just an aside for the analytically minded. If you're into analyzing on different levels of abstraction—a useful thing in design work—you might note that the Elmsley vanish is analogous to the earlier example of the *Vanishing Radio*. The ace sinks into the deck just as the radio collapses into the table. The performer's hand retains the form of the card just as the cloth retains the form of the radio. The hand moves forward to the table to vanish the card just as the stage performer walks downstage to vanish the radio. Both actions serve to draw the audience's eyes from where the method occurred.

In *Darwin's Ambitious Card* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards**, at one point I insert the ambitious card into the deck face up. I then perform a pass to make it visually appear on top. Using a pass in this way in an Ambitious Card routine is an old idea. It's usually done with some variation of the classic pass. The two hands converge on the deck and the face-up card suddenly appears on top. The magic is totally visual. One instant the card isn't there, the next instant it is. This is one of those rare instances where visual magic happens with no cover at all. The performer relies on pure speed and technique to hide the modus operandi.

My approach in *Darwin's Ambitious Card* is a little different. I use my variation of the Hermann pass. The move happens in the act of turning the left hand palm down. More specifically, the right hand comes over to square the cards. Most of the pass is performed at this point. The left hand then turns palm down, completing the pass in the process. To the audience, it

appears as follows. I insert the card face up into the center of the deck and square the cards. I then turn my hand palm downward for an instant and give the deck a shake. When I turn my hand over again, the face-up card is on top.

I prefer this handling because it eliminates a problem with the classic pass approach: the fact that both hands have to converge on the deck to make the card appear on top. Every other time the card comes to the top, the deck is held with just one hand. But, the one time it comes to the top face up, both hands have to clutch the deck.

I'm not concerned here, however, with whether you agree with my objection to the classic pass approach. I only want to analyze how my approach exploits psychological retention. Both hands still have to converge on the deck to square it. But, as far as the audience knows, nothing happens at this point. When the left hand starts to turn palm down, the top of the deck still shows a facedown card. The right hand now falls away as the left hand finishes turning palm down. I give the deck a shake and turn the hand palm up again. At this moment the audience first sees the face-up card on top.

Remember, in visual magic, the audience feels that the effect *happens* when the effect is *revealed to* them (the visual moment). When I reveal the face-up card on top, my right hand is at my side, far from the deck. The audience saw a facedown card on top of the deck as my left hand stand to turn down. A psychological retention of that image stayed with them. I gave the deck a shake. When the face-up card comes into view after the shake, it seems to have materialized in *that* instant.

My right hand was at my side during the shake and the subsequent revelation of the face-up card on top. Through the use of a delay of only second or two a two-handed move appears to be an impossible *one-handed* production of the card. And, thanks to the concept of psychological retention, the appearance of the face-up card is just as visual as with a classic pass.

If you always insist that the audience must *see* the magic happen, you may fool the eye but you'll often leave a trail of clues for the mind to follow. Consider, for example, some of the topit vanishes that have become

fashionable recently. In an effort to have the vanish happen in full view, the principle is used nakedly. The performer simply snaps or flings the object into the topit. The speed of the action prevents the *eye* from following the path of the object. But, a moment later when the shock wears off, the *mind* can easily deduce what that path must have been. What was the object near when it vanished? The open jacket. Hmm, could that be where it went?

Suppose, instead, you apparently transfer the object to the other hand at the moment of tossing it into the topit. The closed hand then moves well away from the body and then opens to reveal the vanish. (This is similar to the handling often used with pulls.) Little would be lost in visual impact and much would be gained in subtle design. The method happens near the body. The effect happens away from the body.

In any visual effect, always consider whether a momentary delay in revealing the visual moment might allow you to create spatial separation. A *delayed* visual effect is still a visual effect, only more mysterious.

Time Displacement in Visual Magic

The weakness of much visual magic is that the method coincides with the effect. The move happens at the exact moment that the visual magic happens. It's hard to misdirect attention from the move if the audience has to be looking at your hands at the moment you do it in order to see the visual effect. Similarly, tension-relaxation misdirection (discussed in **Strong Magic**) depends on relaxing during the method but tensing during the effect. This is impossible if method and effect converge.

Many die-hard fans of visual magic will respond that this just means that you need perfect technique. The problem with this argument is that visual effects are often done pretty much the way one would think they would have to be done. When that's the case, perfect technique will fool the eye but it won't fool the mind.

I've already suggested that the best visual effects depend for their impact on secret work accomplished long before or after the *visual moment*. Indeed the subtlest visual effects are those in which, rather than effect and method coinciding, the audience is deceived into *thinking* they coincide. They're led

to believe that the magic happens at the visual moment, when the truth is far different.

Guy Hollingworth's *Waving The Aces* is a fine version of *Twisting the Aces* largely because the visual reversal is a scam. In fact, the card is reversed long before the audience realizes it. The real reversal happens while you're holding the cards down by your leg. You secretly flip the card over, using your leg for leverage. You then use the Jennings optical move to create a forward time displacement.

Another example of a beautifully constructed visual effect is Bill Goldman's *Monkey In The Middle*. Once again, you achieve the bulk of the effect long before the audience suspects it. You sandwich the selection between the two cards well in advance. Yet the clever use of a standard gaff creates the illusion that the selection materializes between the two cards long after all the dirty work has been finished.

As these examples show, it's possible to achieve visual impact without sacrificing sound design. In visual magic, as in all magic, look to keep method and effect separated, and don't make the mistake of thinking that fast hands are a substitute for cunning thinking.

***Conceptual Barriers in* Visual Magic**

It's worth repeating: Visual effects are often done pretty much the way one would think they would have to be done. This makes it all the more important to utterly disprove the correct explanation. It can be a challenge to figure out how to build a wall between the effect and the obvious method in a visual effect. But success can dramatically improve audience impact.

Anyone who sees a magician perform *Spellbound* and doesn't suspect that he is simply switching one coin for another through sleight of hand is brain dead. Therefore, the key to making the effect a miracle is disproving that theory. The best way to do so is to convince the audience that you don't have another coin in your hands. Any techniques that strengthen that conviction are worth far more than learning yet another way to visually switch one coin for the other.

Most packet All Backs routines rely on holding two cards together face to face and claiming that they're actually a double-backed card. No matter how well you handle the double, the concept of holding two cards together face to face is not hard for intelligent people to grasp. Indeed, even a real double-backed card, by its nature, suggests the notion of two cards held together face to face. When you later print a face on the card, it may be visual, but is it hard to deduce that you may simply have removed one of the two face-to-face cards? This is why, in my packet All Backs routine *The New Back Off* I created a handling whereby each double-backer could be handed out for examination immediately prior to my printing a face on it. Thus, no one could doubt that each was a single card with a back printed on both sides.

Of course, once you establish that you're starting with a real double-backer, when you then print a face on it, the natural conclusion for the audience to draw is that you must have exchanged the double-backer for a regularly printed card (kind of like with *Spellbound*). For that reason, I start by establishing convincingly that *every* card in the packet is a double-backer. And I continually reinforce that conviction throughout the routine (kind of like establishing and reinforcing that you don't have a second coin palmed during *Spellbound*).

The combination of these two conceptual barriers to establish that I'm not doing what they might have thought I was means that each time I print a face on the double-backer, it not only carries a visual shock, it registers as a true impossibility.

Limitations of Visual Magic

One limitation of visual close-up magic is that its impact decreases as the spectator's distance from the effect increases. This limits its value when doing close-up for a large group. The farther away the spectator is, the smaller the visual effect appears and the less impact it has on him. By contrast, in undercover magic, the effect happens entirely in the mind of your audience. If you're successful in conjuring up the desired mental image, it will be just as powerful in the mind of a spectator in the last row as it is in the mind of a spectator in the first row.

One reason many magicians hate mentalism is that most mental effects have little visual clement. Yet, that's precisely why a good mentalist can work to an audience of two thousand using nothing but a pad of paper and a couple of other small props. A close-up magician in the same venue would die.

One of the strongest effects I do is a trick from **Cardshark** called *Harry in Your Pocket*. I've done it successfully for audiences far larger than we usually associate with close-up magic. This is because the magic literally happens inside a spectator's pocket. No one can see it happen, no matter how close they are. They have to *imagine* what may have occurred inside that pocket. What happens in the imagination of the spectators farthest away is no different from what happens in the imagination of the spectators closest to the action. Consequently, distance doesn't diminish the effect.

Exploiting Visual Magic

As a Time Displacement Device

I've already spoken of the importance of building time displacements into visual magic to make it more miraculous. Intriguingly, we can sometimes use visual magic itself as a time displacement device. We do this by exploiting in a different way a principle I mentioned earlier: *In visual magic, the audience believes that the effect happens when the effect is revealed to them (the visual moment)*. This allows us to use visual magic to convince an audience that an effect occurred much later (or earlier) than it really did. We do this by introducing a visual element into a longer effect to signal the magic.

A simple example would be a standard color-changing deck effect. Suppose you take out a red deck with a blue ten of spades on top. Through various subtleties you convey the impression that this is actually a blue deck.

You now take out a red-backed ten of spades (the one actually belonging to this deck) and insert it into the middle of the “blue” deck.

You announce that you'll change the color of every card in the deck. You perform a classic pass that sends the blue cover card to the middle and reveals a red back on top. You then spread the deck to show that every card now has a red back except the ten of spades, which has a blue back, the exact opposite of the initial condition.

The classic pass makes the effect highly visual, as the audience seems to set the deck change color. This visual moment appears to pinpoint exactly when the deck changed color.

This impression is, of course, false. The bulk of the methodology took place much earlier and consisted of the various subtleties to disguise the red deck as a blue deck. But the natural tendency of the audience is to believe that you changed the color of the deck at the moment they saw it change. As long as they believe that the transformation occurred when you executed the pass they have no prayer of penetrating the mystery of the color-changing deck. They're looking for the explanation at the wrong time. The visual dement becomes a perfect time displacement device.

A similar situation occurs in *The Last Laugh* from **Scams Fantaisies with Cards**. The effect is that two red aces instantly trap any card the spectator names. The performer places one red ace face up on top of the deck and the other face up on the bottom. The spectator names a card. Instantly, the aces vanish from view (again thanks to a pass). The performer spreads the deck and the audience sees the face-up aces in the center with one card trapped between them. It proves to be the named card.

To a layperson, the conclusion is irresistible that the red aces located and trapped the named card in the fraction of a second they vanished from view. In reality, the card had been secretly located and maneuvered into position to be trapped much earlier. Because the audience believes that the effect happened at the moment they saw the aces vanish, they overlook the casual handling that had occurred earlier. That handling was, of course, the real key to the mystery.

Finally, consider a visual effect we've already discussed, *Metamorphosis*. The Pendragons' split-second transformation is breathtaking. But what makes the effect a miracle that lingers in the audience's imaginations is the

complete false belief that the person inside the trunk changes places with the person atop the trunk in that highly visual split-second.

Of course. Jonathan is escaping from the trunk and getting into position for the transformation long *before* the visual moment. Charlotte is still sneaking into the sack in the trunk long *after* the visual moment. Once again, the audience believes the *method* happens at the moment they see the *effect* happen. The visual transformation thus functions as a brilliant device of both forward and backward time displacement. A rather long and intricate method is, in their minds, squeezed into the blink of an eye. All of these examples use a visual moment to create *time compression*.

Each also uses a visual moment to force the audience to ask the wrong question. How could he undetectably switch a blue deck for a red deck in full view and in a *split-second*? (No switch of decks ever occurred.) How could the aces travel through the deck to trap a card in a split-second? (The aces never change their positions relative to the other cards in the deck.) How can a person inside a trunk change places with a person outside a trunk in the blink of an eye? (Both people are outside the trunk both before and after the transformation.)

A little thinking will furnish you with more examples where incorporating a visual element into a longer effect can create a time displacement. More importantly; a little imagination will allow you to create these situations in your own magic. Always look for opportunities to convey a false impression of *when* an effect happens by creating a visual moment either before or after the bulk of the method happens.

As a Validating Phase

Another ideal way to use visual magic is as a single phase in a multiphase effect. The visual phase then becomes the *validating phase*. It *proves* the other phases by establishing that the magic really does happen at the moment—and in the manner—that you claim.

We know that, in visual magic, the audience believes the magic happens at the visual moment. (In most cases, unfortunately, they're correct.) We are here going to make that belief work for us. For example, in most handlings

of *The Ambitious Card*, the card is actually sneaked to the top *touch* earlier than we lead the audience to believe. In fact, often the card never leaves the top of the deck. We merely create the illusion that we're burying it. This is precisely what makes the effect such a mystery. When the audience is expecting something to happen, *nothing* happens because we've already done the dirty work.

But if this combination of time displacement and raise frame of reference is the great strength of *The Ambitious Card*, it's also its great secret. It's the one thing the audience must never be allowed to suspect. A powerful

way to conceal that secret is to include one phase where the audience actually *sets* the card travel from the center of the deck to the top.

I've already mentioned the idea of using a pass so that you can insert the card face up into the deck and let the audience see it instantly materialize on top. Alternatively, Geoff Latta and Ray Kosby have both devised handlings in which the ambitious card is left outjogged in the middle of the deck. While in that condition, it rises in stages to the top. Any of these handlings seems to conclusively prove that you're really doing what you claim to be doing. They can't doubt the evidence of their eyes.

Adding one of these handlings to your routine pays a double dividend. The visual phase will itself evoke a strong reaction. More importantly, this visual phase lends credibility to all the non-visual phases, thereby strengthening the entire routine.

What is true in card magic is true in coin magic. Halfway through John Carney's version of the Misers Dream. *Money For Nothing*, he turns his hand palm toward the audience. They can see that the hand is empty. A coin then visibly materializes at his fingertips. This one time the audience gets to see that he is doing what he claims to be doing, plucking coins out of the air. Having established that. John can now go back to using more subtle methods.

Positioning such a phase midway in a routine radiates credibility both backward and forward. It retroactively validates the previous phases and prospectively validates the subsequent ones. It squashes any doubts that

might have started forming in the audience's minds about whether you were really doing what you claimed to be doing. It also predisposes them to accept unskeptically the phases to come. Indeed, you can often get away with the most bald-faced swindles immediately after such a visual proving phase.

I've always felt that Dai Vernon's original approach to *Twisting the Aces* and those subsequent versions that follow his lead are the strongest. Using false counts for time displacement permits you to appear to cause each card to turn over despite the slowest, fairest, most open handling. The magic just seems to happen. The various visual handlings of the plot that have recently captured magicians' imaginations never, in my view, achieve the same mystery. (This is admittedly a minority view.) I think, however, that incorporating *one* visual turnover borrowed from one of these newer routines into a more traditional routine could be very effective. It would both startle in its own right and strengthen the more mysterious phases by legitimizing the whole process in the audience's minds.

Of course, the visual phase doesn't have to go in the middle. This should be decided by dramatic considerations. Since the routine must build in strength, the positioning of the visual phase should be determined by how strong it is relative to the other phases.

Sometimes the visual phase works best at the end. For example, probably the oldest visual Ambitious Card phase is *The Pop-Up Card* from **Expert Card Technique**. The performer puts a strong bend in the card before burying it in the deck. When the card travels to the top, the audience can see it arrive because the bend makes it pop up. This is one of the strongest possible endings for the Ambitious Card. However, this handling would be to less effective if performed in isolation because, like most visual magic, it's very brief. For an audience to fully appreciate a miracle, they must first be brought up to the proper level of interest and expectation. A quick visual effect like the pop-up card doesn't provide enough time to raise the audience to that level. Putting it at the end allows you to first build the spectators up to the right pitch of expectation. That's why you'll find many twines where the visual phase works well in the middle and many where it

works well at the end, but almost none where it works well at the beginning.

Another good example of a visual climax to a non-visual routine is Juan Tamariz's great version of *Oil and Water*. In the final phase, Juan simply spreads the cards face up between his hands, showing reds and blacks alternating. He squares the cards and instantly re-spreads to show the now separated colors. As stunning as this ending is, it would be nowhere near nowhere at strong performed either by itself or at the beginning of the routine. (There would also be a greater risk that the audience would penetrate the method.) The earlier phases of Juan's routine are non-visual. The cards are mixed race down and a fair amount of time elapses before they're revealed to have separated. But the impossible conditions under which they occur put the audience in the proper frame of mind to be blown away by the visual ending.

This means that, not only does the visual phase validate the non-visual phases, the reverse is also true. Through the use of strong conditions, the non-visual phases prepare the audience to believe that you really can do what you claim to be doing. They're then ready to accept at face value the stunning but bold visual finale. (See the visual climax of *Darwin's Ambitious Card* for another good example of this dynamic at work.)

Visual and non-visual phases can be creatively combined in many ways to make the whole routine greater than the sum of its parts. Just as a visual phase can work well at the end of a series of non-visual phases, a non-visual phase can sometimes perfectly climax a visual routine.

In *The New Back Off* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards** I print faces, one at time, on four double-backed cards. My greatest challenge in putting this routine together was how to end it. After three extremely visual phases, there didn't seem to be anything I could do to top what had come before. The perfect solution proved to be a completely *non-visual* climax. I place the fourth double-backer between a spectator's palms. The card acquires a face while in her hands. Thus, the last phase is completely non-visual. But, due to the stringent conditions (magic in the spectator's hands), it's also the most impossible phase. The deep mystery of this completely non-visual,

undercover phase was the only thing strong enough to top what was, until then, a highly visual routine.

In the next chapter we'll explore in detail how to combine methods in a multi-phase routine to create a cumulatively perfect method. For now, it's enough to note that using visual magic as a validating phase is a special application of this concept and one of the best exploitations of the power of visual magic.

As Part of a Visual/Covered Design

One thing that can be said for visual magic is that it certainly gets people's attention. It can, therefore, be a great technique for grabbing the audience in preparation for an effect's climax. A particularly potent approach is to use a visual grabber that leads into a non-visual, but deeply mysterious climax.

Many transposition effects lend themselves to this approach. A good example is Ed Marlo's *Copsil*. The performer places a silver coin into the spectator's hand, which she then closes. He now picks up a copper coin. Using a *Spellbound-type* change, he transforms it into the silver coin. The very visual nature of the change dazzles the audience and grabs their attention. While the change itself impresses the spectators, it also raises the question, "Where is the copper coin now?" This sets up the audience for the amazing climax in which the copper coin is found in the spectators closed hand. This final revelation is non-visual magic, but it constitutes the truly memorable impossibility for which the visual change was merely a prelude.

Using a visual transformation for the first half of a transposition, which then leads to revealing the more impossible half of the transposition, might be termed the *half visual formula*. One can apply it to almost any close-up prop. New York magician Benjamin Levy does a version of the *Bill Transposition* in which he places an American bill in a spectator's hand while he holds onto a bright red bill of foreign currency. The bill in his hand visually changes to the green American bill. The red bill is then found in the spectator's hand. Similarly, in a two-card transposition, you could place an ace in a spectator's hand and show a king on top of the deck. Perform a

color change to visually transform your king into the ace. The spectator now finds that she is holding the king.

In each of these cases, the visual transformation is impressive and surprising in itself. Yet, it also serves the more important function of creating anticipation for the *real impossibility*, the change in the spectator's hand. After all, you might be able to change a coin/bill/card in your hand by means of your dazzling sleight-of-hand skill. But changing an object while someone else is holding it is a *miracle*.

Nor is the half-visual formula limited to simple two-object transpositions. One of the reasons that *McDonald's Aces* is so powerful is that it incorporates this approach. The *vanishes* of the aces are fairly visual. The *appearance* of those aces under the spectator's hand is a profound mystery. Each time you vanish an ace in your hand, you baffle the audience by its disappearance. But you also build suspense for the eventual revelation of that ace under the spectator's hand. By themselves, the vanishes of the aces might be dismissed as clever sleight of hand. The arrival of those aces under the spectator's hand is completely non-visual magic, but it's also impossible.

Finally, be open to opportunities to apply the half-visual formula to non-transposition effects. Earlier, I described *The Last Laugh*. Two aces visibly vanish and are found in the middle of the deck trapping a named card. The visual vanish grabs their attention. But the non-visual production of the named card is what the audience remembers. This idea of using a *visual grabber* to build anticipation for a *deep-mystery payoff* is one of the best ways to exploit visual magic.

As Incidental Magic

In **Strong Magic** I coined the phrase *incidental magic* to refer to the little throwaway effects one sometimes performs in the course of a more substantial effect or between major effects. An example is Del Ray's *Vanishing Lighter*. If Del noticed someone about to light a cigarette during one of his performances, he would offer them his lighter. He would time it so that he got there just a little too late. At that point, he banged the lighter against the table and lifted his hand to show that it had vanished. Similarly,

in **The Books of Wonder**, Tommy Wonder describes an effect called *Fifty Percent Lighter*. The performer tries to light his cigarette, but his lighter won't work. After a couple of tries, he simply transforms the lighter into a box of matches and uses one to light his cigarette.

Judged purely as magic effects, both of these items are pretty lightweight. They have little going for them beyond their momentary visual impact. Both would fall flat if you took out a cigarette lighter solely to perform the effect. (As Tommy Wonder observes, “The effect is greatly heightened if you treat the whole episode as incidental.”) Both items are, however, highly visual, and that's all they need to fulfill their purpose as incidental magic.

I've suggested that pure visual magic tends to fall short of creating deep mystery. However, the purpose of incidental magic isn't to create a deep mystery. It's to create a certain atmosphere: an atmosphere in which anything seems possible. It also serves to convey a certain impression about the performer: the impression that he can call on unknown forces virtually without thinking about it. (As Tommy Wonder says of his effect, “This is exactly the sort of thing a true magician would do: Solve an annoying little problem by magic!”) Quick, purely visual effects are perfect for these purposes.

In the final analysis, incidental magic is only *incidental* to what you should be trying to accomplish as a magician, creating profound and lasting mystery. As I observed earlier, one thing that can be said for visual magic is that it certainly gets people's attention. The question is: Once you have their attention, what will you do with it?

Chapter Nine: Correlation: Making and Breaking Patterns

Conviction

In *Strong Magic* I extensively discussed what I believe to be the most important factor in creating memorable magic, what I termed conviction. By this I mean the spectator's belief that the initial condition really is what you claim it is. The concept of conviction is as central to this book as it was to that one. I don't want to repeat what I said there, so I'll just mention one central premise from that book. The stronger the spectator's conviction, the

stronger the magic effect will be. The more convinced they are that it's an apple, the more amazed they'll be when it changes to an orange. This is particularly relevant to the use of repetition in magic.

Suppose you're about to leave home and you realize that you don't have your keys. You remember that you left them upstairs on the bedroom dresser. But when you look, they're nowhere to be seen. You're positive that's where you left them, so you search again. There's no doubt about it; they're just not there. When you go downstairs again, you find the keys on the coffee table. You don't remember putting them there. In fact, you'd still swear you left them on the dresser. Yet there is no one else in the house who could have moved them.

Do you conclude that some violation of the laws of nature has occurred? Do you decide that, by some miracle, the keys were teleported from the dresser to the coffee table? Of course not. You think, "I could have sworn I left those keys upstairs. But, obviously, I was wrong." No matter how strong your initial belief that you left the keys in one place, finding them in a different place causes you to revise your belief. The fact of the keys being downstairs is, in itself, proof that your initial belief was wrong, and you accept that.

This simple commonsense attitude that we all adopt in daily life poses a major challenge if you want to perform effects with miracle impact. Revealing the final condition tends to cause the audience to question their prior beliefs about the initial condition. It means nothing that the audience believes the initial condition before the magic happens. Will they still believe it after the magic happens? Will the spectator still believe that you put a silver coin in her hand when she opens it later to find a copper coin?

We've all heard these discussions among magicians. A magician uses, for example, a visual retention pass to apparently place a coin in his hand. Invariably, another magician will ask, "Why don't you just put the coin in your hand the way you would in real life?" Answer: Because in real life the coin doesn't vanish. Therefore, in real life, you don't need to convince anyone of anything. If you're planning to end the effect by showing that the coin is still in your hand, any coin transfer will do. If, however, the coin is going to vanish, you need to be convincing.

What is going to happen later in the effect determines how much conviction I need to create earlier in the effect. Once, when performing *Triumph* using Daryl's cutting display, a magician asked me, "Do you really need that convincer? Is there any reason for the audience to doubt that you just shuffled face-up cards into facedown cards?" My answer was, "Well, *not yet*. But, in a few moments, when I spread the deck and the cards are all straightened out, there will be." The fact that the cards are no longer in a face-up/face down condition is, itself, reason to doubt that they ever were. Magicians are, in fact, often confronted by exactly this kind of commonsense reaction. One magician will complain to another, "I did *Daley's Last Trick* for her. Do you know what she said? 'You never put the black aces in my hand to begin with.' Can you believe that?" This is usually delivered in a way intended to elicit sympathy about how stupid laypeople are. Of course, since she was right, it would seem to indicate how *smart* laypeople are.

It's simple missing-keys logic. I thought I put the keys on the dresser. But, since they're not on the dresser, I must have been mistaken. I thought he shuffled the cards face up and face down. But, since they're all face down, I must have been mistaken. I thought he put the coin in his hand. But, since the coin isn't in his hand, I must have been mistaken. I thought he put the black aces in my hand. But since they're in his hand, I must have been mistaken.

This is the challenge of conviction in magic. By its very nature, *the effect itself challenges the audience's belief in the initial condition*. Yet, in order for the effect to register as magic, the spectators must cling to their original belief even in light of the subsequent evidence. They must be so convinced that you put a silver coin into their hand that even having it change to a copper coin doesn't shake that belief. They must remain convinced of the reality of the *initial condition* even after you reveal the *final condition*.

Repetition

Suppose that the day after your adventure with the missing keys, you make a point of leaving the keys on the dresser. A little later you pass the coffee table and notice the keys lying there. At this point you start to get spooked. You might decide to conduct a test-conditions experiment. You

check to make sure that there is no one else in the house. You put the keys on the dresser. Just before leaving the room, you glance back to make sure they're still there. You lock the door behind you. If those keys still materialize on the coffee table, you'll have to accept that unknown forces are at work. *Repetition produces conviction.*

That's why, when a spectator isn't quite convinced by an effect, he'll say, "Do that again." Many magicians think this is a compliment. In fact, it's an expression of skepticism. At the very least, the spectator is saying that he is reserving judgment until he sees it again. The audience instinctively believes that it would be much harder to repeatedly fool them with the same effect. Of course, they're right. That's why, if you can succeed in doing so, you can create a particularly strong magical experience.

Some magicians disparage repetition effects as being mere puzzles rather than magic. The empirical evidence, however, doesn't support that view. Rene Lavand's *I Can't Do it Any Slower* and *The Three Breadcrumbs* are among the most magical effects in the history of close-up. In the former, he repeats the same basic effect six times, in the latter case about twenty times. In fact, Juan Tamariz once pointed out to me that almost all the effects that we think of as classics involve repetition. This includes the Linking Rings, Cups and Balls, Cut and Restored Rope, and Ambitious Card.

Another criticism is that such effects lack surprise. It's true that they lack *narrative* surprise. The audience knows what is supposed to happen. However, all strong magic contains an element of surprise. The surprise is that the effect works. If the routine builds properly, the audience should be surprised each time that the effect continues to work despite the increasingly strict conditions. They know what is supposed to happen, but it's still surprising that it actually does.

Whether it's Lavand's six-phase Oil Water, or his twenty-plus-phase *Three Breadcrumbs*, or Daryl's *Ambitious Card* routine, also in the twenty-phase range, or Francis Carlyle's two-phase *Homing Card*, at the end of each, you're forced to conclude that the performer didn't just catch you off guard. He didn't get some really obvious swindle past you. He really can

do it. Any time, any place, under any conditions, he really can do it. The only possible explanation is magic.

Naturally, it requires skillful showmanship to perform such a multiphase effect and hold the audience from beginning to end. Here, however, I'm concerned only with making the magic as *amazing as* possible because I've already dealt with the challenge of making it *entertaining* in a previous book. I'm assuming that you already have a good command of showmanship skills. I will, however, touch on one concept from **Strong Magic** that is particularly relevant to multi-phase routines and that is the dramatic element of progression.

I've been speaking of doing the same thing again and again. Yet, an audience doesn't want to watch *exactly* the same thing again and again. The key point is the difference between the intellectual and the dramatic. In a well designed and well presented multi-phase effect the audience should feel that they're witnessing the same phenomenon repeatedly but under increasingly impossible conditions. Intellectually, it appears that you're demonstrating the same phenomenon again and again. Dramatically, it feels like you're making it harder each time.

When you understand this concept, you won't have to ask, "How many phases are enough?" The answer is: how many times (and ways) can you do it and still create the impression that each time is more impossible than the one before? It may be two times (as in Carlyle's *Homing Card*) or twenty times (as in Daryl's *Ambitious Card*). The answer to the one question is the answer to the other.

If you doubt, however, that repeating an effect can make it more amazing, just go back to our house-keys example. Under such circumstances, repetition is the only thing that would ever convince you that something inexplicable was going on. That is, of course, precisely what we want to convince our audiences of. In **The Magic Way**, Juan Tamariz outlines his eight-step formula for making a magic effect as strong as possible. The final step is: "Repeating the effect using different procedures." Tamariz goes on to say that, "Repeating effects this way increases their impact a thousand percent (or a 100,000%)."

Of course, not every effect needs repetition. It's particularly useful however, for brief effects, the kind of trick that's over almost before the spectator realizes its begun. This is precisely the type of trick that tends to leave people feeling, "I must have blinked at the wrong moment."

If you're unsure whether a particular effect would benefit from repetition, try to recall whether, when you perform it, spectators ever say, "Do

it again." If this happens with any frequency, perhaps you should consider doing it again.

Eliminating Pattern Clues

"In epidemiology, which relies heavily on observational studies..., cause and effect is established by observing the same thing in a wide variety of settings until all but the suspected cause can be ruled out."

Gerard E. Dallal, Ph.D,
The Little Handbook of Statistical Practice

I observed a moment ago that an audience instinctively realizes that it would be much harder to deceive them repeatedly with the same effect. This is partially because they feel that the next time they'll be ready for you. They won't be caught off guard. Even more importantly, however, they realize that repetition allows them to search for patterns.

In Chapter Three I observed: "Life has taught us that whenever an effect is present, the cause must be present also. If a doctor is called to an outbreak of stomach problems among the patrons of a restaurant, he will try to find out what they all ate in order to find the one item that was present in *every* case. This pattern will reveal the cause." This is what the audience will be looking for, the clue—mannerism, gesture, or procedure—that is present in every case. Any such element, they know instinctively, must have a causal connection to the seemingly miraculous effect.

Method vs. Technique

The repeat approach can be a powerful means of creating a magical experience *if you* succeed in deceiving the audience each time. But you'll only succeed if you can disguise any pattern clues that might lead to the correct solution. One approach that can work in many effects is to use the same *method* but change the *technique*. The basic secret that achieves the effect remains the same. The specific moves that exploit that secret change.

A couple of examples should clarify things. In *McDonald's Aces*, all three aces are vanished by means of the same method, double-faced cards. However, any good version of *McDonalds Aces* will use a different handling to make each ace vanish. This avoids the tip-offs that would result from using the same sequence of moves three times in a row.

This was one of the reasons I developed *Modern Jazz Aces (Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table)*, my re-routining of Peter Kane's *Jazz Aces*. The Kane effect used the same method for each ace transposition, the one-ahead principle. But it also used the same technique each time, the Elmsley count. I kept the method but varied the technique. One time I use the Elmsley count, another time the Olram subtlety, another time multiple lifts.

Mexican Poker from the same book also illustrates routining that uses the same method but varies the technique. Since *Mexican Poker* is a version of the Ten-Card Poker Deal, each of the five phases relies on the same method: forcing the Jonah card on the spectator. But I force the card in a different way each time. The result is that the spectator has freedom of choice at different points and in different ways in the different phases. The composite result is a feeling of total freedom and control on the spectator's part. (For yet another case study of this approach from the same book, see *Darwin's Wild Card*.)

Complete Time Displacement

In some multi-phase routines, all the work is done before the first phase begins. A good example would be Daryl's *Psychological Assembly*. One at a time, three aces vanish from their packets. They are then shown to have joined the fourth ace in the leader packet. The reality is that all the aces were switched out of the follower packets and into the leader packet before the first phase.

Such tricks are really mock multi-phase effects. You achieve all the magic at the outset but reveal it piecemeal to create the illusion of several different phases. Nonetheless, such effects can achieve some of the magical power of true multi-phase routines if there are sufficient convincers to disguise the truth.

Combining Different Methods

Now we come to the real powerhouse approach to multi-phase routines and the reason why repeat phases can be such a great tool for the magician who wants to create a true magical experience.

We magicians know that, for almost any effect in existence, magicians have devised a variety of ways of achieving it. Laypeople don't suspect this. If you perform an amazing effect, it's difficult for the audience to imagine even one way of doing it. They're hardly likely to think that there may be many ways.

The two previous approaches *disguise* the pattern of a consistent method. This approach *eliminates* any pattern by avoiding a consistent method. Different methods have different strengths and weaknesses. If you can accent the strength of each method and disguise the weakness, combining a variety of methods in a multi-phase routine can be one of the strongest design approaches in magic.

The Composite Perfect Method

Years ago a famous stage illusionist had a TV special. On it he performed a levitation unequaled before or since. The camera showed the floating woman from every possible angle. There could be no means of support. It was just magic.

Those with inside information knew that the magician had taped three different levitations using three different methods but all with the same woman. These were then edited together to combine the best features of each. Magicians, who tape these shows and study them with the dedication of a Talmudic scholar, noticed that the audience members in the first row

kept changing from shot to shot. Most other viewers never suspected that they were watching a composite. They just thought it was a miracle.

Before you start envying the advantages available to those TV magic guys, consider this. Suppose you decide that you want to put together an *Ambitious Card* routine. Would you like to be able to have a card freely selected and signed on the face? Would you like to really insert it in the middle, and let the audience see the face of the card as you push it in? Then, without any kind of manipulation, cleanly show that the signed card has arrived on top? It would be the perfect method, wouldn't it?

The good news is that you can achieve all those elements in your *Ambitious Card* routine. The bad news is that you can't achieve them all in the same phase. The really good news is that it doesn't matter. If you structure the effect properly, you can achieve the different conditions I described in different phases. And, if you present it properly, you won't need a TV editing booth. The spectators will edit the different phases together in their own minds.

This approach exploits the audience's tendency to seek *one* explanation for all demonstrations of the same phenomenon. As Tamariz writes in **The Magic Way**: “Remember that psychologically, we tend to think that, 'The same causes produce the same effects.'”

This is often referred to as the cancellation principle since cancels out the flaws of another method. Another way to look at it is that, you are creating a *composite* perfect method. It's not enough, however to combine different methods. You must *strive to combine different method that nullify each other's weaknesses*. Each method should offer a conditional element that the others lack.

This is why in Chapter Eight I suggested using visual magic as dating phase in a multi-phase routine. Visual magic allows you to establish conclusively that the magic happens during the critical interval. Having established that in one phase, you can use other phases to counteract the typical weaknesses of visual magic methods. For example, in an *Ambitious Card* routine, in one phase insert the card into the deck face up. Then use a

pass to make it visibly appear on top. The phases before and after can use more subtle methods.

The Ambitious Card is the *obvious* example for applying these concepts. Once you start thinking in these terms, however, you'll find other less obvious applications. When I put together my Cannibal Cards routine, I incorporated a strong sequence for vanishing the three selections from Mike Powers' *A Case of Indigestion*. The first vanish lets you show the face of the selected card as you insert it among the kings. After the vanish, it lets you conclusively show that you have only four cards left. You cannot, however, spread to show the faces of all four kings. The second vanish lets you do exactly that but leaves you holding more than four cards. The last vanish ends completely clean with only the four kings in your hand. It does not, however, allow you to show the face of the selected card when you first insert it among the kings.

If you stress the strong point of each phase, however, the audience will feel that you showed the faces of the selections as you inserted them into the king packet at the start of each vanish and conclusively showed that you had only four cards, each of them a king, at the end of each vanish. In other words, you'll have the perfect Cannibal Cards vanish.

Suppose you're going to do a prediction effect in which you predict more than one event. Consider using a different method for each predicted item. Perhaps a nail writer combined with a force combined with a multiple out? (Barrie Richardson's *Wigging The Baldpate* from **Theater of the Mind** is an excellent example of this approach.)

At one time book tests usually involved one book. The mentalist might give the spectator a choice of several volumes, but only one was used for the test. Today many mentalists start a book test by handing out several books

to various spectators. Each is gaffed in a different way and works on a different principle. Therefore, each has a different limitation and a different strength. In one case, the performer handles the book. In another case he doesn't. In one case, he asks the page number. In another case he doesn't. In one case, he tells the spectator the first word on the page. In another case,

he tells them any word they choose. In yet another case, he describes the contents of the whole page.

By jumping from book to book, the mentalist blurs the details and creates a cumulative impression. The audience thinks, reasonably enough, that what he does with any one book he could do with any other. The overall effect is that he can tell anyone anything they read in any book.

Case Study: Carlyle's Homing Card

Some years ago I decided to start using the Carlyle trick in my walk-around performances. I quickly sensed that the two-phase structure left people with a feeling of incompleteness. It's just another example of the "rule of three." Doing something three times gives the audience a sense of closure. Doing it twice doesn't. I solved this problem in the obvious way. I added one phase.

Since I felt that Carlyle's original ending was as strong a card-to-pocket phase as anyone could ever produce, I felt that it should remain the closing phase. I decided, therefore, to insert this new phase between the two phases of the Carlyle original. What I arrived at is no great act of creativity. It does, however, beautifully illustrate how multi-phase construction can produce an ironclad mystery by mixing methods.

I'll explain the handling briefly. (If you're not already familiar with the Carlyle original, I suggest you study it in **The Stars of Magic** or **The Magic of Francis Carlyle** first to make it easier for you to grasp what follows.) As you read this, keep in mind that it's a repeat card-to-pocket effect. That means that the critical interval starts when the card goes into the deck and ends when it comes out of the pocket. Note how each phases method relates to this critical interval.

The first phase is identical to the Carlyle original. I start by forcing the seven of clubs on a spectator. While my back is turned she initials the face of the card. During that time I casually palm the *eight* of clubs and slip it into my right pants pocket. The spectator then returns the initialed seven of clubs to the deck and I control it to the top.

I explain that, when I riffle the deck, the card will travel invisibly to my right pants pocket. I riffle the cards dramatically. With an obviously empty hand I reach into my pocket and partially pull out the eight of clubs. Covering the index with my thumb, I bend the card outward so the audience can see the face as I look at the card. I then push the card back into the pocket as I say, "Did you select the seven of clubs?" The audience never sees a seven pip but assumes that I must have. Otherwise, how would I know what the selected card was?

As they react to the miracle, I palm the top card. "But does it have your initials on it?" I say as I produce the palmed card from my pocket (using Norman Houghton's pocket load). "Yes, it does," I say as I hand the card to a spectator. Thanks to Carlyle's genius, the method (palming) has happened *after* the critical interval.

Now comes the new second phase. I have the spectator return the card to the deck and I apparently leave it jutting out of the center. In fact, I perform a variant of the convincing control in which I bottom palm the selection in my left hand while appearing to leave it outjogged.

I explain that I will again make the card travel to my pocket. As I say this, I gesture to my right pocket with my empty right hand. My right hand squares the outjogged card and riffles the deck. Immediately my *left* hand travels to my left pants pocket and produces the selection by means of the Houghton pocket load. This time, the method (palming) has happened *during* the critical interval but is covered by the surprise of going to a different pocket with a different hand.

"That wasn't fair," I say, "Because you were expecting it to travel to this pocket, weren't you?" As I say this, I transfer the deck to my left hand and the selection to my right hand. In illustrating my comment I slip the selection into my right pocket for an instant and pull it out. In fact, I perform the pocket switch that is the key to the last phase of the Carlyle effect.

I insert the "selection" into the deck, leaving it outjogged as I explain that I'll do it one last time, this time once again to the *right* pocket. I casually flash the face of the "selection," covering the pip, as I comment that the

card is clearly buried at least halfway down in the deck. The eight is, of course, taken for the seven of clubs. (The audience assumes that the initials must be on the portion of the card hidden by the deck.)

All that remains is to square the card, riffle the deck, and produce the selection from my pocket with an obviously empty hand. This time, again thanks to Carlyle's brilliance, the method (a switch) has happened *before* the critical interval.

One phase happens before, one during, one after the critical interval. In the first phase, the method happens after they expect it. In the third phase, the method happens before they expect it. In between there is a phase in which the method happens when they expect but not in the manner they expect.

The Rule of Three

“If you do something once, people will call it an accident. If you do it twice, they call it a coincidence. But do it a third time and you've just proven a natural law.”

Grace Murray Hopper,
mathematician and
computer science pioneer

This is a good time to discuss the so-called “rule of three.” Magicians often cite it. But understanding it is another matter. As always in magic (and just about anything else) understanding is better than mindless parroting. So it's worth exploring why and how the rule of three works.

You'll recall from high school geometry that it takes two points to define a line. Similarly, it takes two instances to establish a trend. In a narrative, the first two instances create the expectation. The third instance works by either confirming or subverting that expectation.

Consider fairy tales. In *The Three Little Pigs*, two houses are enough to establish the pattern: the wolf blows down pig houses. The third house provides the payoff. That's why *The Boy Who Cried Wolf* only gets to do so

three times. Also, the genie grants you exactly three wishes. When you squander the first two, the audience detects the pattern and waits to see if you learn from experience or fritter away the third one also.

Jokes provide another example. Spend some time watching Comedy Central, keeping the rule of three in mind, and you'll be struck by how many jokes consist of the comic offering a list of items, the last of which doesn't fit (at least in the expected way). Almost always, the list consists of *three* items. The first two establish the pattern. The third breaks it. In sitcoms, often one character will make a comment. A second character will offer a suitable follow-up. Then a third character will add a wildly inappropriate comment. This comedy formula is sometimes known as setup, setup, payoff. As Jon Vorhaus observes in **The Comic Toolbox**, "If you have three setups, it's just redundant."

Jokes rely heavily on surprise for their impact. So you can expect the third instance will always subvert the expectation created by the first two. Magic is not about surprise, but about impossibility. Indeed, the impossibility provides built-in surprise. The surprise is that the trick worked despite the fact that it's impossible.

That's why. in a three-phase effect, the third phase can succeed by either subverting or *confirming* the pattern established by the first two. Two of my favorite ace assemblies, both from **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table** illustrate these alternative approaches. *The Hitchcock Aces* is so strong because the third phase *subverts* the expectation created by the first two. *Modern Jazz Aces* is so strong because the third phase *confirms* the expectation created by the first two.

The quote above from Grace Murray Hopper perfectly sums up the dynamic of this latter type of effect. With the third phase, the audience can no longer dismiss what they've seen as luck, coincidence, or inattentiveness on their part. You've proven a law of nature. More precisely, you've proven your power to violate a law of nature. Fewer than three repetitions feels inconclusive. More than three feels redundant.

It's important to appreciate that the rule of three doesn't mean that four-phase routines can't be effective. It does mean that, if you do the *exact same*

thing four times in a row, the fourth phase will almost always bore the audience. There are some fast-paced routines where each phase is so short that you can get away with four identical repetitions. But in most cases, the audience will feel that the fourth phase is pointless. No matter how impossible what you're doing is, by the third time you've done it, they're convinced that you can do it. They've surrendered. Doing it a fourth time will start to bore them.

An example of an effect that suffers from this flaw is *The Stanley Collins Aces*. The trick always starts to drag at the fourth ace vanish. Yet, some effects by their nature require four iterations. This is particularly true in card magic where, as in the Collins example, the structure is dictated by the fact that you're working with four of a kind. One solution is to double up on one phase. For example, in Conradi's version of the Stanley Collins effect from **Classic Secrets of Magic**, the last two aces are vanished in tandem, one by the performer and one by a spectator. Similarly, in Paul Harris' *Reset*, you change the last two aces into kings at the same time. In both cases, *four* transformations occur in *three* phases.

Alternatively, a particularly effective approach is to find a way to make the fourth phase significantly different from, and stronger than, the previous three. When I revamped one of my earliest creations, *Back Off* into *The New Back Off*, one of the things that made the new version so much stronger was this realization. In the original version I did essentially the same thing four times. I eventually recognized that I had to make the last phase stand out from the others. I did this by making the last transformation happen in the spectator's hand.

Similarly, my *Twisting the Case* idea, described earlier, gives Vernon's *Twitting the Aces* the same three-plus-one structure. The fourth reversal happens under more stringent conditions. Three identical repetitions followed by a final phase that ups the ante is a winning formula. Four identical repetitions is not.

Keep in mind that these comments refer to effects in which you apparently do exactly the same thing under exactly the same conditions each time. A multi-phase routine in which each phase seems more impossible than the last because it occurs under more stringent conditions is

a different matter. In such effects, there is no theoretical limit. There is only the practical limit that eventually you won't be able to make it any more impossible. A good example of this type of effect is René Lavand's *I Can't do it Any Slower*. It contains six phases. Yet no one who has seen him do it would say that it drags.

The rule of three relates more to dramatic issues than issues of designing for maximum impossibility. But as long as we're discussing using multiple phases, I thought it worth clarifying that I'm not recommending an endless string of seemingly identical phases.

Thematic Misdirection

Since the different methods in a multi-phase effect have different strengths, they must also have different weaknesses. You want the audience to note the strengths and miss the weaknesses. If you leave the matter to chance, however, they might note the weaknesses and miss the strengths.

The solution is to apply Ascanio's concept of *thematic misdirection*. It works very much like physical misdirection. Both physical and thematic misdirection are based on the fact that you can't pay attention to two things at the same time. For example, a person can't look at two things at the same time. Yet, it's impossible to make someone look *away* from something. We can only make him look *at* something. In physical misdirection, we give the audience something to look at so they can't look at what we don't want them to see.

Similarly, a person can't think about two things at the same time it's impossible to make someone *not* think about something. We can only make him think about something. In thematic misdirection, we give the audience something to think about so that they can't think about what we don't want them to notice. Just as, in physical misdirection, you direct the audience's eyes away from one thing by directing them *toward* something else, in thematic misdirection you direct the audience's minds away from one idea by directing them *toward* another idea.

In this case, we want to sell the strength of each phase and gloss over the weakness. There's nothing difficult about it. In each phase, talk about the

unique, stringent condition that particular method allows. Keep the spectators mind focused on that and he'll have no chance to think about its weakness. Thus, as you move from phase to phase, you go from strength to strength. Afterward, the audience will assume that the strength of each phase was present in all the phases—which means there are no weaknesses to provide a clue to any possible method.

Creating False Correlations

I've repeatedly spoken of removing any possible cause in an effect to achieve the illusion of impossibility. Keep in mind, however, that we are not truly trying to eliminate all possible causes. We're only trying to eliminate all possible causes within the laws of nature. Our ultimate goal is to compel the conclusion that the cause of the effect is *magic*.

Although the audience is never going to believe that's the case, we want them to feel that it is. In a multi-phase routine, this means encouraging the audience to feel that each phase is achieved by the *same* method and that this method lies outside the laws of nature. We can psychologically reinforce this causal theory by providing a false correlation.

In a multi-phase effect, the broad effect should remain the same in each phase. There is no reason, however, that procedures must remain the same. Indeed, since we're trying to make the conditions more stringent each time, it's natural that the procedures will vary from phase to phase. There is, however, one element that should not vary: the supernatural cause. And the outward manifestation of that supernatural cause is the magic gesture.

I've talked earlier of the value of the magic gesture. The concept gains particular power in multi-phase effects. If you incorporate a consistent magic gesture into every phase, you turn to your advantage the spectator's

belief that the cause must be present every time that the effect is. The magic gesture becomes the only lifeline that he can grasp. It's the one element that fits his preconceived notions of correlation. Consequently, it psychologically reinforces the one causal theory that you're selling: It's done by magic.

Chapter Ten: Manipulating Memory

“Memory can change the shape of a room; it can change the color of a car. And memories can be distorted. They're just an interpretation, not a record of events.”

Leonard Shelby in **Memento**

“The true art of memory is the art of attention.”

Samuel Johnson

When I was in law school I made extra money by working as an instructor in Harry Lorayne's Memory School. One entire lesson was devoted to dealing with the problem of absentmindedness. The great insight I gained from teaching that particular class was that a memory system is virtually useless in fighting absentmindedness (as Harry's own legendary absentmindedness illustrates). The reason is that absentmindedness is not about memory. It's about attention.

As you're jotting down some notes, the phone rings. You put down the pen to answer it. At that moment, you're not thinking about the pen; you're thinking about the phone. Putting down the pen is simply an automatic, unconscious action that is an incidental step in performing the action your mind really focused on: answering the telephone.

After you get off the phone, you think, “Where did I put that pen?” After wracking your brain for a while you may wonder. “Why can't I remember where I put the pen?” The answer is that memory is about retrieving information that you mentally filed away. If you never filed it away, you'll never be able to retrieve it. If you weren't paying attention to what you were doing when you put down the pen, the information was never encoded in your memory banks. A mental search will turn up nothing. This is exactly the phenomenon we're going to try to create *in the spectator's mind*.

This leads us to an important concept, that of *psychological invisibility*. Sleight-of-hand technique can make something literally invisible. If you execute the Scarne card fold well, the eye cannot see you do it. Physical

misdirection can make something literally Invisible. If they're looking at point A, they won't see what you do at point B. Psychological invisibility is another matter. It refers to *anything that the eye sees but the mind does not register*. This is our goal, to keep certain actions from going into the spectator's long-term memory banks.

People tend to remember what they consider important and forget what they consider unimportant. This leads us to a major goal of effect design: *make the important elements seem unimportant and the unimportant elements seem important*. The unimportant is forgettable and hence immediately forgotten. It is, in effect, edited out.

People unconsciously classify actions as important or unimportant based, not on the action itself, but rather on what they perceive to be the *motivation* behind that action. If they perceive the motivation to be unimportant, they will classify the action as unimportant. If they perceive the motivation to be irrelevant to the matter at hand, they will consider the action irrelevant. That's why an important key to manipulating memory is the use of false motivations.

The Fallacy of Deep Motivation

“All forms of misinterpretation must occur before the spectators notice anything odd and begin to wonder about it. Once curiosity is aroused, it is hard to satisfy—even when the explanation is genuine.”

Henning Nelms,
Magic and Showmanship

Magicians often complain that some action in an effect is not “logical.” When magicians say that an action is not logical, they usually mean that it's not *motivated*. Believing that motivation has to be logical is what leads to the fallacy of deep motivation. In fact, a motivation can be highly illogical yet completely effective. This is because the roots of effective motivation are not *logical* but *psychological*.

While every action in an effect should be properly motivated, in most cases that motivation doesn't have to run *deep*. That is to say, the motivation

needn't be capable of withstanding twenty minutes of rigorous analysis. If the audience feels impelled to analyze why you did something, you've already lost the battle. The purpose of motivating an action is precisely to *keep the audience from analyzing it*.

Many film critics have pointed out that the plots of Alfred Hitchcock's movies don't make much sense when you analyze them. The flaws are precisely in the area of motivation. "Why did the protagonist do this? Why didn't he just do that instead? It would have been more logical." But, even Hitchcock's severest critics admit that these questions never occur to you *while* you're watching the movie. Carried along by the story, you accept everything as logical at the time. The Master of Suspense understood that, if your goal is entertainment, a character's motivation doesn't have to make sense. It just has to *seem* to make sense.

Like Hitchcock's audiences, your audience wants to know what's going to happen next. They'll accept anything plausible that moves the effect forward. In fact, magicians have it easier than Hitchcock did. Film critics and serious film buffs will watch a movie repeatedly and ruminate over it. As a result, they may find logical flaws to pick apart. The spectator only gets to see the trick once. And, having just witnessed a miracle, he will be thinking along completely different lines. He will be asking himself "*How?*" not "*Why?*". If the motivations for your actions made sense to him at the time, he won't question them in retrospect.

Even magicians, when watching an effect, will accept illogical but plausible motivations at face value. It's only when they're learning an effect that, plagued by insecurity, they'll think, "Gee, this isn't logical, if you think about it."

Of course, there is nothing wrong with making an action completely logical as long as it doesn't involve labored explanations, additional handling, or anything else that slows down the pace of the effect. It's important, however, to understand the real purpose of motivating critical actions. Your goal is not to make the action logically unassailable, but to make *a psychologically invisible*.

To achieve this, your actions don't require *deep* motivation. They just require *obvious* motivation. Your actions need to make sense in *a self-evident way at the moment you perform them*. This will guarantee that the spectators will have no reason to analyze the big picture. Your motivations don't have to be able to withstand your audience's critical faculties. They have to avoid awakening those critical faculties.

A simple example should clarify this distinction between obvious motivation and deep motivation. In my version of the Travelers plot (called, coincidentally, *Hitchcock Travelers*), I take out a pen to have a spectator sign the four aces. When she finishes, I place the pen in my pocket. I then have four cards selected and lost in the deck. At that point I take out the pen and place it across the tabled aces as a paperweight. This action has a secret purpose. In removing the pen I load a palmed ace into my pocket. I need to go to my pocket to load the ace, and removing the pen provides the motivation.

It could be argued that it doesn't make sense to put the pen away if I'm going to need it later. Since I must have performed this effect many times,

I must know that I'll need the pen again. All of this is true and none of it matters. When I put the pen away, the action makes sense since the spectator is finished with it. The audience understands why I do it and forgets the action almost instantly. When I later take the pen out, the action makes sense since I need it to pin down the aces. The audience understands why I do it and forgets the action almost instantly.

The time delay between putting the pen away and taking it out again prevents the audience from putting the pieces together and noticing the illogicality. If I were to put the pen away only to take it out again ten seconds later that would indeed look odd. It would be easy for people to see the big picture. That's the key. In order for an audience to analyze your motivations deeply, they would have to step back and contemplate the big picture. They're not going to do that. If they're inclined to do any contemplating after the effect, the question they'll contemplate is, "How on earth did those aces get out from under that pen and into his pockets?" Even if, after the fact, they did try to look at the big picture, they wouldn't

remember your incidental actions with the pen because, at the time that you did them, they were *psychologically invisible*.

Mistakenly thinking that every little action requires deep motivation tends to produce labored procedures, long-winded presentations, endless patter rationales, and a generally bloated effect. Keep the motivations simple and obvious and you'll keep the methodology below the spectator's radar.

Finally, keep in mind that these comments relate specifically to effect design. There are many other issues of motivation that relate to presentation. In particular, your actions must make sense in terms of a presentation's dramatic premise. I discussed these sorts of things in **Strong Magic**. My comments here relate to what we're discussing here, how motivation can help make an action psychologically invisible.

Telegraphing Motivation

“A motivation must be made clear before you perform the action which it explains... when the explanation is offered beforehand, no one is sufficiently interested to examine it closely.”

Henning Nelms,
Magic and Showmanship

“Anticipated action is viewed with less suspicion.”

John Carney, **Cameycopia**

In magic, the most suspicious reason for doing something *is no reason at all*. If the audience doesn't detect a reason for an action they'll search for an ulterior motive. This search brings with it the two things we're most crying to avoid: attention and suspicion.

Whenever possible, the motivation for an action should be apparent to the audience at the time of the action. Ideally, it should be apparent a moment *before* the action. Thus, the audience is psychologically prepared to dismiss the action even before you've performed it.

An audience dismisses an action at the moment that they understand the reason for it, not a second before. If the motivation for the action becomes apparent a moment after you've performed it, they may well dismiss the action a moment after you've performed it. By that point, however, they've already taken note of that action. It's gone into their memory bank. Our ideal goal is for them *not* to take note of the action at all. Having the audience notice an action and then dismiss it is good. Having them *not* notice the action because they dismissed it even as you were starting to do it is better.

Suppose you have to go to your pocket to ditch a palmed object. You may motivate this action by openly *placing* something in your pocket or openly *removing* something from your pocket. From the standpoint of Psychological invisibility, going to your pocket to put something away is better than going to your pocket to take something out. When you put something in your pocket, the motivation is apparent before your hand has even reached the pocket. When you take something out, the motivation only becomes apparent as your hand emerges with the object.

When the only practical option for covering a trip to the pocket is removing an object, it's a good idea to telegraph the action in advance. You might, for example, say, "We're going to need a pen for this." When, a moment later you go to your pocket, the audience understands, even before your hand reaches it, that you're going to take out a pen. Thus, their understanding of the motivation for the action *precedes* the action itself.

Let's take a concrete example of telegraphing motivation. In *The Quick and the Dead* from **Scams Fantasies with Cards** I use the old idea of loading a palmed card into my pants pocket under cover of pushing in the lining of the pocket. At the beginning of the effect I remove whatever I have in the pocket and pull out the lining to show it empty. I leave the lining hanging out as I continue the effect. My jacket covers the reversed pocket, so the audience forgets the condition of the pocket and so, apparently, do I.

Later (after I've palmed a card) I pull back my jacket, glance down, and notice that the pocket is still inside out. The audience, of course, notices the same thing at the same moment. Even as my hand swings down to push the lining back in, the audience has already registered that I'm simply going to

do what I forgot to do before. Even before I finish the action, I turn my attention to the assisting spectator and start to give him instructions. Even before I finish the action, the audience turns *their* attention to what I'm saying to the spectator. Neither my audience nor I have time to dwell on unimportant matters. (What I instruct the spectator to do is to shuffle the deck. I make this seem important. In fact, it's unimportant since the selected card is no longer in the deck. It's in my pocket, placed there by an important action made to seem unimportant.)

Ruses

When it comes to false motivations, a valuable concept is that of the *ruse*. In **Magic by Misdirection**, Dariel Fitzkee defines a ruse as, “a plausible, but untrue, reason, or action conveying a reason, for concealing the true purpose for doing something.” In other words, the audience sees what you do. They're only misled as to *why* you do it. This leads them to misconstrue the importance of the action. We'll now analyze three of the most valuable categories of ruses: the *incidental*, the *accidental*, and the *extraneous*.

Incidental Actions

“Actions that appear necessary but unimportant are only half-noticed and soon forgotten. Actions that are unnecessary arouse suspicion.”

Al Baker, **Pet Secrets**

Perhaps the epitome of actions that appear necessary but unimportant are what Ascanio termed *in-transit actions*. Suppose that, during a performance, I'm holding a deck of cards in my right hand and transfer it to my left hand. If you were to ask the audience what I had just done, everyone would say that I had shifted the deck from one hand to the other. Suppose again that I'm holding a deck of cards in my right hand. This time, however, I search my right ear with my right hand. In order to do so, I first transfer the deck to my left hand. If you were to ask the audience what I

had just done, everyone would say that I scratched my ear. No one would mention the deck of cards. Transferring the deck from one hand to the other became *psychologically invisible*.

The reason is simple. *People interpret actions in terms of their end goal* They don't bother to note—let alone remember—each trivial step on the way to that goal. The *in-transit action* is the incidental act that has to be gotten out of the way in order to perform the target act. In our example, shifting the deck to the other hand is just something I have to do in order to scratch my ear.

Think back to my initial example of the lost pen. You put down the pen to answer the phone. Later you can't remember where you put it. This is an everyday occurrence that has happened to all of us. The reason we don't remember where we put the pen is that putting down the pen was an *in-transit action* performed solely to achieve the target act of picking up the phone. Even when *you're* the one performing the actions, in-transit actions tend to be forgotten. (More precisely, they tend not to be noticed in the first place.) What works on you will work on your audience.

An in-transit action achieves both of Al Baker's goals. First, it provides motivation. It makes it clear that the action is a *necessary* step in order to achieve the end goal. Second, it minimizes the action's significance. It makes clear that the end goal is the important thing. What happens in-transit to that goal is *unimportant*. The spotlight is on the target act. The in-transit action happens in its shadow.

Here is a three-step formula for applying the in-transit action concept to make key elements of the method psychologically invisible. First, identify an element that is important to the method but unimportant to the effect. Second, find an action that is important to the effect (or can be made to seem so) but unimportant to the method. Third, find a way to perform the first action in transit to the second action.

Admittedly, this may sound a little vague when stated in general terms. A couple of examples should help. In *The New Hitchcock Aces (Cardshark)*, at one point I have three aces in my right hand. The deck is in my left hand and the fourth ace is face down on the table. I have to place the three aces on the deck in order to switch them. To do so unmotivated would ignore Al Baker's warning that, "Actions that are unnecessary arouse suspicion."

Instead I use the three aces to flip the tabled ace face up. (This is a logical action in the context of the effect). However, when I flip the ace over, it falls too far to the left, so I slide it back to its original position. In order to do so, I have to first free my right hand. I do that by placing the three aces

on top of the deck. Thus, an action that is important in the inner reality of the method (placing the aces on the deck) becomes unimportant in the outer reality of the effect because it's just an action performed in-transit to the target action of repositioning the tabled ace.

A similar situation arises in *The Color Of Money* (**Scams Fantasies with Cards**), my version of the Follow the Leader plot. Early in the trick the red packet and the black packet must be brought in contact to effect a transfer of cards. Since contiguity is one of the great clues to method, I wanted to make this momentary contact psychologically invisible. Here is how I did it.

I use two casino chips, one red and one black, to mark the positions of the two packets. The black packet is in my left hand. The red packet is on the table to my left. My right hand removes the two chips from my pocket. I drop the black one on the table to my right. While looking at the audience, I start to table the red chip to my left. At the last moment, I look down and notice that the red packet is in the way. Therefore, my left hand turns palm down and picks up the red packet under the cards it already holds. My right hand then drops the red chip where the packet was. The two packets in my hand are then placed in their proper positions, the secret transfer having been accomplished.

This sequence deceives because I'm not concerned with the cards. I'm concerned with the chip. I want to place it in the correct position. Picking up the packet and putting it down again are incidental actions needed to make room for the chip. Thus, bringing the packets together (which is important to the method) becomes unimportant to the effect while properly positioning the chip (which is unimportant to the method) is made to seem important to the effect. A moment later, the audience will no more remember the packets touching than they would remember my transferring the deck from one hand to the other to scratch my ear.

Finally, here is an example that also illustrates another issue I've already raised. At the end of *Museum Piece* (**Cardshark**), I clean up by switching the packet I've been using for a group of cards on top of the deck. I use Mario's visual retention switch. This involves dipping the packet against the deck with the left thumb, then tossing it on the table. As the name indicates, the move is visually very illusive. To be *psychologically* illusive, however, you need to first motivate placing the packet on the deck and then motivate tossing it on the table.

Here is how I do it. My left hand holds the deck and my right hand holds the packet. I want to pick up the card box to put the deck away. So I clip the packet under my left thumb to free my other hand to pick up the box. Once I've picked up the box, however, I have to drop the packet to the table so that I can slip the deck into the box. (In that action, I execute the switch.) Both clipping the packet under my left thumb and dropping it on the table happen in-transit to the end goal of putting the deck in the box. The packet switch thereby fools the mind as well as the eye.

My reason for bringing up this last example is that the motivation makes no sense if you analyze it. Why not just drop the packet from my right hand to the table in the first place? This logical hole becomes apparent the moment you start to analyze the big picture. This fact, however, simply *doesn't matter*. No spectator is ever going to engage in such an analysis. The psychological persuasiveness of each motivation *at the moment that it happens* forestalls any further thought.

Accidental Actions

One of the problems we magicians must contend with is that people are always looking for ulterior motives in everything we say or do. (To make matters worse, they're usually right. Almost everything we say or do in a performance *does* have an ulterior motive.) Accidental actions are, however, exempt from this suspicion because they are, after all, *accidental*. People, therefore, take them at face value.

To illustrate how effectively “mistakes” can motivate necessary actions, I'll provide a few examples from my own repertoire. I know that these examples work because I've used them countless times.

In *The Hitchcock Travelers (Scams Fantasies)*, I use a beautiful ploy of Ed Marlo's to produce the last ace. The effect of the Travelers plot is that four signed aces travel to four different pockets. In my version, two of the aces are loaded into the *same* pocket. But, thanks to Marlo, they are still produced from different pockets.

I pull the first ace out of my inner left jacket pocket (which also contains a second ace). I now remove an ace from my left pants pocket. Next I remove an ace from my right pants pocket. I then reach into my inner left jacket pocket (the same one that the first ace came out of). My face registers mild annoyance as I realize that I've gone to the wrong pocket. I finish by removing the last ace from my inner *right* jacket pocket. In fact, by means of a beautifully choreographed sequence of Marlo's, I've secretly transferred the Last ace from one pocket to another. But, as good as the handling is, it deceives only because the audience is convinced that reaching into the wrong pocket was an honest mistake.

I'd be willing to bet that no layperson describing this effect to a friend would ever mention that I briefly reached into my inner *left* jacket pocket before removing the last ace from my inner *right* jacket pocket. That's the real test. When people recount a magic effect, they mention the relevant details and leave out the irrelevant ones. A passing mistake falls in the latter category. That's why using a mistake as a motivation can advance our goal of making the important seem unimportant.

In *Maximum Risk* from **Scams Fantasies**, after the spectator has peeked at a card, I deal the deck into two piles. In order for the trick to work, however, the selection must first be repositioned. I must transfer a certain number of cards from the top of the deck to the bottom. Yet, any suggestion that I'm *attempting* to reposition the selection would spoil the effect. Cutting or shuffling, no matter how artfully done, would fail because they are so obviously *deliberate* actions. Alternatively, using a pass would require executing the move at the worst possible time.

The solution I settled on was to accomplish the displacement under cover of a mistake. I start to deal the cards into two piles. Suddenly I realize that I forgot to take out the money for the wager I had earlier offered to make. I casually drop the deck on the dealt cards and place it aside as I take out my

wallet. After the money is on the table, I pick up the deck and start dealing again. My “realization” is timed to occur right after I've dealt the number of cards that I need to displace. Dropping the deck on these cards accomplishes my goal.

From the audience's viewpoint, forgetting to take out the money wasn't part of the trick. *If it's not part of the trick, it can't be part of the method.* Everything about how I handle this says, “That part didn't count. Now we're starting for real.” The false start simply isn't worth remembering. It *won't* be remembered when the spectators later search for a solution to the mystery.

It is best, however, to use mistakes as motivations sparingly. First, if you use this type of ruse too often it can become obvious. Second, you can come across as the kind of performer who makes a lot of mistakes. This may not be desirable unless it ties in with the persona you're trying to project. (Juan Tamariz makes frequent potent use of “mistakes” precisely because of the image he is promoting.)

Used strategically, however, the “mistake” is an extraordinarily effective technique for making actions psychologically invisible. People judge actions by their intentions. By definition, a mistake is unintentional. That makes it unimportant and guarantees that it will be *unremembered*.

Extraneous Actions

The reason audiences dismiss accidents from consideration is that they're unplanned. Since you must have planned how you would make the trick work, anything that's unplanned can't be related to how the trick works. If, however, the audience can be made to believe that an action, although planned, has nothing to do with the effect, they won't factor it in when trying to determine how the effect happened.

The prime example of such apparently extraneous actions in magic is the humorous gag. Any action associated with a gag is taken at face value because your motivation is so obvious: to get a laugh. There is no need for the audience to search any further for motivation. Additionally, getting a laugh has nothing to do with achieving the effect. Therefore, when the audience thinks back on the effect, the gag won't be part of the picture.

A while back I published an effect called *The Big Bounce* using the bounce/no bounce balls. At one point I make a hundred-dollar wager on the outcome. Under cover of the bill, I perform the necessary switch of balls. I'm left, however, with a finger-palmed ball under the bill that I need to ditch. To do so, I start to place the hundred-dollar bill back in my pocket as I say, "Maybe you'd rather just play for fun." As soon as my fingertips enter the pocket, I allow the finger-palmed ball to roll into the pocket. I immediately appear to register the spectator's disappointment and toss the bill on the table as I say, "I didn't think so." It's a mild enough joke but it gets a smile from the audience. Since the act of going to the pocket was just part of a joke, the audience forgets it a moment after I did it.

The best example I've ever encountered of going to the pocket under cover of a gag is a brilliant bit from Jim Pace's *Miser's Dream* routine. As he produces coin after coin, at one point he looks at one and says, "This one's a Krugerrand. I think I'll keep that one." He then pockets the coin and goes on with the routine. What no one suspects is that, when he goes to his pocket, he comes out with another load of coins palmed. No suspicion attaches to his putting his hand in his pocket because it's just a joke. No one gives it another thought.

Since people tend to relax their attention when they laugh, gags provide a double-barreled cover. They provide motivation for the necessary action and they provide intensity misdirection in the form of the laugh.

Gags can not only solve small problems, but also motivate major handling elements. One of the most challenging plots in card magic is to place a card face down on the table, have a spectator name any card, and then show that the tabled card is the one they named. The big problem is the need to look through the deck after the spectator names a card in order to locate it. How do you keep the audience from realizing *why* you're searching through the deck? Larry Jennings has a version in **The Cardwright** called *First Impressions*. In it, he does the searching under cover of a genuinely funny gag. No one ever suspects his real reason for looking through the cards because his apparent reason is so obvious, to get a laugh.

Roy Walton's *Smiling Mule* makes brilliant use of a gag to lead the audience to ignore the very handling that produces the magical result. I know from performing my own version. *The Last Laugh* from **Scams Fantasies**, that when people later describe the effect to others, they don't even bother to mention the gag. For another example, go back to Chapter Four and check the subchapter on *The Time Displacement Device*. There you'll find a description of a pseudo-estimation effect that uses a simple gag to psychologically erase the key move in the effect.

Finally, notice that each of these gags is amusing, but none is fall-out-of-your-chair hilarious. Ideally, we don't want the gag to be so funny as to be memorable. We're aiming for the opposite, something funny enough to be motivated, unfunny enough to be quickly forgotten.

Altering the Final Picture

At the climax of an effect, there is a moment when the audiences grasp of the details of that climax is still fluid. The impression has not yet gelled. This can offer the performer a brief window of opportunity to mold the final impression to make it still stronger. This is possible because, at the climax of any really amazing effect, the spectators tend to turn inward to absorb it. (Often they also literally turn to each other, looking in each other's faces to see if the other person is affected the same way.) After a moment, they will again turn outward toward the performer. In the interval, you may be able to subtly improve the effect's final picture

Juan Tamariz uses this idea when he performs the old Rising Card effect where the selection is on top and you secretly push it up with your forefinger. While the audience is reacting to the rise, he pulls the card the rest of the way out and reinserts it in the middle of the deck. He does it openly, but the audience hardly notices because of their state of mind at that instant. By the time they refocus on the performer, he can show the deck from every angle, the card legitimately sticking out of the middle. That becomes the final picture in the audience's memory. That memory will block anyone from ever penetrating the secret of the effect.

I do a quick poker deal based on an idea shown to me by Roger Klause. I deal a head-up round of draw poker to myself and a spectator. Each of us

clearly receives five cards. But, a moment later, when the spectators look up, I'm holding a large fan of cards. My poker hand has grown to about thirty-five cards.

This impression is partially created by some photo doctoring. I initially add about fifteen cards to my poker hand. (Much more than that would be risky, given the method.) I immediately fan these cards and wait for the spectators to look up at me. When they do, they react with surprise and laughter. I seize on that moment to add another fifteen cards or so to the poker hand and ribbonspread the cards on the table.

The method that I use for the second add-on is bold, but it simply doesn't matter. It happens in the moment that the audience unfocuses in reaction to the initial shock. By the time they refocus, the picture has changed. Of course, they are not conscious of any change in the number of card. However, as they calm down, this stable, clear picture of thirty-five cards is waiting for them. It's the one that gets locked into their minds, replacing the fuzzy image they saw for an instant before being thrown into shock.

This idea of altering the final picture is related to the concept of backed time displacement. However, here the notion is used, not to achieve the effect, but merely to enhance it. Admittedly, opportunities to apply this idea don't come along often. But, you have to be aware of the concept to seize them when they do.

Final Points

Remember that the goal of all ruses, whether incidental, accidental, or extraneous is to make important actions appear unimportant. Ideally, they will appear so unimportant as to keep them from being encoded into long-term memory banks.

If you're unsure whether a particular ploy will do the job, ask yourself whether a layperson recounting the effect to someone else would bother to mention the ruse handling in question. (For example, would he really bother to mention that you had to move a packet of cards out of the way in order to drop a casino chip in its place?) If you're unsure of the answer, perform the effect for a layperson and then ask him to recount what you just did. If he

doesn't bother to mention the ruse handling, you know that you've achieved your goal.

Finally, I want to stress that, as useful as these techniques of psychological invisibility are, I don't think that, by themselves, they're strong enough to form the basis for a powerful effect. Think of them as tools for putting the final polish on an effect that already rests on a sound foundation of time displacement, disguising proximity and correlation, and solid conceptual barriers. These techniques can add a further layer of deception to an already strong method, making it virtually bulletproof.

Afterword

There you have it, the principles that have long guided me in creating, choosing, and routining material for my professional work. Admittedly, its only over time that these ideas have crystallized into their present form. But the clearer and more systematic they became, the more useful they became. That is, after all, what craft is all about. It is the process of raising instinctive knowledge and the lessons of experience to a conscious level so that they can be applied more efficiently and systematically.

Over the years, many magicians have had kind things to say about the effects that I have published. The proof of any theory is whether it works in practice. The material in **Darwin Ortiz at the Card Table**, **Cardshark**, and **Scams Fantasies with Cards** is a good indicator of how well these principles have worked for me.

You can determine if they work for you by seeing whether they help you understand issues of audience reaction that may have puzzled you in the past. If so, the next step is to apply them to help you choose stronger effects to perform and strengthen effects you may already be performing. This means internalizing these concepts in your thinking.

What I've attempted to do in the preceding pages is, in fact, to propose new ways of thinking about magic and offer new tools for understanding how magic works, why it sometimes doesn't, and how to make K work better. These are, of course, tools for thinking, not a substitute for thinking. You won't be able to apply them mechanically. Their use will demand

thought, effort, and creativity on your part. But the rewards can be enormous.

I realize that not every magician aims to give his audience “the feeling of being overwhelmed by something incomprehensible.” I do, however, believe that the most memorable experience that we as magicians can give people is the feeling of seeing something that is not merely amusing but amazing, not merely a puzzle but a miracle, nor merely something that they can't explain but something inexplicable, something extraordinary. If that is your goal. I believe that the way of thinking and the set of tools in this book will help you reach it. Why should either you or your audiences settle for less?

Appendix One: Darwin's Laws

1. How laypeople think is the most important subject in magic.
2. The only thing that matters about a method is how impossible an effect it produces, not how good it makes you feel inside.
3. Magic can only be established by a process of elimination.
4. Eliminate the correct theory before it occurs to them.
5. Get into the habit of thinking in terms of both inner and outer realities at every point in a trick.
6. The more amazing the phenomenon, the more convincing the effect must be.
7. If you can mislead them as to when the effect happened, you'll guarantee they'll never figure out how it happened.
8. If possible, ensure that, by the time the magic happens, the device necessary to make it happen is no longer in sight.
9. One move at the wrong moment may be worse than ten at the right moment.
10. If an effect can be solved simply by the application of logic, the effect is no good.” (Bob Cassidy)
11. The obvious explanation is usually the last one to occur to magicians but the first one to occur to laypeople.
12. Don't reveal to the audience that you possess a piece of information if doing so will put them on the path to the correct method.

13. Laypeople think in terms of direct methods. Therefore, it's precisely the kind of method they're most likely to uncover.
14. If you can get them to ask the wrong question, you'll guarantee that they'll never arrive at the right answer.
15. Don't add a kicker to an effect that would allow the audience to accurately reinterpret what happened previously.
16. The best way to guarantee that the spectator isn't thinking about method when the magic happens is to ensure that he gets all that thinking out of his system before the magic happens.
17. Eliminate suspicion before it forms.
18. It's the *context* you create for the visual element that determines how powerful visual magic will be.
19. The only valid purpose of the visual element in any effect is *to stimulate the audience's imagination*. If it fails to do that, it will foil as magic.
20. It's what comes *before* the visual moment that determines whether that moment registers as a miracle.
21. Repetition produces conviction.
22. In multi-phase effects, strive to combine methods that nullify each other's weaknesses.
23. "Actions that appear necessary but unimportant are only half-noticed and soon forgotten." (Al Baker)
24. "Actions that are unnecessary arouse suspicion." (Al Baker)
25. Make the important seem unimportant and the unimportant seem important.
26. Any generalization about lay audiences that is based on your experiences with magician audiences is likely to be wrong.
27. Any generalization about lay audiences that is based on your own reactions to magic is likely to be wrong.

Appendix Two: Glossary

"It is very often necessary to create a new word or give a more specific meaning to an existing word in order to convey a new concept."

Edward de Bono, **Parallel Thinking**

backward time displacement The stratagem of creating the impression that the *effect* has been completed when, in fact, the *method* has not yet been completed.

causal cue Any element (such as temporal proximity or contiguity) that triggers the audience's instinct to make a causal connection.

convincer any minor action that serves to strengthen the audience's belief that nothing has changed yet.

the critical interval The time between the audience's last view of the initial condition and their first view of the final condition.

dual-track thinking The mindset of simultaneously thinking about how every element impacts both the outer reality and the inner reality.

effect The difference between the initial condition and the final condition.
[Ascanio]

extended magic An effect that creates an impossible condition (e.g., levitation, partial penetration); the magic lasts as long as the condition is maintained.

eye candy Visual magic that has no lasting element of mystery to support the visual moment. (The effect has shock value and may have aesthetic appeal, but evokes no lasting sense of wonder.)

final condition The state of affairs once the magic has happened.

forward time displacement The stratagem of making the effect appear to happen later than it really did.

half-visual formula Using a visual grabber to build anticipation for a non-visual, but deeply mysterious climax.

impossibility quotient The degree to which a magic effect appears to be truly inexplicable.

information barrier. A. conceptual barrier that makes the correct solution to the miracle seem implausible because you apparently didn't have access to the information needed to make that method work.

initial condition The state of affairs before the magic happens.

inner reality The situation as the performer knows it to be.

linear method A method that follows the direct path that the audience would expect it to.

mental set The set of prior beliefs, assumptions, and expectations with which an audience views an effect.

mystery value That aspect of an effect's impact that comes from its impossibility rather than other entertainment values.

“no way” moment The moment the audience realizes what is going to happen and contemplates its impossibility before you actually reveal that it has happened.

outer reality The situation as the audience believes it to be.

physical barrier A conceptual barrier that makes the correct solution to the miracle seem implausible because there was something standing in the way of anything getting from here to there.

psychologically invisible Anything that the eye sees but the mind does not register.

ruse A false motivation provided for a visible action. The audience sees what you do; they're only misled as to *why* you do it.

time displacement device Any methodological technique that allows you to show the initial condition apparently unchanged even after it has been changed.

thematic misdirection Ascanio's concept of providing the audience with something to occupy their thoughts so they won't have a chance to think about some potential weakness of the effect.

time misdirection Interposing a time lapse between method and effect to obscure the causal link.

validating phase In a multi-phase effect, the phase that proves the legitimacy of the other phases by establishing that the magic really does happen at the moment—and in the manner—that you claim.

the veil principle The notion that combining several conceptual barriers may produce an impenetrable mystery even though each barrier, by itself, might be susceptible to a spectator's analysis.

visual effect Magic in which minimal time elapses between the audiences last view of the initial condition and their first view of the final condition. The shorter the interval, the more visual the effect.

visual gag An effect that fools the eye without fooling the mind or that fools the eye and mind initially, but becomes transparent the moment the surprise wears off (e.g., pulling off your thumb).

visual moment The instant the final condition is revealed.

wonder. “The feeling of being overwhelmed by something incomprehensible.” (Dr. Paul Ekman)

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